

Engl 310 The Shakespearean Tragedies

Numbered Transcript

ENGL 310 • Dr. Andrew Doyle

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Lecture 1: The Bard's Beginnings

At a glance — Doyle asks why Shakespeare has never been bettered and sets up the tragedies.

- 1.1 I'm going to start with a question. Why is it that the playwright William Shakespeare has never been bettered? He was writing over a period of roughly 25 years, a little over four centuries ago, at a time when the public theaters were in their infancy. So shouldn't it be the case that writers improve as the years go by, that they learn from their predecessors and improve upon them? We live in a time when many of us seem to have embraced a teleological view of history. In other words, we think that human progress is inevitable. But Shakespeare, I think, is just one example of many that shows to us that, when it comes to the arts, this is a kind of wishful thinking.
- 1.2 In this series of lectures, I'm going to be focusing on Shakespeare's tragedies in particular, because I think they represent the very highest point of his artistry. I want to think about why it is that no other dramatist has come close to his achievements. At the same time, I do want to caution against the oversimplification of Shakespeare, who's become a cultural icon who can basically represent whatever it is that we choose him to represent. And actually, it's the complexities and ambiguities of his plays that I think have ensured his immortality. He understands human beings too well to reduce the world to simple binaries of good versus evil. In other words, he's really not interested in a Disneyfied landscape of heroes and villains.
- 1.3 Now, even those who haven't read any of Shakespeare's tragedies will know that they are concerned with power and with politics. When we hear a commentator in the media using the adjective "Shakespearean," they're usually alluding to some kind of political betrayal or conflict or conspiracy, something like that. But Shakespeare's treatment of these themes has a potency that transcends that of other playwrights. Directors and theater companies and filmmakers have always turned to Shakespeare in order to address contemporary themes and anxieties.
- 1.4 So, in 1944, for instance, you might have seen the film version of *Henry V* by Laurence Olivier, which was a particularly nationalistic version. And this, of course, was when Britain was on the cusp of war. This was a film that was part-funded by the UK government, by Churchill's government of the time. And what Olivier did in that film is that he stripped out lines of dialogue that suggested any kind of moral ambiguity on the part of the English king. So, for instance, when Henry is at Agincourt and he orders that the French prisoners ought to be killed, that does not appear in the film because that would not send the message that Olivier was trying to convey.
- 1.5 To give you another example, in 1937, Orson Welles produced a show which was called *Death of a Dictator*. This was at the Mercury Theater in New York, and this was an adaptation of Shakespeare's *Julius Caesar*. And what Orson Welles was trying to do in that show is he was taking aim at what he perceived to be liberal weakness in the face

of a fascist threat. For this, what he did is he explicitly turned Julius Caesar into Benito Mussolini. He was played by an actor called Joseph Holland, and he included scenes that incorporated Nazi rallies, things like that. Now, if you think that's unsubtle, it does get worse. There was an incredible moment on the sixth of April, 1938, live production. You can imagine it. Orson Welles. He's playing Brutus, by the way, Orson Welles, in the production. So he gets to stab Julius Caesar. Brutus, as you probably know, is the final conspirator to stab Julius Caesar.

- 1.6 Now, Orson Welles was very fussy. He didn't like the fake knives that the other conspirators were using. He didn't think that the lighting effect was particularly good. He wanted to use a real knife. That was his attention to detail. He used a real knife. Every night, he was stabbing at this man, Holland, with an authentic blade. And on this particular production, on sixth of April, 1938, he stabbed Holland through the chest and the arm, live, in front of many hundreds of people. Now, what was interesting about this was that Holland carried on acting, which I find incredible. He said the line, "Et tu, Brute," then for Caesar, having just been stabbed through the chest and arm, fell to the floor. Then they carried on acting for about 15 minutes. Blood was spilling all over the stage. When they did have the blackout at the next scene, then he went to hospital. He almost died.
- 1.7 I would say that is commitment to your art. That's an aside. Now, I just mentioned that because I find it interesting. But my point is that Shakespeare can become a focal point for any kind of political messaging that any particular director wants to choose, but only if the director makes changes to the text that in some way simplifies it, because Shakespeare is too complex. Now, even today, directors are at it all the time. Many of you are probably theatergoers. You're probably very familiar of the phenomenon of opening a theater program, and the director is talking about why this play is relevant right now. This is very, very common. I find it very irritating because I think that any play about human beings is always going to be relevant. I don't need it to be contextualized in that way.
- 1.8 While there are undeniable cultural differences based on time and place, the core aspect of humanity does not change. That's why I think Shakespeare's work resonates across the globe. I would say, beware of critics who simplistically put this down to the legacy of colonialism. But to give a recent example of how Shakespeare in tragedy has been adapted to address contemporary concerns head-on, you might want to think about a production that took place in 2017. This was in Central Park, New York. This was a production of Julius Caesar. You probably read about this. It was widely covered in the press.
- 1.9 What had happened is, the director of this particular production had decided to depict Julius Caesar as Donald Trump. This is a year, of course, after the election of 2016. And so therefore, you have this spectacle of Donald Trump being assassinated in broad daylight on stage. Now, there were lots of complaints about this, debates on television,

articles, general outrage. People were saying this is an example of incitement to violence. But of course, the production company was trying to make a political statement, quite a blunt political statement. But again, it did involve a simplified version of the text in order for that to work. Because in Shakespeare, as I'm going to come to in a later lecture, our perception of Julius Caesar is not at all straightforward. For this production, it had to be straightforward for the attack on Trump to work.

1.10 My point is that Shakespeare is often the go-to writer when it comes to exploring political tensions of any given time. His work is so powerful, it can actually sometimes even galvanize those tensions, rather than just comment on those tensions. Let me give you a specific example of what I'm talking about from a production early in the 20th century. One of the oldest theaters in Paris, the Comédie-Française. It's been around since 1860. Still a working theater. You can still go and see shows there. This was a production in 1934, a production of Shakespeare's *Coriolanus*, one of his Roman tragedies, a late play.

1.11 Now, this production of *Coriolanus* was critically acclaimed, very popular, hugely commercially successful. It was doing really, really well. The show had just been translated into French by a Swiss journalist. It just so happened that this production coincided with an especially intense period of political turmoil in France. At the time, there was a radical left-wing government. It was a Republican government. Members of the cabinet had become embroiled in a scandal because it turns out they'd been protecting a fraudster called Alexandre Stavisky. And his name became well known because this man, Stavisky, had committed suicide.

1.12 Now, at this time in Paris, tensions were running really, really high. And this production of *Coriolanus* became a focal point for the frustrations of the Parisians. Political activists would go along to the show. They would cheer the anti-Republican sentiments that are being expressed within the show. So for instance, when *Coriolanus* is insulting the plebeians, when he's talking about how their breath stinks, when he's attacking the tribunes of the plebs. I'll give you an example. There's these lines from Act 3, Scene 1. *Coriolanus* says, "Your dishonor mangles true judgment, and bereaves the state of that integrity which should become it, not having the power to do the good it would for the ill which doth control it."

1.13 Now, that accusation could well have been leveled against the Prime Minister of the time and his cabinet. That's certainly how it was received by many in the audience. *Coriolanus*, in other words, was articulating their anger against the corruption of the state. And matters came to a head on the 27th of January, 1934. There was a particular production where members of the audience started shouting so loudly that the actors couldn't be heard anymore. You had Republicans in the audience, you had anti-Republicans in the audience, and they were cheering for different lines. They were shouting over each other. Then fights started breaking out in the auditorium, actual fist

fight. One Parisian newspaper at the time called it an indescribable mess, and it didn't stop there.

1.14 So just a couple of weeks later, the havoc, it was still taking place night after night in the theater for this run of *Coriolanus*. And one night, it spilled out onto the streets, and there were riots. Police were called, 15 people were killed, over 1,300 wounded, and all because of a production of *Coriolanus* by William Shakespeare. Now, of course, this show had not been staged in order to ferment civil unrest. But the power of its language and its themes had that effect nonetheless. We might ask ourselves, how can it be that a play written in the early Jacobean period could retain such power that it could almost contribute to the fall of the third French Republic? How could that be?

1.15 Even in Shakespeare's own lifetime, this potency of his drama was well known, the idea that it might inspire political upheaval, rather than just comment on political upheaval. I'll give you an example of this. There's a very specific historical example, which you probably may have heard of. This was in 1601, when Robert Devereux, the Earl of Essex, mounted a rebellion against the council of Queen Elizabeth I. Just before this attempted coup, Devereux commissioned a production of *Richard II*, Shakespeare's play, *Richard II*. He commissioned this at the Globe Theatre. The idea was that he wanted to stir up popular sentiment against the Queen and her council. The reason for that being that, if you know *Richard II*, you will know there is a deposition scene. There is a scene in which the monarch is deposed. That's Act 4, Scene 1. It's why the play was so controversial. When it was published in quarto form at the time, that scene was cut by the Master of the Revels. Elizabeth herself was fully aware of this. So later on, it is said that Elizabeth I remarked, "I am Richard II, know ye not that?"

1.16 And yet, there is a problem with using Shakespeare to stir a particular sentiment because he doesn't write morality plays. We don't know where he stands on any issue whatsoever, really. And this is why, during that ill-fated production of *Coriolanus* in Paris in 1934 that led to these riots, the audience responses were, well, they were very varied. The same text, in other words, seemed to be capable of stirring the Republicans in the audience and also stirring the anti-Republicans in the audience in equal measure. It's almost as though they were watching two entirely different plays. Accounts from the time revealed that these factions of the audience would be cheering and applauding for different lines. They would be shouting opposing political slogans. You had cries of, "Vive la Republique!" On the same night, you would have cries of, "Bravo, Hitler!" which is never something you want to hear.

1.17 But of course, remember, at that time in March, the previous year, the German Parliament had passed the Enabling Act. So Hitler was de facto dictator, and to some in the anti-Republican movement in France, that made him a hero. The point is, you have all these different people with different views, passionately held views, crying out for this play that they felt endorsed their worldview. And why is that? Why is it the case that a play, one single play, can elicit such different responses? Well, you've heard that

phrase, presumably, "The devil can cite scripture for his purpose." Well, you can do the same with Shakespeare. You can find any quotation in Shakespeare to support any particular viewpoint. Shakespeare never reveals his hand. He never takes sides. His unique brilliance, I think, is in representing this multiplicity of characters in a deeply authentic way, almost as though he was capable of seeing the world through multiple perspectives all at the same time.

- 1.18** So were the conspirators in Julius Caesar right to assassinate him? That depends very much on who you ask. Two different audience members will watch that play and they will come away with totally different views on the subject. Coleridge called this the "wonderful impartiality of Shakespeare's politics." And I want you to think about this. I want you to bear this in mind while we're exploring these tragedies over these lectures. Don't think of them as stories with a moral message because you won't find one.
- 1.19** What, after all, is the moral of Macbeth? Don't go around killing kings, right? Maybe. It's good advice. Beware of your own ambition, possibly. So in Macbeth, he is destined to act as he does, but the revelation of his destiny is what prompts him to enact it. In other words, there are other forces at play. Would he have killed Duncan if the witches hadn't told him that he was going to take the throne? At all stages, Macbeth knows that what he is doing is wrong, and yet he does it anyway. Shakespeare shows us what a world without free will might look like, and it is horrific, but it is not a morality play.
- 1.20** So, yes, these plays explore the most powerful emotions and terrible deeds of which humankind is capable. But most importantly, in all the struggles for power, the bloody revenge, the pitfalls of love and hate, Shakespeare is able to explore why human beings behave as they do. Each of his characters, as I say, is totally unique. They seem to think for themselves. They seem to be almost detached from their creator. What did Alexander Pope said? He said, "Every single character in Shakespeare is as much an individual as those in life itself; it is as impossible to find any two alike." This is very rare in writing. This is one of those reasons why I think Shakespeare has never been bettered.
- 1.21** Who else can do this? If you think you might be familiar with Quentin Tarantino, the films of Quentin Tarantino, I'm a bit of a fan, but even if you're a great fan of his, you will notice that all the characters sound like Quentin Tarantino. They all have his inflections. They all have his turns of phrase. Even that 9-year-old character in Once Upon a Time in Hollywood talks like Quentin Tarantino. Now, you're not going to find that in Shakespeare. I mean, yes, to our ears, they all sound vaguely similar insofar as they are speaking in a heightened, poeticized version of the Elizabethan tongue, but they think differently. They are individuals. I would go so far as to say they are autonomous individuals. This is something I want you to bear in mind as we work through these various tragedies.
- 1.22** Shakespeare is interested, above all, in human nature. Kings and queens, for him, are not just abstract figures, pawns in some grand narrative, a story that he can tell. Kings

and queens are men and women with flaws, like the rest of us, subject to the same desires, the same anxieties. So, I want to ask the question, why Shakespeare? Why was Shakespeare able to achieve all of these incredible things? How is it that this middle-class man from a relatively small town of Stratford-upon-Avon achieved such greatness? It's actually a tricky question. I think one of the explanations for the immense achievements of Shakespeare lies in the very specific historical circumstances.

- 1.23** There are all sorts of geniuses who live and die without leaving a legacy, perhaps even without knowing that they had a gift in the first place. There's a really great poem by R.S. Thomas, the Welsh poet, and he's writing about a farmer who spends his whole life just toiling the fields, and he's born into a time and place where that is the only option for this farmer. And so, as Thomas writes, he is merely "contributing grimly to the accepted pattern, the embryo music dead in his throat." And I have no doubt that if Shakespeare had remained in Stratford-upon-Avon, that little town in Warwickshire, his genius would have been wasted. That's not to say he wouldn't have had a fantastic life. He probably would. But we wouldn't be talking about him today. I wouldn't be standing here in front of you today, talking about his work. He may not even have ended up writing anything. If he did, it certainly wouldn't have been preserved.
- 1.24** Now, Shakespeare had, like I say, a middle-class background. His opportunities were fairly limited, but he did have some advantages. He wasn't dirt-poor, that's the first thing. He was able to go to grammar school. That was really, really key. I've actually been to the grammar school that he went to. You can go and see it yourself. It's in Stratford-upon-Avon. It's really, really worth visiting. I once attended a conference in the very room in which Shakespeare was taught. Grammar school, by the way, refers to the Latin grammar of the curriculum of the time. That was the core of the curriculum.
- 1.25** This is really important because his grammar school education gave him the necessary literary grounding for his talent to flourish. He would have encountered all sorts of texts there. Ovid, for instance, would have been a key text. Cicero, that kind of thing. He had this grounding there. The Bible, most importantly. Shakespeare, by the way, had married young. He was 18. He married Anne Hathaway, a woman who was 8 years his senior. This meant that he would have been prohibited from attending university anyway. Remember, there were only two universities at this time, Oxford and Cambridge. You can't go if you're married. You can't enroll.
- 1.26** The likelihood is, we don't know, but the likelihood is that Shakespeare probably encountered visiting theater troupes, traveling theater troupes, that came to Stratford-upon-Avon. It might be that this is how he was recruited into the theater. Maybe he met someone who provided him with a connection. We don't know. But however it did happen, he made that trip to London. At the time, not a short trip. We're talking about 83 miles, about 130 kilometers. He found some kind of employment in the theater. There are various traditions about what it is he did. Some people have him tying up

horses for aristocrats who want to pay for the more expensive seats. We don't really know what he did, but he was employed in the theater.

1.27 Now, I wanted you to try and understand that this would have been quite a culture shock for Shakespeare, coming from a very small town at the time. Obviously, no television, Internet. He doesn't know what the outside world looks like. He goes to London. He goes from a town of 2,500 people suddenly to a huge city, by the standards of the time. If you look at illustrations of London from this time, you can see it's a hub of activity. The old illustrations show that all of the buildings were very tightly arranged. Of course, this is why, when the great fire of London happened in 1666, it all went because you have tightly arranged wooden houses. A very bad idea. Terrible fire hazard. Now, about 200,000 people are living there in London at this time, compared to 2,500 in Stratford. It is, as I say, a culture shock.

1.28 But in terms of Shakespeare's arrival, one of the key points I want to mention is that the timing was absolutely perfect. This was the year 1587. The public theaters in London had only been established for around a decade at this time. They were now flourishing, mostly on the South Bank, but not all. There was one in Shoreditch, for instance. This was mostly because of two theater companies, the two principal theater companies of the time, the Admiral's Men and the Lord Chamberlain's Men. Now what you had was a city's population that had a permanent and an affordable source of entertainment. Early English theater had developed out of the morality plays, this medieval tradition, the mystery circles, the miracle plays. This was a medium that was very entertaining, but it was also, crucially, very didactic. They were written in the vernacular. So this enabled the public who, let's not forget, at the time would not have spoken Latin, all of a sudden, they can see the lives of the saints, the stories from the Bible enacted in front of them.

1.29 But now with the public theaters in London, the open-air theaters, you get a further development. A new kind of theater is emerging. So I take the view that Shakespeare could not have flourished at any other time, in any other year. 1587. Try and lock that year into your head. This is a key year. In relocating to London at that particular moment, he was wading into this dizzying whirlpool of cultural and political forces. It's the year before the Spanish Armada; the war with imperial Spain is at its most intense. The capital is gripped in a patriotic fervor. There are rumors of attempts on the life of Queen Elizabeth I, most famously the Babington plot of 1586, which resulted in the execution of Mary, Queen of Scots, and that had led to this upsurge among the public of a patriotic belief, a love and enthusiasm for the monarch at the time.

1.30 That's important for Shakespeare because, of course, remember, a lot of his early plays were based on the history of England. His history cycle of 10 plays takes us all the way through from King John right up to Henry VIII. And all of those, except for Henry VIII, were written before the end of the 16th century. Of course, he couldn't write Henry VIII while Queen Elizabeth was alive. That was her father. He couldn't do that.

- 1.31** At the same time, the foremost writers were preoccupied with the foundation of a national literature. The English tongue was rapidly evolving, so the language of Chaucer was now obsolete. But at the time, remember that writers, those who considered themselves to be literary figures, would have written in Greek and Latin. Those were the literary languages of the poets. This case for English poetry, English poetry in the vernacular, is put forward very forcefully in a text by George Puttenham called *The Arte of English Poesie*. That's from 1589. It was proven right. We ended up with masterpieces such as *The Faerie Queene*, the great epic poem by Edmund Spenser, Philip Sidney's great piece, *The Arcadia*, which is like a novel. It's mostly written in prose. It's interspersed with poetic elements.
- 1.32** The stage, the theater, was not considered to be high art at all. That happened much later. Even while Shakespeare is writing and being very, very successful, it isn't considered this great artistic endeavor. And yet, at this time, the theater is changing. The plays are changing. And there's one major reason for this. Remember, we're still in 1587. There's a group of writers called the University Wits. They were known as the University Wits. They were injecting something new into theater. They were educated at Oxford or Cambridge. We're talking about people like Christopher Marlowe, Robert Greene, John Lyly, George Peele, Thomas Nashe, and so on. These were the most popular playwrights of the time. Thomas Kyd is another one. He's often considered one of the University Wits, although he didn't actually go to university. But the point is that they were changing theater. They were making it more learned, more artistic, high-brow, I suppose we would call it.
- 1.33** Now, for an aspiring writer, these conditions couldn't have been more favorable. In order for Shakespeare to compete with these lettered peers, he couldn't rely on hackwork. That couldn't be done anymore. He couldn't rely on the run-of-the-mill potboilers that were a common feature of the revels of the Inns of Court at the time. So for the first time, there was a necessary collision of literary sensibilities and popular taste. And another key point, because of these developments, because of the nature of the theater, because of the influence of the University Wits, you suddenly have in the theaters an immense cross-section of society. And that's a unique moment in the theater. It has never been repeated. If you go to the theater now, yes, sure, there are some cheap seats. On the whole, we all know that theater is expensive. We all know that the majority of audience members are middle-class.
- 1.34** You don't get that cross-section that occurred in Shakespeare's day. We have eye-wateringly extortionate ticket prices. Now, it's considered a bit of an elitist pastime. But in Shakespeare's day, at theaters, like the Swan, on the South Bank, there there was this kaleidoscope of rich and poor. Now, if you look at the layout of the theaters at the time—and these are new theaters, remember, they've only been established about a decade—you can really get the sense of what this experience would have been like. It's really good to look at the old illustrations.

- 1.35** The best way, actually, is to go and see the Globe Theatre. In London, there is the Globe Theatre. It was built, I can't remember when, late '90s, I think. It was a reconstruction of the actual Globe Theatre, about 200 meters away from the original site. They were really trying their best to replicate what the experience would have been like. The design is exactly the same. Unfortunately, the Globe isn't putting on any good shows at the moment because it is in the grip of this strange identitarian ideology that seems to have gone absolutely everywhere. So, the Globe Theatre, definitely worth a visit. The plays will be bad, the productions will be bad at the moment, but we might get a better artistic director in the future. Fingers crossed.
- 1.36** Now, there's only one image of a London theater from Shakespeare's lifetime that survives. We're very lucky to have it. This is an image of the Swan Theatre. Now, all of the theaters followed the same basic design. They were all based on the Roman amphitheater design. This one was built, the Swan, was built in 1574. A Dutch student at the time called Johannes de Witt, attended a play there in 1596, and he actually sketched what he saw. Now, that would have probably been lost, except that a friend of his then copied the sketch and put it into his diary, and it was therefore preserved. Please do look at this illustration if you get the chance.
- 1.37** If you look at it, you can very clearly see the layout of the Swan Theater, and you can see how it worked in terms of this intimate combination of rich people and poor people. You have the very affluent people who are paying 6 pence to sit in the galleries. If you've been to the Globe, you'll know what I mean, the things around the walls. Then you have the groundlings. These are the poorer people who pay just a penny, and they stand in the yard. They actually have the best view. It's still the case today in the Globe. You pay a very small price and you can stand and watch the productions. I think we can scarce imagine the raucousness of this outdoor spectacle. Open-air theater. If it rains, you get wet. The jeers, the cheers, the braying heckles of drunks, rich and poor, all in the same space.
- 1.38** And outside, there are bears being baited. Bear-baiting was a common theatrical practice. You chain a bear to a stake and you taunt it with dogs. Very, very cruel. In *The Winter's Tale*, there's that famous stage direction, "Exit pursued by a bear." It was probably a real bear. All of this going on. People getting drunk, prostitutes plying their trade. This is why the Puritans hated the theater of the time. They saw all this as just a den of vice, and the Puritans eventually got the theaters closed down. That was in 1642, thankfully, after Shakespeare had died, but they hated it. And of course, it didn't help matters that there were no women on the stage, because although female actors would have been considered whores, the fact that you've got boy actors playing female love interests is a problem for the Puritans, because inevitably, you get that specter of homosexual desire.
- 1.39** Now, I want to draw your attention to another aspect of these theaters, and it's particularly relevant for what we're going to be talking about through these lectures in

terms of tragedy, and that is the sheer versatility of the space. So the stage was very large, about 40 feet across, and it's surrounded on three sides by the audience. It's almost like being in the round. On a stage of that magnitude, you can stage battle scenes. The scale can be really epic. In the early scenes of *Coriolanus*, for example, you've got the battle scenes there, or the late civil war scenes in *Julius Caesar*, or Macduff's assault on Dunsinane Castle in *Macbeth*. All of these things can be shown in incredible detail. Now, of course, they probably wouldn't have had more than roughly 10 actors on stage at any given time. But these actors were actually fighting with swords, real swords, a bit like Orson Welles with his real blade. Creates excitement. The audience are right up there, close to the action. They're experiencing it. They get flecked by the sweat of these brawling actors. Very exhilarating stuff. Must have been pretty intense.

1.40 There's no complex scenery at this time. The sound effects are not particularly sophisticated, so the audience has to use their imaginations, and that's a good thing. Remember, also, we're outdoor. A lot of the plays are predominantly set at night. So it stimulates the imagination. It's why, of course, so many of the descriptions in Shakespeare are so vivid in the language, I mean. We have all these incredibly beautiful passages because Shakespeare has to paint a picture using words for the audience. There's an example which I really love from *The Tempest*, which is this short speech by Caliban. Caliban says, "Be not afeared. The isle is full of noises, sounds, and sweet airs that give delight and hurt not. Sometimes a thousand twangling instruments will hum about mine ears, and sometimes voices that if I had waked after long sleep will make me sleep again; and then in dreaming, the clouds methought would open and show riches ready to drop upon me, that when I waked, I cried to dream again."

1.41 It's an incredible piece of writing. It's all the more startling because, of course, Caliban is one of Shakespeare's most physically grotesque figures. One of the things I hope you get from these lectures is that Shakespeare is continually defying our expectations. Anyway, so let's go back to the theater. As I say, the theaters of the time on the South Bank, incredible potential for these epic scenes. Great for tragedy, the sheer breadth of the stage, the trap door going down to the lower part known as the Hell, the painted canopy at the top, painted with stars that was known as the Heavens, which is by the Minstrel's Gallery. You've got great versatility here.

1.42 At the same time, there is the potential for intimacy, which seems the exact opposite. But no one in this theater is more than 40 feet away from the action. It doesn't matter where you sit. I mean, I've sat at the very top of the Globe Theatre, and it still feels like the actors are very, very near. This is important for Shakespeare because one of Shakespeare's major innovations is the soliloquies, which is one person on stage sharing his inner thoughts with the audience. They're the key to the success of the tragedies. The soliloquies aren't simply a character providing exposition. In other words, they're not simply someone just telling you what his plans are. There's a bit of

that in Richard III. But later in the play, the soliloquies start to show the king wrestling with his own thoughts, his own nature. These soliloquies, this is what we see throughout Hamlet, throughout Macbeth.

1.43 Like I said, these are plays about human beings. This is why they've never stopped being relevant. The soliloquies are key. This is the first time we really have an insight into the mind of the protagonists of these plays. On a stage like this, you could feel like it's just you and the actor delivering the soliloquy — intimacy as well as epic scale. It's very, very important. Hasn't been repeated. Modern theaters, with the typical proscenium arch style, you don't get that effect. The theater scene in London in the late Elizabethan period, 1587, remember the date, you got this ultimate fusion of high and low culture. You had the democratization of great art blazing for a few precious decades before being extinguished for good. We haven't had it since. Were it not for the high mortality rates and the casual murders on the streets and the repugnant general hygiene, you would almost want to be there. You'd almost want to exchange places with them. I envy these people.

1.44 OK, 1587. Shakespeare arrives in London. You have the new public theater scene with its exceptional theater design. You have writers from the universities injecting literary qualities into public entertainment. This is now an art form, in other words, but one that is enjoyed by this huge cross-section, this socioeconomic cross-section of society. You have a thirst for national pride at the same time, as developed through works of literature, through works of art, and, above all, you have a monarch on the throne who really loves the theater. Really important. Queen Elizabeth I was a huge champion of the theater. The Queen's Company, which was formed in 1583, were commissioned for performances at court and London theaters and regional tours. I would say that, if it weren't for Queen Elizabeth I and her patronage of the theater, this nascent theatrical scene would have been stillborn. And into all of this, into this concatenation of circumstances, comes this unique individual, this mind, this genius from Stratford-upon-Avon. The stars have aligned.

1.45 1587 is also really important because it was the publication of the second edition of a historical work by Raphael Holinshed, Holinshed's Chronicles. This second edition is the version that Shakespeare was going to use. He plundered this book for so many of his historical plot lines. Shakespeare was a magpie. I want you to remember this as well. Shakespeare borrowed from all sorts of sources. He was a voracious reader. This is something that's often overlooked. He read a lot. He didn't go to university, but because of that grammar school education, he knew the texts, the Ovid, the Cicero, etc. He knew the Roman plays of Terence. He knew all of this stuff, and he knew where to find these books as well. So university wasn't all that necessary, really. I mean, Ben Jonson didn't go to university, for instance. He was considered one of the most renowned scholars of the time.

- 1.46 The Bible, by the way, absolutely key for Shakespeare's work. The Bible at this time underpins popular culture. So it's a really good shortcut, a heuristic. You can drop a reference to the Bible and you know that everyone is going to get it straight away. So if you want to develop a decent understanding of Shakespeare, you should familiarize yourself with the Bible. Hopefully, you know a bit about it already. But the breadth of Shakespeare's reading, both historical and literary, is very much evident from the sheer range of allusions in his works. Now, today, we might think of that as a form of plagiarism. If you steal someone else's story, you get sued, don't you? It wasn't the case back then. Shakespeare's innovations emerged because of his peerless mastery of language. He has a vocabulary far in excess of any of his contemporaries or any writer since, for that matter.
- 1.47 It's the psychological complexity of his characters, his near-flawless dramatic and comedic instincts, and his insights into human nature. Not the plots. He wasn't interested in plots. He rarely invented plots. He did it a few times. *Midsummer Night's Dream*, for instance, *Love's Labour's Lost*, *The Tempest*, those are exceptions. *Titus Andronicus*, generally an original plot, although it takes its subplot from Ovid. Shakespeare generally scoured history and literature for the stories that appealed to him, for the stories that would enable him to explore the human condition. The best way to think of it is that the plot lines are like skeletons on which he could apply the flesh of his artistic vision. His interest in plots basically extended to how far they might serve the execution of his artistic aims.
- 1.48 And with Holinshed's *Chronicles*, the second edition, this book, 1587, the year that he arrived, he found this extensive wellspring to sustain his imagination, featuring detailed accounts, detailed historical accounts of events, that may have been overlooked in his grammar school education. In terms of his writing for the stage, it should be pointed out, with Shakespeare, that comedy seemed to come far more naturally to him than tragedy. His earliest comedy is *The Comedy of Errors*. *Taming of the Shrew* is another early comedy. These work just brilliantly, straight off the bat. He gets it absolutely right. His earliest tragedy, by contrast, is *Titus Andronicus*. And although *Titus Andronicus* was hugely successful, it isn't quite as artistically satisfactory as the later tragedies. Actually, it doesn't really come close to the great tragedies of the Jacobean period. Even *Romeo and Juliet*, which is another early tragedy, and it is a masterpiece, it doesn't quite reach those heights.
- 1.49 Now, another thing to always remember is that Shakespeare did not start out as a writer. This is very, very important and often forgotten. Shakespeare was an actor before he became a writer, and actually he remained an actor throughout his writing career. Because he started this way, there was actually some resentment because of his success. Now, we've got some secure evidence of this from the writer Robert Greene, one of the University Wits that I mentioned. He had a reputation as being this bitter, self-indulgent, drunken, lecherous man. I don't know how fair that reputation is.

And he wrote a text called *A Groats-Worth of Wit, Bought With a Million of Repentance*. This book was published actually after Robert Greene died, so we don't know for sure that he wrote all of it. But it does constitute the first recorded remarks about Shakespeare's involvement in the theater. This is from 1592.

1.50 So Robert Greene says the following. He says, "There is an upstart crow, beautified with our feathers, that with a tiger's heart wrapped in a player's hide, supposes he is as well able to bombast out a blank verse as the best of you; and being an absolute *Johannes fac totum*," Jack of all trades, "is in his own conceit the only Shake-scene in a country." So he's definitely talking about Shakespeare here. The phrase "tiger's heart wrapped in a player's hide," which is suggesting that Shakespeare has this dark, malevolent heart, but he's an actor—that's a variation from a line in Shakespeare's play, *Henry VI, Part 3*, which has the line, "O tiger's heart, wrapt in a woman's hide." This is a direct allusion. And of course, the phrase "Shake-scene," it's hardly subtle.

1.51 But basically, it's a complaint that this actor, this upstart crow, has started to write plays and that they are successful. The public loves them. He is, as Greene says, "beautified with our feathers." He's stealing from us. He's taking our feathers. He's making himself beautiful with our feathers. Shakespeare, as I say, is a magpie. I've said this. In fact, there might be a little dig at Robert Greene in *Hamlet*. There's the scene when Polonius is reading out loud a letter from Hamlet to Ophelia, and he says, "To the celestial and my soul's idol, the most beautified Ophelia." Then Polonius stops and says to himself, "That's an ill phrase, a vile phrase, 'beautified' is a vile phrase." I think it's very likely that's a dig at Robert Greene. He didn't let it go, clearly. It's such a curious and specific term, isn't it? It must be a reference.

1.52 But by the way, I should note, because one of my supervisors, when I was studying for my doctorate, Katherine Duncan-Jones, she was convinced that Robert Greene did not write this. She said this was common trick at the time, that when someone had died, you could publish a text and attack whoever you wanted and blame it on the dead man. She actually thought it was Thomas Nashe who wrote this, which is pretty likely. He was pretty caustic. Anyway, it doesn't matter. Whoever it was, it's absolutely clear what we do know, is that Shakespeare's contemporaries had a bit of a beef with Shakespeare. They didn't like the idea of someone who wasn't university-educated making such incredible headway in the theater when, after all, he's an actor, the lowest of the low.

1.53 Now, what I'm going to do before I finish is, I'm just going to fast forward to the end of Shakespeare's life, actually seven years after his death. So he died in 1616. In 1623, you have the production of a book, a massive book called *The First Folio*. This is what it's become known as. Now, there are 38 extant plays by Shakespeare. There are at least two others that we know about that we have lost entirely. One is called *Cardenio*, the other one is called *Love's Labour's Won*, probably a sequel to *Love's Labour's Lost*. There are references to these plays elsewhere, but we don't have them. It's very frustrating.

- 1.54 The reason is, we don't have most plays that were written during this period. During his lifetime, plays were generally published in what they call quarto editions. Now, quarto is created by folding a printed sheet twice over, so you end up with eight pages. They're like little comic books. That's roughly the size of a little comic book. They used to cost 6 pence. Some of these survived better than others. For instance, *Venus and Adonis*, which is Shakespeare's great narrative poem, very popular. Very, very popular. It went through 15 editions before 1640, but not many survived because they were so well-thumbed. These quartos, these little quartos, tended to fall apart very, very easily.
- 1.55 Now, during Shakespeare's lifetime, only 18 of those 38 plays were published in quarto form, just 18. So where are the other 20? We would not have any of the other 20 if it weren't for the publication of this book, *The First Folio*. And it only happened because two of Shakespeare's contemporaries, two actors, John Heminges and Henry Condell, decided that they would put this together. They wanted to put this together to preserve Shakespeare's work for posterity. It was an expensive business. It was hard work collating all the documents and the manuscripts, but they did it, and it was published as *Mr. William Shakespeare's Comedies, Histories, and Tragedies*. There were about 1,000 printed, about 230 survive. They are incredibly valuable.
- 1.56 I've seen one in the flesh. I've been lucky enough to see one. There's one in the basement at Wadham College. When I was studying there, one of my supervisors, Robin Robbins, took me down into the basement, and I was able to browse through an original *First Folio*. He wasn't meant to do that, by the way, so perhaps I shouldn't have mentioned that, but it was a great privilege. They really worked hard on it because they wanted the best versions of the plays to survive. They used Shakespeare's manuscripts. Shakespeare's manuscripts, we call them his foul papers. That's the phrase that we use, the foul papers. None of those survive now, none. But they were used for the production of the *Folio*.
- 1.57 If you think about that, it's quite alarming. If you think about the plays that we might have lost, right? Some of the plays that I'm going to be talking about in these lectures, gone. *Julius Caesar*, gone. *Antony and Cleopatra*, *Macbeth*, all gone. This, by the way, was the first of its kind. The *First Folio* was the first kind of book. There hadn't been a folio edition. These are bigger books, a folio, right? You just fold the paper once. Big, bound books. There hadn't been any of these dedicated just to playwrights, because playwrights, as I said earlier, weren't an example of high art. Ben Jonson published — Ben Jonson, by the way, a very arrogant man, and he wanted to see through, he wanted to preserve his own work, so he published his own folio, but that also included poems and prose. That was in 1616.
- 1.58 Shakespeare's *Folio* was the first of its kind dedicated solely to drama. This is important, not just because it preserved these masterpieces, but because they clearly regarded these works as literary, as worthy of preservation. This is really key because Shakespeare was not, at this point, the bard. He wasn't considered in the way that we

consider him. That didn't happen for a long time. But the Folio was the start of this thing that changed that perception of Shakespeare.

1.59 I would like you to draw your attention. In the First Folio, there is an image of Shakespeare, and this is really important. It's on the frontispiece of the book. This image is probably the closest to the reality. It's why we know what he looked like. It was an engraving by Martin Droeshout. I hope I pronounced that right. He was only 22 when he did this engraving. We don't think that he ever met Shakespeare, but the portrait will have been based on a likeness which would have been provided for him, probably by Heminges and Condell, maybe by Ben Jonson, who was also involved in the production of the Folio. So the people who knew Shakespeare best would have provided the image, and therefore, they would have wanted it to be accurate. Therefore, we can assume that this image, the famous image, with the rough and the bald head, that's Shakespeare. That's what he looked like.

1.60 And it's very similar as well, if you go to where Shakespeare is buried. He's not buried in Westminster Abbey, by the way. You would assume he would be, but he's not. There is a monument to him there. He's actually buried in his hometown of Stratford-upon-Avon in a delightful little church called Holy Trinity Church. You can go and visit it. It's always empty. You can just step in. Shakespeare's grave is there. It's really worth seeing. On the wall, there's a monument to Shakespeare, a bust, which was sculpted by a man called Gerard Jonson. Although recently, some people have said it might have been Jonson's brother. This is on the north wall of the chancel. It's probably, again, an image that would have been commissioned by maybe Shakespeare himself, certainly his wife, certainly the people who knew him best, so it is likely to be accurate. Mark Twain once described this bust as having "the deep, deep, deep, subtle, subtle, subtle expression of a bladder." That's Mark Twain for you. John Dover Wilson said it had "the look of a self-satisfied pork butcher." But that's what he looked like, so be it.

1.61 Let's just go back to the Folio. There are also two pages in the Folio that I want to draw your attention to, in particular. Firstly, there is a list of actors in Shakespeare's Company. Very interesting for us. The Folio is a fascinating document because the compositors who worked on it, the men who put it together, often made little mistakes here and there. There's a couple of moments in the Folio where they accidentally put the name of the actor rather than the character. So, in *Much Ado About Nothing*, for instance, when Dogberry enters at one point, it says, "Enter Kemp." William Kemp played Dogberry. We know who played who. Every now and then, there's little fascinating details. It's really worth having a look at.

1.62 But this list of actors tells us a great deal. It mentions Richard Burbage, for instance, who was the first person to play the great tragic heroes Hamlet, Othello, Macbeth, King Lear. William Kemp is in the list, the great comic actor. He famously danced all the way from London to Norwich. Rather strange character. Heminges and Condell are there themselves, the people who put together the First Folio. But the first name on the list

of actors is William Shakespeare. Now, of course, this is his book. They're going to try and dignify him in a certain way, but he was a renowned actor. With the only roles we know he played are the ghost in Hamlet and Adam in As You Like It, but he probably played a whole lot more.

1.63 I know the critic Harold Bloom was convinced that he wasn't a bit part actor, that he would have played major roles. It's important to remember that he was an actor. I think if you didn't know that he was an actor, in reading the plays, you would get the sense that he is, because he has a sense of how the lines are to be delivered. He's thinking in those terms when he writes. It improves the work, I think, to have come from the acting background.

1.64 The other reason why the First Folio is really important is because it helps us to understand genre, our consideration of the tragedies, because there's also a contents page. Remember that this book is entitled Mr. William Shakespeare's Comedies, Histories, and Tragedies. For the first time, Shakespeare's plays are divided into these three genres. Now, the plays, as listed, are not in any particular order. The Tempest comes first, probably because it was the most recent, or at least one of the newer plays. Troilus and Cressida is in the Folio, but it's not on the contents page. It's an imperfect art. But crucially, you see this division—comedies, histories, and tragedies. But these are not straightforward designations. We might assume that a comedy makes people laugh. We might assume that a tragedy ends in death, that a history delves into the stories of the past. All very straightforward. That is true as it happens.

1.65 But renaissance conceptualizations of genre differ from ours, and Shakespeare did not stick to any rules. So for instance, a purist in Shakespeare's time would have said that plays featuring clowns couldn't be classified as tragedies. And yet, I mean, look, Shakespeare has plenty of clowns in his comedies. He has Feste in Twelfth Night, he has Touchstone in As You Like It, but there are also clowns in Hamlet, the clowns that appear as the gravediggers. There's a clown in Othello. People often forget about him. There's a clown in Titus Andronicus, and of course, the fool in King Lear, an absolute key character. And this is just one example of how Shakespeare enjoys blending the genres.

1.66 I mean, we might think of Twelfth Night as a comedy in its purest sense, but what about the treatment of Malvolio? I've always really warmed to Malvolio. I know he's a snob and a prig, and we're meant to despise him, but I feel sorry for him, right? The trick that they play on him is genuinely cruel. It's a form of psychological torture that almost drives him to despair. I mean, so what that he wants to marry Olivia and become Count Malvolio? What's wrong with a bit of harmless vanity? I think it's very unfair. And of course, at the end, he leaves swearing revenge. "I'll be revenged on the whole pack of you." So, is that comedic? I mean, we get to the end of Twelfth Night and think, well, we get an uncomfortable sense at the end. Things haven't been resolved.

- 1.67** Blending of genre, really, really important when we're talking about tragedy. Polonius, when he talks to the actors. You remember when the players turn up at Elsinore, and Polonius says, "The best actors in the world, either for tragedy, comedy, history, pastoral, pastoral-comical, historical-pastoral, tragical-historical, tragical-comical-historical-pastoral, scene indivisible, or poem unlimited." Lots of critics, by the way, have pointed out that that phrase, that compound "tragical-comical-historical-pastoral," could well apply to Cymbeline, Shakespeare's Cymbeline. But on the contents page of the Folio, Cymbeline is firmly there in the tragedy category. So whatever you think about genre, it's really important to understand that Shakespeare's plays don't fit neatly into any particular categories, and they never did.
- 1.68** Richard III is based on a historical figure, but isn't that also a tragedy? I mean, it was published as such. When it was published in quarto edition, it was published as *The Tragedy of King Richard III*. I'm going to be talking about Julius Caesar. But is that a tragedy, or is it a history? Published as a tragedy. Well, you could say that Coriolanus, that's another history play. It's based on Plutarch, just like Julius Caesar. But Coriolanus is listed as a tragedy in the Folio. Perhaps it might be helpful to look at what a contemporary of Shakespeare made of these genres. In 1598, there appeared a book called *Palladis Tamia: Wits Treasury*, by a man called Francis Meres. This book has been very valuable when it comes to dating Shakespeare's plays, because Meres mentions so many of Shakespeare's plays. Remember, 1598.
- 1.69** This is what he says. He says, "As Plautus and Seneca are accounted the best for comedy and tragedy among the Latins, so Shakespeare, among the English, is the most excellent in both kinds for the stage. For comedy, witness his *Gentleman of Verona*, his *Errors*," as in *Comedy of Errors*," his *Love's Labour's Lost*, his *Love's Labour's Won*." There's that reference to that missing play. "His *Midsummer Night's Dream* and his *Merchant of Venice*." Again, his *Merchant of Venice*, really a comedy? The treatment of Shylock seems pretty unfair to me. The forced conversion at the end.
- 1.70** Meres continues. He says, "For tragedy, his *Richard II*, *Richard III*, *Henry IV*, *King John*, *Titus Andronicus*, and *Romeo and Juliet*." It's quite clear that, for Meres, who was just a year younger than Shakespeare, he drew no distinction between history and tragedy. However, since the publication of the Folio, critics have generally followed this idea that we should divide Shakespeare's plays into these three categories. You might also add the category of the late romances. That's the *Tempest*, *Pericles*, *Cymbeline*, *The Winter's Tale*, *The Two Noble Kinsmen*. Critics have another category, too, called the problem play. This is where nothing quite fits into any category, so they call it a problem play. We're talking about *Measure for Measure*, *All's Well That Ends Well*, *Troilus and Cressida*.
- 1.71** And *Troilus and Cressida* is an excellent example of a play that just doesn't fit anywhere. It doesn't fit in any genre. It's not even on the contents page, as I said, of the Folio. It's satirical, it's bleak, it's iconoclastic, it's pessimistic, it's even petulant, I would

say. It opens with a prologue by a man, a provocatively armed man, who stands there in front of the audience and says, "Like or find fault. Do as your pleasures are." In other words, Shakespeare is saying, "I don't care if you like this play. I'm not interested. Your opinion is of no importance to me." It's a really startling opening, and it really sets the tone for this very sour, bitter play, *Troilus and Cressida*, with Helen of Troy. I mean, what is Helen of Troy? She was known as "the face that launched a thousand ships." That's Marlowe's phrase. But in Shakespeare's *Troilus and Cressida*, she's an airhead. She's a whore.

- 1.72** Then you've got Thersites, a comic character. Sour, unpleasant. *Troilus and Cressida* themselves. They're not dead by the end of the play. Well, shouldn't they be dead? It's a tragedy. That's a prerequisite, right? It really does transcend genre in a way that makes purists really, really uncomfortable. Problem plays, in other words, are basically plays where the resolution is unsatisfactory. But for this series of lectures, I'm going to be focusing on Shakespeare's major tragedies, and I'm hoping that, by the end, you'll be able to answer the question that I posed at the start of the lecture. Why have his works never been surpassed?
- 1.73** It's become unfashionable to say that Shakespeare is timeless or universal. It's associated with that school of criticism known as liberal humanism, in which morality and esthetics are often intertwined. But there's a truth to it. Shakespeare's younger friend and rival, Ben Jonson, wrote that Shakespeare was "not of an age, but for all time." And given that I'm standing here talking to you now about a writer who's been dead since 1616, I think it's safe to say that Jonson has been proved right.
- 1.74** Thank you very much. I would like now to take any questions that you may have.
- 1.75** Good morning. My question relates to the idea that you said at the start of the — I suppose there's an ambivalence to Shakespearean characters and a depth of feeling and understanding in these characters, I think only matched by Dostoevsky and some of his characters. But we see today, we see characters that are very straightforward and narrow in their progression. You understand the character, you understand who the hero is, and that has been lost in modern writing, that I find some of today's characters are just so, they're so base. There's no depth to characters nowadays, which I think is what made Shakespeare so powerful. Why do you think that has happened in modern-day writing? Even to the, I suppose, the upsurge in the late 19th century in the English revival then, the character is a little bit more fresher, but there's no depth to characters that we've seen with Shakespeare. Every single character in Shakespeare has an ambivalence and a depth of understanding that we haven't seen. I would say the only match of that is the Dostoevskyan characters. Why do you think that is?
- 1.76** It's a really interesting question, and I wish I knew the answer. What I would say is, the first thing I would say is that Shakespeare was uncommon for his time. So the fact that Shakespeare had this ability to create that depth and profundity in his characterization wasn't matched by the other playwrights that I've been talking about. He was unusual

even for his time. Every now and then, the world throws up a genius. But I'd also say, I think you're absolutely right, that we are lacking that now. But I think there's something really fascinating, which is that it seems to be that any particular medium or art form appears, and it reaches a zenith quite early on in its development and then seems to collapse. If you think about the novel form, you mentioned Dostoevsky. There's a high point of novelistic writing which hasn't been matched since. I, generally, if I want to read a good novel, will make sure that it was written before I was born. There are some exceptions to this, Salman Rushdie, Kazuo Ishiguro, people like that, who I love. But on the whole, novels were just better 100 years ago. Why is that?

1.77 Theater, as well. I was talking about Shakespeare. That's the early years of the public theaters. You get this high point, and then it dwindles. Poetry, you could say exactly the same. Music. Haven't we seen a decline in music quite palpably? There's something interesting about the development of new art forms. Maybe we'll come up with something new, thanks to the Internet, thanks to AI. God, I hope not. But ultimately, maybe the same thing will happen. Maybe this is just a phenomenon that recurs time and again. I don't know, but I absolutely agree with you.

1.78 There's also a laziness, I think, with storytelling now, with the creation of character. Maybe it's to do with Hollywood. There's a very mechanistic approach to the creation of story. When we watch Hollywood films, we can often predict what's going to happen, can't we? We often have the good guys winning and the bad guys getting their just deserts. They're very formulaic. When you have that formulaic, almost writing-by-committee thing, then there's no real room for genius to flourish. I even think in terms of the development of televisual drama. The Singing Detective by Dennis Potter is the best television drama that has ever been written. It would never be written again because it would never be commissioned again. Who's going to take the risk to have something so layered and difficult and profound and unusual and bizarre and eccentric? Who's going to do that? You take that to the BBC, they're going to laugh at you.

1.79 It's partly, I think, to do with the conditions of writers today. Insofar as Dostoevsky had complete artistic freedom, but you take a Dostoevsky or the equivalent to a publisher today, and they'll be giving it to a sensitivity reader to check that it doesn't hurt anyone's feelings. You don't have the same conditions. Shakespeare, for whatever reason, I think it might be because he had an early success with Titus Andronicus, it almost gave him the freedom to choose. He has that artistic freedom that is absolutely essential for the manifestation of genius. I don't think we have that anymore.

1.80 Thank you, Andrew. You talked about the ambiguity of Shakespeare, but also and the importance of understanding the Bible to understand Shakespeare. Could you not say that there's also an ambiguity in understanding the Bible, just like the Puritans? Do you think it's important to understand the Bible from the same perspective that Shakespeare understood the Bible? There's a lot of speculation that he was a Catholic.

- 1.81** There is some speculation that he was a Catholic. There are those things called the Lost Years, where we don't know where he was or what he was doing. Some people think he was indulging in some Catholic sensibility then. The absolute truth is, we don't know about his religious affiliation at all, in the same way that we don't really know about anyone's religious affiliation at the time. Even someone like Christopher Marlowe, who we think of as an atheist—he was accused of being an atheist, but we don't know for certain. In terms of the type of Bible that he would have used, the Geneva Bible was the common one at the time, which, of course, is Calvinist. I suppose, and a lot of the allusions, a lot of the phrases that appear in Shakespeare, come from that.
- 1.82** All I can say to you is we don't really know what Shakespeare felt about religion, about God. He could have been a devout believer. He could have been a complete atheist. His father got in trouble for not turning up to church, but that was probably because he might meet the people that he owed money to, so he was scared of that. That was the likely reason for that. So we don't know. But what we do know is that those allusions and references from the Bible recur with incredible frequency in his work. That's what we do know. So while we don't know what his beliefs were, we do understand the importance of the Biblical imagery, because as I say, there are three references to Cain and Abel, the story of Cain and Abel, in Hamlet.
- 1.83** Shakespeare didn't have to explain the significance of Cain and Abel. He doesn't have to explain the comparison of Claudius with Cain because everyone already knew. Everyone already understood. There's a guy who killed his brother. But today you have to explain it a little bit. I can't assume that everyone knows what we're talking about. That's why I made that point that the Bible was popular culture. Just everyone believed it. Really, really important. Actually, it's a very interesting time for religion because there had been religious turmoil, exactly what you say. Catholics wouldn't have been very popular at this time because of the war with imperial Spain. There was always this fear that the Catholics, the Spanish, were going to come in through the back door, through Ireland. They were going to land there and they were going to come over.
- 1.84** Not without cause, by the way. That fear was legitimate. Spain actually wanted to do this. Of course, you've also got the Gunpowder Plot, as well. It's a Catholic plot against a Protestant king in 1605. These religious tensions are very high, and this is a country that has been in flux, anyway, since Henry VIII and the Reformation. It went from being a Catholic country. Henry VIII, by the way, was a staunch Catholic. He was defender of the faith. He was horrified by the notion of being excommunicated. He was a Catholic. Then you go into the Reformation, you have the establishment of a Church of England, and then it goes back again, with Mary, and then it goes back again, with Elizabeth. It's all over the place. So religion is really, really important at this time, and the Bible is particularly important at this time.
- 1.85** What I would advise is, when you're reading the plays, if there is an allusion to a Biblical event or something that you're not particularly familiar with, it's always just worth

going to read the story. And I'd say that for any allusion within Shakespeare. Just having some grasp of what he's getting at when he mentions these things is really, really helpful.

Lecture 2: Hamlet's Haunting

At a glance — Hamlet — the most written-about work of stage drama.

- 2.1 Hamlet can often seem like a daunting prospect. No work of stage drama has been more widely read, written about, performed, analyzed. If there's a better play in existence, I certainly haven't read it. Hamlet, in other words, represents, possibly, the ultimate human literary achievement. So naturally, we're going to be a bit wary when we approach it. We're going to be a bit trepidatious. I'm fully aware that there's very little that I can say today that won't have been said before in some form or another about this play. In fact, you may have noticed it's become a bit of a tradition, when people are writing books about Shakespeare, they often open the book with an apology for writing the book. You might have seen this. They will say, "I'm very sorry, I'm adding to the pile, the endless pile, of Shakespearean books." Hamlet, in particular, is one that has been a obsession for some of the greatest minds in literary criticism.
- 2.2 The first thing I will say to you is, I think we need to leave that aside. I think you need not to worry about that. I mean, yes, Hamlet is a work of genius, but that doesn't mean that we should feel intimidated by it. On the contrary, I think that is the reason for reading it, for engaging with it, for immersing ourselves in it. How do we find an entry point into this immense play, this absolute beast, in literary history? Well, we might assume that the best approach is to see it being performed, but there are problems here. For one thing, whenever we see a play in performance, we're not really seeing the play. We're seeing a specific interpretation of the play. One director's Hamlet will be completely different to another director's Hamlet, not to mention the huge varieties of interpretations by the actors themselves. Theater is essentially a collaborative project.
- 2.3 When you're reading the play, you obviate that problem. It is your sole interpretation. And by the way, there's also a problem which I alluded to before, that in today's climate, when you have most professional theater, productions are tending towards propaganda for a particular ideological worldview. That doesn't quite work as well. Certainly doesn't work with Shakespeare. Shakespeare is not best served by theater directors who think that it's their job to sanitize his work for modern sensibilities or to modify the work to promote certain fashionable trends. Shakespeare, as I've said, is too complex for that. Put simply, in a theater industry that is currently so captured by ideology, you will struggle to find worthwhile productions of Shakespeare. I've been very disappointed with all of the productions of Shakespeare I've seen over the past 10 years. It is a real problem because Shakespeare doesn't work as propaganda.
- 2.4 But of course, there's nothing new here. So in 1820, William Hazlitt, who I think still is one of the critics of Shakespeare who's really worth reading; I would really recommend his book, *Characters of Shakespeare's Plays*. And he wrote, "We do not like to see our author's plays acted. And least of all, Hamlet. There is no play that suffers so much in

being transferred to the stage." I think he's got a point, but thankfully, we have got the texts themselves. That's where we ought to begin. If, by the way, you are interested in seeing a filmed version of Hamlet, there are plenty of strong ones. So, Laurence Olivier's Hamlet, from 1948, has a lot to recommend it. He has a very interesting cinematic technique where he puts the soliloquies as voiceovers, which, of course, you can do in the cinema. It does somehow dilute the theatrical impact, but it works for film.

2.5 Kenneth Branagh's film of Hamlet from 1996 has a lot to recommend it, not least that the script is virtually all intact. That's why it's about four hours long. There's even an intermission in that film. The only problem I find with that film is that you end up playing "spot the celebrity" because there's all sorts of famous actors that turn up in little roles, like Jack Lemmon or Charlton Heston or John Gielgud suddenly appears in a flashback. Judy Dench is there, Robin Williams, even Ken Dodd turns up. Franco Zeffirelli made a very good film of Hamlet in 1990, with Mel Gibson in the title role, and Glenn Close is brilliant in that film as Gertrude.

2.6 But I would say, however, on a personal note, for all of Hollywood's efforts, I actually think the best filmed adaptation of Hamlet that I've ever seen is a far more obscure version. This is a televised version by the BBC in 1964. It was entitled Hamlet at Elsinore, filmed on videotape, so it's very grainy, it's not great quality, but it was actually shot at Elsinore Castle in Denmark, so the very castle where Hamlet is set. So there's that, which is really beneficial in terms of watching the play. But also Christopher Plummer, who plays Hamlet, I think is the best on-screen interpretation of Hamlet that I've ever seen. Robert Shaw plays Claudius. Michael Caine plays Horatio, very important choric figure in the play, and he's very good at it. You've got a brilliant Polonius, played by Alec Clunes. It's the best Polonius I've ever seen. Not an easy character to get right. Steven Berkoff actually turns up as one of the players, and they do a Japanese dumb show version of the play within a play. Very, very effective. I would really, really recommend that one.

2.7 But anyway, let's talk briefly about the background to Hamlet. The first thing that we absolutely need to be alert to when we're approaching this text is that there are multiple Hamlets. As I said in the previous lecture, a lot of the plays were published in quarto form, in those small dispensable texts that often fell apart and didn't survive, and also in the Folio version. Now, with Hamlet, we have three different versions of Hamlet. We have the Folio version, from 1623, but we also have two quarto editions. Now, this wouldn't matter so much, except that they are all quite wildly different in certain respects.

2.8 So there's a quarto edition that was published in 1603. We call that the Bad Quarto. What we know about that is that it was probably cobbled together from memory. They didn't really have copyright laws in these days, and sometimes people would put a text together to make money. We think, or critics believe, that this was put together by the

actor who played Marcellus, who also probably doubled as the diplomat, Voltemand, and also Lucianus, from the players. We know this because those roles are particularly well rendered. They're particularly well remembered, and it's all very clean. Then when he gets into some of the other roles, he's getting things slightly wrong. The "to be or not to be" speech is completely unrecognizable. That version of the play, as I say, isn't fully intact. It was an unauthorized version. That's the Bad Quarto. That's around 2,150 lines long.

2.9 Then you've got the Good Quarto, and that's 3,674 lines long, so it's significantly longer. Much expanded. That was published in 1604, republished in 1605. We have a few editions of that left. We know that that was probably put together from Shakespeare's own manuscripts, from his foul papers. The reason it's so long is because the foul papers were almost always cut in performance. Shakespeare would overwrite, and then when it came to putting it on the stage, various things that didn't work were cut out. You might remember in *Romeo and Juliet*, at the start of *Romeo and Juliet*, the chorus references the "two hours' traffic of our stage." Do you remember that? This gives us a good sense of the usual length of a play at this time, not four hours as Kenneth Branagh's *Hamlet* is, but more like two hours. So the Good Quarto of *Hamlet* probably does run to about four hours.

2.10 And then we have the version published in the First Folio of 1623, which is just a little shorter than the Good Quarto. That's 3,500 lines. Again, quite a long one, and there are significant textual variations. Now, I haven't got time in this lecture to go into all the specific textual differences. There are many, many books about the subject. But what I'm saying is that it's very important for you to understand that there is not a definitive text of *Hamlet*. It's very much going to depend on the editor of the particular edition that you have. So if you have the Arden edition or the New Cambridge edition or the Oxford edition, there will be differences between all three of them.

2.11 Some editors just choose one of the versions. Some editors do this weird hybrid, where they try to amalgamate all the different types of versions. Same thing happens often with editions of *King Lear*. If you, for instance, if you've got the New Cambridge edition of *King Lear*, it's missing the scene where they put on the faux trial of Goneril and Regan, and represent Goneril with a stool, which is actually quite a famous scene, but it's not in that version of the play. So you do have to be a bit careful.

2.12 And in addition, if you ever see *Hamlet* performed, it will almost always be cut in some way or another. So for instance, in Laurence Olivier's film, he took out Rosencrantz and Guildenstern completely. Well, actually, they do appear for about five seconds. They don't say anything. They take the letter to the King of England, saying that Hamlet ought to die, and they move off, but they're not in it. That does change the tenor of the play. I would think, with Rosencrantz and Guildenstern, the fact that Hamlet arranges for them to be killed is actually very important, because it gives us a different aspect to Hamlet, a kind of needless cruelty to Hamlet. He didn't need to do that. It goes back to

this thing that I'm going to be talking about a lot, about moral ambiguity of the heroes in Shakespeare's tragedies.

- 2.13** We don't know what version of Hamlet appeared on the Elizabethan stage. If you look at a play like Macbeth, that's very short, one of the shortest of Shakespeare's plays. The only version of Macbeth appears in the Folio. It's one of those plays we would have lost if Heminges and Condell hadn't put it together. We know that that was probably a stage performance, a stage version, of Macbeth, because it's nice and short. I do wonder whether one day the foul papers of Shakespeare will be discovered. That would be an absolutely fantastic thing. There will be a longer version of Macbeth, just as there is a longer version of Hamlet.
- 2.14** And there'll be lots of gems within that, lots of beautiful passages that have been lost—just as there are, doubtless, many, many literary gems still to be discovered under the volcanic ash at Herculaneum, which for some reason they haven't delved into as much as they should. There are probably Shakespeare texts and documents lingering in all sorts of basements and attics and dusty old libraries, waiting for the light of day. But let's work with what we've got.
- 2.15** I'm raising these points, as I say, so you understand there isn't a definitive Hamlet at all. But it does look as though, given that we've got these very, very different versions of the same play, it looks as though this was a particular obsession for Shakespeare, almost as though he continually returned to this, rewrote this play, was never really satisfied with this play. I would even suggest that there probably wasn't a definitive version of Hamlet in his lifetime. Maybe he was never satisfied with it. Most people date the play for around 1600. If you think, Hamlet is pretty much smack-bang in the middle of Shakespeare's career. So 1600, right in the middle.
- 2.16** We don't have any manuscripts, by the way, in Shakespeare's hand. There is one that we do, possibly. This is a manuscript of a play called Sir Thomas More, which was a collaborative play. Many writers were involved in this play, including Shakespeare. It is very likely that one of the pages is written in Shakespeare's handwriting, because other than that, we've just got a few signatures on legal documents and things like that. But it is likely that this is, in fact, Shakespeare's handwriting. If it is correct, if that attribution is right, that's the only sustained piece of writing we have in Shakespeare's hand.
- 2.17** We should think of Hamlet as a play that Shakespeare kept returning to, that didn't get settled. There was an earlier version of Hamlet, which is known as the Ur-Hamlet, U-R, Ur-Hamlet. We don't know who wrote it. We know that this was around a number of years before, late 1580s. We don't know who wrote it, as I say. A lot of people think Thomas Kyd wrote it. He was that guy who was considered part of the University Wits, even though he didn't go to university. But the evidence for that is very circumstantial. Thomas Nashe refers to this version of Hamlet in a preface to a text by Robert Greene. This was from 1589, where he criticizes those playwrights who rely too heavily on Seneca for inspiration.

- 2.18** So this is what Nash says. He says, "English Seneca, read by candlelight, yields many good sentences as 'Blood is a beggar,' and so forth; and if you entreat him fair in a frosty morning, he will afford you whole Hamlets, I should say, handfuls of tragical speeches." There's an allusion to Kyd in Nashe's preface, but it is by no means proof that Kyd wrote this version of the play. So I would be very wary about taking that. A lot of critiques just say, "Thomas Kyd wrote the Ur-Hamlet." I don't think he did. Harold Bloom, the great literary critic, was convinced that Shakespeare was the author of the Ur-Hamlet. I think that is very likely, as well. We just don't have the evidence. But if Shakespeare was the author of the Ur-Hamlet, then it would mean that actually it was one of his earliest plays, and that the 1600 version was him returning to it, improving on it. That seems very, very feasible to me, especially in the light of the variations that we see between the three extant versions of the play.
- 2.19** Now, my focus today on Hamlet is around the notion of revenge, and I think this is the entry point into the play. This is the way that we can really grapple with it, to think in terms of genre. As we can see from what Nashe had written, revenge tragedy was hugely popular at the time that Shakespeare came to London, that key year, 1587. Senecan tragedy. He mentioned Seneca, right? You know Seneca, the Roman writer, the tutor to Nero. Very, very popular at this time. And around this time, also, you had Thomas Kyd's play, *The Spanish Tragedy*. That was from 1587 as well, really popular, was really off the stage. I directed a version of *The Spanish Tragedy* once at a school I was teaching at, Merchant Taylor School, which is actually where Thomas Kyd attended. It really is a bloodbath. It is spectacular. It is gory. It's actually a great play, but it is very much in the Senecan mold.
- 2.20** The style of Senecan tragedy that was popular in Elizabethan England had a few key characteristics that defined it as revenge tragedy. You'd normally have a ghost. You would normally have a very high body count. There's usually madness, or affected madness, of the protagonist. That's a feature in the Spanish tragedy, as well. And of course, most importantly, there is a revenge plot. There's something so pure about revenge as a plot. It's something that you can just grasp immediately. It always really, really works. If you think about Tarantino's film, *Kill Bill*, the reason why that's so good is because it's very, very simple. You can summarize it quite straightforwardly. A woman is shot almost to death by five of her ex-colleagues, and throughout the two films, one by one, she gets them back, kills them off. Absolutely pure and very entertaining.
- 2.21** *Star Trek II: The Wrath of Khan*. It's a pure revenge story. It's the best of the *Star Trek* films because of that. I think revenge works really, really well. No wonder it was so popular during Shakespeare's time. No wonder the Spanish tragedy and *Hamlet* was also hugely, hugely popular. We think of it as a elitist text. It was really, really popular at the time. And also, and this is crucial, *Titus Andronicus*, right? I mentioned this before. *Titus Andronicus*, Shakespeare's probably his earliest play, pure revenge

tragedy. It's got most of the features that I just mentioned. It's also the play that really establishes Shakespeare as a major force on the Elizabethan theatrical scene.

2.22 So let's just talk about *Titus Andronicus* a little bit first before we get on to *Hamlet*, because I think you can understand one in the context of the other. So first thing, it's a bloodbath, it's a gorefest. It is just dismemberment, degeneracy. It is very difficult to watch. And because of this, a lot of critics like to say, "Well, Shakespeare didn't write that." Or they say, "It was just the exuberance of youth." They make apologies for it. They say things like, "Surely, the great Shakespeare couldn't have written such a hideous representation of the basist deeds of which mankind is capable." But of course he could. We forget this was the fashion of the time.

2.23 Now, I said before that Shakespeare had a great instinct for comedy, that it came very naturally to him, and that, with tragedy, he developed. And by the time you get to the late Jacobean period, where you get all the great tragedies—you know, *Othello*, *King Lear*, *Antony and Cleopatra*, *Macbeth*, *Coriolanus* —he's unsurpassed. He's unparalleled. No one comes close, and no one has beaten it ever since. But in these early years, when you have plays like *Titus Andronicus* and, to an extent, *Romeo and Juliet*, he's still developing his craft. He's still working it out. When it comes to *Titus*, there have been many attempts to dismiss it. Some people even say that they think Christopher Marlowe wrote *Titus Andronicus*, or George Peele, or even Thomas Kyd, because I suppose it's seen as a blot on Shakespeare's legacy.

2.24 I don't think that's right. I mean, for one thing, it's a better play than people give it credit for. *Titus Andronicus* is worth watching. Also, it's important in his journey as a tragedian, as a dramatist. Remember, public sensibilities are really different at this time. One of the most popular family days out, one of the best excursions, was to go and see a traitor being publicly executed. You would take the kids to watch a man being hung by the neck until he was almost dead, and then have his belly severed and his entrails slowly pulled out while he's still alive. And then eventually, he would be hewn into four pieces, hung, drawn, and quartered. They loved it, and they took the kids. So this is what we're talking about. This is the kind of society we're talking about. So of course, when you get the advent of the public theaters, they want to see violence. They want to see gore, and that's what they get with *Titus Andronicus*, right?

2.25 And it's also why the comedy of *Titus Andronicus* would have been more effective then. They would have been more receptive to that. We watch *Titus Andronicus* and we think, "This can't possibly be funny, can it?" I think it is. Not only that, I think it's deliberately funny. Now, *Titus* is set in late imperial Christian Rome, around 6th century. There aren't any direct sources for *Titus*, apart from Ovid, who provides the subplot, the story of Lavinia. Now, interestingly, the only contemporary illustration we have of a Shakespeare play, drawn at the time, is from *Titus Andronicus*. This is an image from 1595. It's a sketch by Henry Peacham. It's called the Longleat manuscript.

It's very interesting to look at because it shows that the actors are in a mix of Elizabethan costume and Roman costume.

- 2.26** It helps us understand how they approach these theatrical events, how they would make an effort to contextualize these things historically, even though there are occasional anachronisms in Julius Caesar, for instance, the reference to the clock. There are deliberate anachronisms in King Lear. When the fool mentions, with his prophecy, he mentions Merlin. He does that deliberately because Merlin predates the Arthurian years. Shakespeare plays around with anachronism as well. But it's just interesting to have a look at this illustration of Titus Andronicus. It's got the Queen of the Goths kneeling, Tamora, Aaron the Moor is there. Titus is there, in full Roman regalia.
- 2.27** Now, I don't like normally to give plot synopses. I won't be doing that during these lectures, but I will give you a synopsis of Titus, just because I think most of you probably won't have encountered it before. So it concerns a war veteran, Titus Andronicus. He returns from fighting the Goths. He's lost 21 of his 25 sons in the war. That's a bad ratio. He's offered the Empire. They say, "We want you to be Emperor." He doesn't want it, so he hands that honor to Saturninus, who's the eldest son of the dead Emperor. Unfortunately, Saturninus is a bit of a brat. He resents Titus because Titus was offered it to begin with. And Saturninus marries the Queen of the Goths, the woman who has just been vanquished in war by Titus. This obviously develops a degree of resentment, particularly since, at the start of the play, Titus sacrifices Tamora's eldest son.
- 2.28** So, once Tamora has established her new role as wife of the Emperor, and she's got her two remaining sons with her, Chiron and Demetrius, she decides to take revenge on Titus. This is a multiple revenge story. So the first revenge is the Queen of the Goths taking revenge on Titus. And what happens is the two sons, Chiron and Demetrius, rape Lavinia in the forest, and they kill her lover, Bassianus, who's the brother of the Emperor. They rape her on the corpse of her dead lover. They then cut out her tongue so she can't tell anyone who did it, and they chop off her hands so she cannot write down the identity of her assailants.
- 2.29** Now, I just want to pause here for a moment in the plot to look at this part of the play, this aspect of the play. I think it reveals a great deal about Shakespeare's use of language and how he enables us to visualize what is taking place. I told you before, they didn't have much in the way of scenery in the Elizabethan era. So, this is the scene where Lavinia enters, having just been raped. Her hands are chopped off. Her tongue is cut out. She is drenched in blood. The first person to see her is her uncle, Marcus. He doesn't rush to help her.
- 2.30** Now, that seems odd to us. This is a really key point, and I'm mentioning this now because I want you to keep it in mind throughout the lectures. Shakespeare doesn't write realism. When you see things that happen in Shakespeare plays that just don't make sense, they don't seem feasible, it doesn't matter, because these are elaborate

works of poetry. You are completely approaching them in the wrong way if you say, "Well, that wouldn't happen." OK, so Lavinia comes in. Marcus doesn't rush to help her, her uncle. What he says is, "Who is this? My niece, that flies away so fast?" He can't quite see who it is. What you have here already is a stage direction embedded into his words.

- 2.31** Stage directions, by the way, very scarce in Shakespeare's early plays. They do appear quite frequently in the late, late plays. If you read *Henry VIII*, also known as *All Is True*, that's the subtitle, which was a collaboration he wrote with Fletcher, that play is full of stage directions, really long, elaborate stage directions. A lot of people think it's because Shakespeare probably retired by that point to Stratford-upon-Avon. He wasn't there at the theater to oversee the productions. So, you can imagine he doesn't bother writing stage directions in the early plays because he's going to be there. He'll say, "I want it done this way. I want it done that way." So he's not there towards the end. But what he does do is embed the directions within the imagery that the characters speak.
- 2.32** So we've got, he says, "Who is this? My niece, that flies away so fast?" And so we know Lavinia is turning away. She's humiliated by her own deformity. He says, "Cousin, a word. Where is your husband?" Again, it sounds unfeasible. She's drenched in blood. She has no hands. I think, actually, that's quite suggestive. I think it's that he cannot see this thing. It is a sight so horrific, his mind will not let him see this thing. I think that's quite psychologically perceptive. OK. And in the next line, he says, he sees it. He says, "If I do dream, would all my wealth would wake me. If I do wake, some planet strike me down that I may slumber an eternal sleep." He's seen it now. He's horrified. "Speak, gentle niece. What stern, ungentle hands hath lopped and hewed and made thy body bare of her two branches, those sweet ornaments whose circling shadows kings have sought to sleep in, and might not gain so greater happiness as half thy love."
- 2.33** Now, in Julie Taymor's film version of *Titus*, which is from 1999, starring Anthony Hopkins, she has Lavinia come in with her bloody stumps, with two branches forced into the stumps as makeshift hands. In other words, she literalizes the imagery that Shakespeare advances here. And Marcus says, "Why not speak to me?" And now there's another moment where Lavinia's actions are signaled by what he says. He says, "Alas, a crimson river of warm blood, like to a bubbling fountain stirred with wind, doth rise and fall between thy rosy lips, coming and going with thy honey breath." So you can see how this is working. This scene is just a monologue. It's just a single speech directed towards the mutilated, ravaged Lavinia. And the poetry of the language is creating the imagery in our minds. And this is why I think reading the tragedies is often a better experience than seeing them staged, because Shakespeare's imagery is so vivid. We don't need it to be reified for us in theatrical form.
- 2.34** He says, "But sure some Tereus hath deflowered thee." This is a direct reference to the story of Tereus, his rape of Philomela. You probably know this story in Ovid's *Metamorphoses*. This is a really interesting, what we would call today, intertextual

moment, because the character in the play is invoking the source material for the play within the play itself. And later on, when Lavinia finds a way to reveal the identity of the people who killed her lover, and raped her, she brings on a copy of Ovid, onto the stage, and points to the story of Philomela. It is what we'd call intertextual. It's very, very interesting.

- 2.35** And he says, "But sure some Tereus hath deflowered thee, and lest thou shouldst detect him, cut thy tongue. Ah, now thou turn'st away thy face for shame." Again, the stage direction. Lavinia turns away. It's embedded in the language. And now we have some visual imagery that describes Lavinia's emotional state. "And notwithstanding all this loss of blood, as from a conduit with three issuing spouts, yet do thy cheeks look red as Titan's face, blushing to be encountered with a cloud." It's a tremendously effective speech, and I want you to bear it in mind when we consider some of the scenes in other tragedies and how Shakespeare compels us not to think in terms of realism, but to immerse ourselves in scenarios that are essentially poetic approximations of human experience.
- 2.36** OK, back to the plot. So after the rape of Lavinia, you've got Titus's—well, things are about to get even worse. OK, so Chiron and Demetrius, they frame two of Titus's remaining sons, Quintus and Martius. Those two sons are arrested. Titus recovers Lavinia, and he's driven to despair by her mutilated condition. Remember, I said, madness is a key feature of Senecan tragedy. Aaron, who is a villainous Moor, the only prominent black character in Shakespeare, apart from Othello, of course—he's a villainous Moor, a lover of Tamora, the Queen of the Goths. He's a master of manipulation. He's actually more similar to Iago, in a way. He manages to convince Titus that his sons will be spared from execution if Titus sends his right hand to the Emperor. It's going to get pretty grim.
- 2.37** Titus cuts off his own right hand and sends it off to the Emperor, but the Emperor does not return his sons alive. The Emperor, in exchange, sends him the two decapitated heads of his sons. This is what I mean by the humor, the dark humor, of Titus Andronicus. Look at what he says here in Act 3, Scene 1. He says, this is Titus, "Come, brother, take a head, and in this hand the other will I bear. And Lavinia, thou shall be employed. Bear thou my hand, sweet wench, between thine arms." So think about that. He has his brother, Marcus, carrying the decapitated head of his son, and in Titus's one remaining hand, he carries the decapitated head of the other son, and he instructs Lavinia, his daughter with no tongue or hands, to carry his own hand between her two stumps. Now, I think this is the comedy of excess. Camille Paglia has written very convincingly about this. I think it's meant to be funny.
- 2.38** Anyway, as I said, Lavinia devises a way to reveal the identity of her assailants. She writes the name of Chiron and Demetrius in the sand, and Titus is now hell-bent on revenge. This is the secondary revenge plot. I want to cut a long story short because it's quite an intricate play. Titus kills Tamora's two sons, Chiron and Demetrius. He doesn't

just kill them, he bakes them into a pie. He mashes up their flesh and he bakes them. And then he holds a banquet, where he invites their mother along and feeds her with her own sons in the form of a pie. At the time, he is dressed as a chef. Please don't tell me that's not meant to be funny. OK? And then what happens at the banquet, he murders Lavinia, his own daughter, in front of his guests, because he says that that's the only noble course of action because she's been sexually violated. Then Titus then discloses that Tamora has, in fact, been eating her sons, and then he kills her at the moment of revelation. Saturninus, in turn, stabs Titus to death, and then Saturninus is stabbed by Lucius, Titus's son, and they all live happily ever after.

2.39 Now, so you can see, the body count is really high in this play. It is very extreme. There are scenes of dismemberment, rape, cannibalism, murder, torture, you name it. Hamlet is a far more sophisticated affair, but there are traces of the Senecan influence. There's the high body count at the end of the play. There is the madness of Hamlet, albeit a feigned madness. He's not really mad. There is the revenge plot. As a further touch, a further Senecan touch, there's a ghost—Hamlet's dead father, also confusingly called Hamlet—appears to him in the first act and reveals that he was murdered. He didn't just die. He was murdered by his brother, Claudius, who is now king. And so this instigates our revenge plot.

2.40 But it's not a straightforward revenge plot, is it? Because in a straightforward revenge plot, Hamlet would say to himself, "OK, my uncle has killed my father. My father's ghost has appeared, wants revenge. I am now going to go and kill Claudius." End of play, half an hour max. It doesn't happen, does it, all right? And this is the key to understanding Hamlet, as far as I'm concerned. We might best understand Hamlet as a revenger who is ill-suited to the role of revenger. So, where you get other revenge tragedies, you have the protagonist seizing the opportunity, taking revenge, Hamlet delays and delays and delays. It's almost as though he's in the wrong play. That's why I think it works. That's why I think we are endlessly fascinated by it.

2.41 You will have no doubt heard the cliché that Hamlet is a procrastinator. I don't think this is a sufficient explanation. He isn't just putting things off because he's thinking about it too much. He does think too much. All he ever does is think, but it's not sufficient. He does have genuine fears that the ghost of his father may not be his father at all, but a demon in disguise. That is a well-founded fear. He's worried about condemning his own soul. This is not a trivial matter at this time in our history. The moment when he fails to kill Claudius because Claudius is at prayer, this is Act 3, Scene 3. His rationale does ring true. He says, "A villain kills my father, and for that I, his sole son, do this same villain send to heaven. Oh, this is hire and salary, not revenge." He doesn't want to—if you kill Claudius at prayer, you'll send his soul to heaven. That's not revenge at all.

2.42 In the very next scene, after that, we see further evidence that Hamlet is no procrastinator. When he's talking to his mother, Gertrude, in her chamber, he thinks he

hears Claudius behind the arras, behind the curtain. He doesn't hesitate. He stabs him. He strikes. It wasn't Claudius at all. It was Polonius. He's killed the wrong man. But it does show us that we're not dealing with someone here who is squeamish about the act of killing itself. So perhaps the best way to think for Hamlet, as I say, is a character who is completely unsuited to revenge, but nonetheless has found himself within the genre of revenge tragedy.

- 2.43** It sounds a bit meta-theatrical, doesn't it? But Hamlet is very concerned with theatricality. I mean, the players turn up. He uses a play to get Claudius to confess his guilt. The players turn up at Elsinore and he says, "I want you to do this extra scene in the play at court tonight." The scene is exactly the same as what happened to his father. The king pours poison into his ear. Claudius, of course, seeing this, seeing what he has done, and being no doubt that Claudius is guilty of this, runs from the room, and that is then confirmation. Hamlet knows for sure. He needs to do that. He needs to be sure that he's taking revenge against the right man. He needs to be sure that the ghost is actually his father and is in earnest. OK, so very concerned with theatricality. It's really key to the play.
- 2.44** Now, Harold Bloom, who I think is a fantastic literary critic, sadly no longer with us. It's really worth reading his book on Shakespeare, *Shakespeare: The Invention of the Human*. He used to say that he felt that Hamlet had a life of his own, that he runs away from his creator. He wrote a book about this called *Hamlet: Poem Unlimited*. Now, I think he's right about this. Hamlet, the character, seems to think for himself almost independently of Shakespeare. It's like Shakespeare can't really control him. He doesn't fit into the play that his creator has placed him in. He's continually questioning himself, probing his own motivations, his own emotions—mostly, of course, through that convention I mentioned earlier, the convention of the soliloquy. Really, really key.
- 2.45** Now, Shakespeare's soliloquies. I cannot emphasize this enough. They are a major innovation. A soliloquy is simply a speech spoken on stage alone by a character. It is a form of direct address. It's the way that the audience learn what's going through the character's mind. But they are not, in Shakespeare, just expositional. An old-style soliloquy would be a character saying, "I'm going to do this. I'm going to take revenge on this person." This is telling you the plot. Shakespeare changes that. He changes that convention. And what happens is, we get inner conflicts within a character articulated. So, whereas plays up until this point would show conflicts out there in the world — wars, battles, revenge, love, hate, whatever, human conflict—Shakespeare makes that conflict internal conflict. There are conflicts going on within these characters. It is an absolutely fascinating development.
- 2.46** Hamlet, I think, is the pinnacle of this idea. He isn't just a revenger, he's a philosopher. Now, Hazlitt said, of Hamlet, "He is a great moralizer," and what makes him worth attending to is that he moralizes on his own feelings and experiences. His thoughts are profound. Hamlet is a student. He's an intellectual. He's also funny. He's one of the

wittiest characters in Shakespeare. He's a character who evades our understanding, even when he's sharing his most private thoughts with us. This is one of the reasons why the play will always last. It's endlessly fascinating, and there has never been a character like this ever since. Nothing like this. Of course, unlike many of the other plays, this one character is the main subject.

- 2.47 This is a play that I would urge you to read more than once. I've read it many, many times, and I still discover new things in it every time I read it. It's all about Hamlet. It's all about him. The whole plot revolves around him. Everything revolves around him. He drives the action. He compels our interest. Then we give an example. So let's have a look at the first soliloquy. Now, remember, this is a moment where he is reflecting on the marriage of his mother to his uncle, following the death of his father. This is a scene at court. Claudius, Gertrude, and the courtiers have left the room. Hamlet is alone. And remember, at this point, he has not yet seen the ghost of his father, right? He doesn't know that there was a murder, but he has plunged in melancholy. OK, this is what he says.
- 2.48 "Oh, that this too, too solid flesh would melt, thaw, and resolve itself into a dew, or that the Everlasting had not fixed his canon 'gainst self-slaughter!" So what do we have? Suicidal contemplations from the outset. And these are going to be revisited and compounded later on in his famous "to be or not to be" speech, which is a speech that is often interpreted for some reason as not being about suicide. It clearly is. This is what Hamlet now says in this soliloquy.
- 2.49 "That it should come to this, but two months dead. Nay, not so much, not two. So excellent a king, that was to this Hyperion to a satyr, so loving to my mother that he might not beteem the winds of heaven visit her face too roughly. Heaven and earth, must I remember? Why, she would hang on him, as if increase of appetite had grown by what it fed on, and yet within a month —let me not think of it. Frailty, thy name is woman. A little month, or ere these shoes were old with which she followed my poor father's body, like Niobe, all tears. Why she, even she—O God, a beast that wants discourse of reason would have mourned longer!" Notice how he continually interrupts his own thought process. In other words, he's working out his thoughts as he goes along. It's reflected in the rhythm of the language.
- 2.50 He says, "Married with mine uncle, my father's brother, but no more like my father than I to Hercules, within a month." He keeps saying this. He keeps emphasizing the brevity of time. He cannot quite comprehend it. "Within a month, ere yet the salt of most unrighteous tears had left the flushing of her galled eyes, she married. O most wicked speed, to post with such dexterity to incestuous sheets! It is not, nor it cannot, come to good." Why so melancholic? Why is he so suicidal? This seems to us excessive. He's lost his father. Yes, it's upsetting. Why has he been plunged into this abyss of despair? Until we realize that what we're seeing here is a young man who has been forced to confront the human failings of one that he had idealized.

- 2.51** The death of his father, a Hyperion in his view, the Titan of Greek mythology, "a Hyperion to a satyr," satyr being Claudius, right? This has left him crushed and bereft. But in addition, his mother has fallen in his eyes. So she married again so quickly, so soon after the funeral, that he is later able to say to Horatio, "The funeral baked meats did coldly furnish forth the marriage tables." The leftovers from the funeral were served on the wedding day. That's an example of how he preserves his sense of humor, even at his lowest point. Gertrude has married Claudius, this satyr to this Hyperion. Claudius, by the way, as he repeatedly emphasizes in the play, is a wastrel. He's drunk. He gets drunk and sings at night. He's not going to be the king that Hamlet Senior was.
- 2.52** It is quite the downfall in Denmark. Remember, "something rotten in the state of Denmark." And Gertrude is now taking to incestuous sheets, not incest in our terms, but she has married her husband's brother. So she is no longer the figure that Hamlet knew. She's become degraded in his eyes. This is a sense that we can all relate to, isn't it? This is something we've all experienced, not just that realization in childhood that our role models, our parents, are flawed, are human. If anything, that's a healthy development, but rather that those we most loved, those we most admired, are not who we thought they were, that we've been worshiping false idols. That we have been deceived, or at least that we have deceived ourselves.
- 2.53** Hamlet's emotional state has been produced by a sense of something beautiful and perfect being irreparably corrupted. He has been living in an idealized world, and now he's collided with the brick wall of reality. That's why he is in despair. We've all been there, I think. But as I say, he does fail as an avenger. This is not the role he was meant to fulfill. Shakespeare makes this very, very clear. The way he does this is, he provides what a real avenger should look like, more than one.
- 2.54** You've got Fortinbras. Fortinbras, who is the nephew of the king of Norway, who is mounting an army on the outskirts of Denmark. Remember, the stakes are very high here. Fortinbras also lost his father, who also shared his name. He was also called Fortinbras. OK. And his uncle is now on the throne. It is the exact mirror image of what has happened to Hamlet. But Fortinbras is going to reclaim the land lost by his father. He's going to march into Denmark. He's going to take the Danish throne in the last scene of this play. In other words, he is a man of action, not of thought.
- 2.55** Laertes is another example. Laertes is the brother of Ophelia, the son of Polonius. When he learns about the death of his father, that Hamlet has stabbed his father through the arras, when his sister goes mad and kills herself, Laertes does not hesitate. He immediately vows revenge against Hamlet, and he commits to that course. He doesn't fear condemning his own soul like Hamlet does, because the duty outweighs the risk of perdition. He says actually, he uses the phrase, "I dare damnation." That's what Laertes says. He doesn't delay. It's almost as though this should be a play about Laertes. If this were the story of Laertes, it would be a conventional revenge tragedy.

Hamlet is not a Laertes, and in pitting them together, we're reminded of this continually. It's a very clever conceit. Hamlet knows it as well.

2.56 When he meets the players and he asks them to put on this show within a show, this play within a play—the Mousetrap, it's called. It replicates the murder of the father. It's a test for Claudius. When he's talking to the players, he's reminded of one of his favorite speeches, of a play that he saw many years ago, the character of Pyrrhus, whose father was Achilles. And this is another son avenging his father. Briefly, we're taken back into the Trojan War, and Hamlet recites the speech from memory. And in that speech, he outlines exactly what a revenger ought to be. He uses the phrase, "Roasted in wrath and fire." Hamlet knows what he's meant to be, but "roasted in wrath and fire" doesn't sound much like Hamlet, does it? There's a reason he chooses that speech.

2.57 Now, I make no claim to originality on this point. Hamlet, as the inadequate revenger, is a concept that predates even A. C. Bradley. He wrote a brilliant book called *Shakespearean Tragedy* in 1904, where he outlined this idea. It predates Bradley. Critics have long known this. They've long understood this. Goethe wrote of Hamlet's "lovely, pure, and most moral nature," and he pointed out that he lacked the "strength of nerve which forms a hero." Coleridge, likewise, wrote of Hamlet's aversion to real action, and he saw this as directly connected to his enormous intellectual activity, as though the two are not compatible. Hamlet is too intelligent, is a thinker, a philosophizer, that's why he does not act. However, I would say an intelligent revenger isn't necessarily inconceivable, but it is flying against the theatrical conventions of the time. But I would urge you to read A. C. Bradley on Hamlet. He's one of those critics that fell out of fashion somewhere in the mid-20th century. But fashion is meaningless, right? Bradley is still right about the fundamental ideas, whether his ideas are fashionable or not.

2.58 And he's particularly strong on this point, of the reasons for Hamlet's melancholy. Hamlet's delight in the infinite potential of man, so brutally wrecked by the disappointment of his mother's hasty marriage to his uncle, has left him in this state of despair. It is the loss of idealism, the loss of joy in life. This is Hamlet's tragedy. I often think that, for a 20th-century equivalent, we might look at E. M. Forster's novel, *A Passage to India*. I don't know if you've read *A Passage to India*, the best of Forster's novels. I would really recommend it. There is a horrible crushing moment where the character with the most exuberance, the character we warm to the most, Mrs. Moore, goes into the Marabar caves, hears the echo of her own voice return to her, and for some esoteric, metaphysical reason, is suddenly hit by the futility of human existence. Everything can be reduced to that echo. Boom, boom, everything. It's a horrible moment. This most glorious and vibrant of characters instantaneously becomes nothing. She's not even wailing in despair. She's just numb. She's just a husk. She's entered the equivalent of what Edmund Spenser in *The Faerie Queene* depicts as the Cave of Despair.

- 2.59** Hamlet is wracked by this similar existential crisis. But what Hamlet does, which is what Mrs. Moore does not do, and is not capable of doing, is Hamlet will intellectualize the experience. He will try and think his way beyond it. He's going to grapple with the significance of the whole thing, or rather the insignificance of the whole thing. This is perhaps why the story of Cain and Abel is invoked not once, but three times in this play. Claudius and Cain represent not just the murder of a brother, but a repudiation of God, a turning-away from God, or at least all that is godly. So, from melancholy, Hamlet moves into madness, or rather what he calls his antic disposition. In other words, madness feigned. He's not really mad. He's going to pretend to be mad.
- 2.60** Now, as we've seen, this is a convention of the revenge tragedy genre. But in Hamlet's case, it derives from the source material. So this is an old, old story. The earliest version of Hamlet was written in Latin by the Danish chronicler Saxo Grammaticus, around 1200 AD. And then the character is called Amleth. That word Amleth derives from the Old Norse for idiot or one who feigns idiocy. So it's a defining aspect of this character. And in Shakespeare's Hamlet, we're led to believe that he's feigning madness to protect himself, to throw Claudius off the scent, to disguise his vengeful intentions. But there is more to it than that.
- 2.61** So within the performance of madness, Hamlet finds a means to explore and interrogate his own emotional state. He's not bound by social conventions. If he's mad, he can say anything. He can think anything. This is why we catch glimpses of wisdom and insight, even within his ramblings. The same thing happens in King Lear. When Lear goes mad, there's a lot of gibberish there, with little moments of insight here and there, particularly penetrating. How does Hamlet put it to Guildenstern? This is in Act 2. He says, "I am but mad north-northwest; when the wind is southerly, I know a hawk from a handsaw." It's one of those strange declarations. Even while he's admitting that he is feigning madness, he sounds completely mad. There's nothing more dissimilar than a hawk and a handsaw. It's a statement of madness, while he's confessing not to being mad.
- 2.62** Now, although Hamlet as a play focuses on this one key character and his private torments and struggles, the stakes are extremely high. Denmark is at war with Norway, and Hamlet's revenge, however long it takes, will destabilize the royal family even further. Marcellus says, "Something rotten in the state of Denmark." There is something rotten here. It's not just about the family, it's about what's going on more broadly. But Hamlet's actions will reverberate beyond himself and his immediate circle.
- 2.63** Then, of course, there's the question of Ophelia, very important character. Now, some feminist critics have argued that—well, they've expressed concern that she's such a passive figure. She's a perpetual victim. The play would be very different if that was a Cordelia, if that was an Imogen. It's not. It's Ophelia. But there are elements of the text, particularly when she's talking to Laertes, that completely disprove this. So just before Laertes sets off to France, he's advising her. He's being very patronizing. He's telling her

how she ought to behave. And he's saying, "You need to be wary of Hamlet's affections." And this is what Ophelia says. She says, "I shall the effect of this good lesson keep as watchman to my heart. But, good my brother, do not, as some ungracious pastors do, show me the steep and thorny way to heaven, whilst like a puffed and reckless libertine himself, the primrose path of dalliance treads and recks not his own rede."

- 2.64** In other words, he, Laertes, should be wary of being the type who gives advice but doesn't take heed himself. That's not a passive figure. And I think the role of Ophelia is key, not least because she represents the path that Hamlet might have taken. I see no reason to doubt that Hamlet was once in love with Ophelia, and she in love with him. But once she stops answering his letters, at the behest of Polonius, she becomes another example for Hamlet of this corrupted ideal that I've been trying to emphasize. Remember that the disappointment of his mother's remarriage leads to him to declare that phrase that you've heard before, "Frailty, thy name is woman." He suddenly starts to generalize about women on the basis of his mother. And so he sees in the loss of Ophelia's affections a similar betrayal.
- 2.65** He tells her, repeatedly, "Get thee to a nunnery." Get thee to a nunnery. Lots of critics say that nunnery was a slang term for brothel, so that he's being dismissive and vulgar and sexual. I don't think that's right. I think he means it absolutely literally. I think he's saying that the only way she can escape from being corrupted by the world is to confine herself, to remove herself from society. And by this point, remember, Hamlet is absolutely disgusted by the sexual act. He now associates it with his mother in her incestuous sheets. And he viciously says to Gertrude, his mother, in the chamber, "Nay, but to live in the rank sweat of an enseamed bed, stewed in corruption, honeying and making love over the nasty sty—" and she interrupts because she can't take it anymore. "O, speak to me no more! These words like daggers enter in mine ears."
- 2.66** Imagine saying this to your mother, conjuring this image of a sweaty enseamed bed. It's grotesque. He's so cruel to his mother in that scene that the ghost of Hamlet's father has to appear to intervene. That's how far he's gone. Now, this cruelty towards women is inescapable in the play. Hamlet teases Ophelia at the staging of the play within a play, The Mousetrap. He teases her in the most crudely sexual way. He says, "Shall I lie in your lap? Do you think I meant country matters?" An obvious anatomical pun. So one minute he's lashing out at her, using her as a conduit for all the anger in the world, his disgust with human sexuality. The next minute, he's making her the butt of a crude joke, crucially in front of everyone else at court, humiliating her. But then, fast forward to Act 5 when he's at her graveside, and he declares that he loved her more than Laertes ever could. He said, "Forty thousand brothers could not, with all their quantity of love, make up my sum."
- 2.67** Can we believe him? Does he believe himself? What we do know is that Hamlet is as capable of tenderness as he is of cruelty. So, do we ever know Hamlet at all? Perhaps

not. But in spite of his idiosyncrasies, in spite of his immense intellect, his endless philosophizing, and the extraordinary circumstances of his story, I think we all find ourselves empathizing with Hamlet in one way or another. There's a long tradition of critics reading their own obsessions into Hamlet, and the sheer scope of Hamlet's thoughts makes this possible for any reader. I myself find a great resonance with his sense of a broken ideal. In recent years, I have been forced to confront the truth that maybe my faith in the essential goodness of humanity is misjudged. People often disappoint me in a really horrendous way. So when I read Hamlet lamenting what his mother has become, I can't help but project my own disappointment onto him.

- 2.68** Coleridge wrote, "I have a smack of Hamlet myself, if I may say so." Look at the way that Freud was able to draw on Hamlet for the interpretation of dreams, for his Oedipus complex? There is something in of Hamlet in all of us. He is the reluctant avenger. But are we not all falling short of a purpose that we imagine for ourselves? I think Hazlitt had it right when he said that "Hamlet's thoughts are as real as our own. It is we who are Hamlet." Thank you very much. If you have any questions, now would be the time.
- 2.69** Thank you. Two of the most famous quotes in all of Shakespeare happen in that play, "To be or not to be, that is the question," and the, in the ambivalence he has in trying to work out what he should do or shouldn't do. Then you have Polonius, who I particularly don't really like, says, "To thine own self be true," to his two children. But he doesn't follow that through in his play. There's an awful lot of, I suppose, inherent goodness, thoughts in the play. Then there's the actions that don't qualify with the thoughts that are being portrayed. You said about Fortinbras and Hamlet. The thing that, overwhelmingly, when I was trying to read the plays, is that the actions and the thoughts of the people in the play don't ever actually correlate to the same thing.
- 2.70** One of the things that I worry about is that, for people who don't think things through, but just go and do it, and the people who think too much, but don't do it, where is Shakespeare trying to find the balance between those two things in the characters? Because, ultimately, Fortinbras ends up on the throne, even though he's looking for revenge in a certain way for what happened in Norway. How do you, how does Shakespeare quantify and qualify those two things? Because, ultimately, Hamlet doesn't—he eventually kills Claudius, but he does it when Claudius has sunk to the lowest point possible and needs to die.
- 2.71** Absolutely. It's a very good question. Well, I think you've hit on it, and I think Shakespeare hit on it, insofar as he doesn't wrap things up nicely. I think continually, as you say, throughout the play, people are falling short of their own ideals, of what they would want to achieve. They don't carry through. Life goes in directions that no one really can predict or anticipate. But beyond that, there are the human failings that Shakespeare is grappling with. I think it's precisely that idea that he doesn't want to tie things up neatly, create a morality play, end up with the good guys winning and the bad

guys losing. He doesn't want to do that because life isn't like that. I think all of us fall short in this way.

2.72 It also points to this idea of life being essentially a struggle. I mean, you mentioned the most famous quotations from that play. "To be or not to be, that is the question, whether it is nobler in the mind to suffer the slings and arrows of outrageous fortune or to take up arms against a sea of troubles and, by opposing, end them." That is what we're dealing in life. "The slings and arrows of outrageous fortune." Whatever we do in life, we're going to be beset by the fates or whatever stepping in our way. Things will never go the way that we want them to go. Who was it who said that "life is what happens when you're busy making other plans"? Was that John Lennon? Someone like that. I think that's what Shakespeare is getting to there.

2.73 When you talk about Polonius, it's an interesting, he says, "To thine own self be true." We can take that as deeply profound wisdom, except that it's coming from Polonius, who isn't a deeply profound person. What that line is, really, is a cliché. He also says, "Neither a borrower nor a lender be." He gives Laertes all these clichéd advice, basically just maxims, really. I think we're not meant to take them too seriously because they are coming from Polonius, but also Polonius is a hypocrite. Polonius sends people to spy on his own son because he thinks his son is going to be a philanderer. He's a really interesting character, I think. I think he's annoying in all the right ways. I think he is a snoop. I think he pries into other people's business. I think he's pompous. I think he's quite funny, and I also think he's quite well meaning.

2.74 That's why I mentioned the interpretation by Alec Clunes in the 1964 BBC version, because I think he nails all of those things. Polonius can come across in performance as just such an irritating character that you just don't warm to him. I know that I get the impression you don't warm to him at all. But I think in the interpretation as presented by Alec Clunes in that performance, we do, and it's a weird feeling because you don't want to warm to him, and yet you do. And yet, even within that, even within the rattling off of clichés, he hits on a few points that are, in fact, deep profound wisdom, because wisdom does sometimes emerge in clichés, in the old stories that we all know. So I think that's deliberate as well. I think in short, what Shakespeare is doing in this play, with these ideals that are never realized, is simply exploring a universal truth.

2.75 This question is coming from someone who's only really familiar with Macbeth. You said that was one of his more early plays.

2.76 No, Macbeth's 1606.

2.77 OK. It seems that there was a lot less characters than in Hamlet. Do you think that you need more—is there a correlation between the amount of characters and the layers and the nuance of the plays? Even you could bring in Cain and Abel. That only, arguably, has three characters.

- 2.78** Well, some of the great stories in the Bible are rooted in the experiences of one or two people, small groups of people. Shakespeare is known for having vast cast numbers. OK, so even though the company at the time would have been maybe 10 to 12 actors, there can be up to 40 different roles. There are plenty of characters in Hamlet. A lot of them are minor characters, of course. In Macbeth, there are also a lot of characters as well. I don't think the number of characters particularly matters. I think what's important is the focus that Shakespeare puts upon those characters. In Hamlet, as I say, the focus is very much about this one man. The other characters are important, but it's so much through this one man, it's less of an ensemble piece.
- 2.79** For that, you might want to go to something like Twelfth Night, where you've got Maria, Toby Belch, Andrew Aguecheek. You've got all that group. You've got the twins. You've got Olivia. You've got Orsino who's in love with Olivia. You've got Malvolio who wants to marry Olivia. It works more on the level of farce, I suppose, where you've got these multiple subplots, and the characters are given equal weight. In Hamlet, the characters are not given equal weight, which is why it is so easy for someone like Olivier to simply cut out Rosencrantz and Guildenstern, because the play will still work, if you strip away some of those other characters. But what I would say is, none of those characters are incidental. Shakespeare has a brilliant habit of being able to invest even a minor character with two or three lines with his own personality, and it really is quite an astonishing thing to see. Any other questions?
- 2.80** This is a slightly leading question.
- 2.81** Oh, wow.
- 2.82** Do you think that Hamlet would be pleased to see Fortinbras take the throne, being that he's similar to his own father? The similarities between Fortinbras Junior and Hamlet Senior?
- 2.83** Well, that's a good question. Would Hamlet be pleased to see Fortinbras? Does he not resign the throne to him, in his final words? I'm —
- 2.84** He might have done. It's been a while since I read the play.
- 2.85** I'm pretty sure that he does do that. In that respect, and let's not forget, he sees Fortinbras approaching with his armies when he gives one of his soliloquies. So he's aware of this encroaching army coming, and by the end, I think he is more than happy to—well, I suppose not because of an affiliation with Fortinbras's experience, but I suppose what's more likely is the idea of the restoration of some kind of order, the idea that Claudius will no longer be king of Denmark.
- 2.86** More than that, he's dying at that point. Hamlet knows that he's going to die. I'm just wondering if he would oddly think that Fortinbras was better suited to the task than he would have been.

2.87 Certainly better suited than he is. I mean, you got to remember as well that Hamlet—we haven't really asked the question, why isn't Hamlet king? I think that's something that's worth considering. Hamlet probably should be, in terms of the order of succession, but it's not really entertained at any point. But I don't think he's a suitable king any more than Hamlet is a suitable avenger. I don't think he fulfills those roles, and I think he's perfectly aware that he doesn't fulfill those roles. Fortinbras has the qualities of a king, of a military leader, of a revenger. So if we were to speculate, I would think that Hamlet would consider the arrival of Fortinbras to be a positive development. Possibly relief.

Lecture 3: Lear's Lament

At a glance — King Lear and its bleak vision.

- 3.1** So in this lecture, I'm going to talk to you about King Lear. But before I get into that, I want to talk to you a little bit more about the genre of tragedy. Remember, we're talking about the age of Renaissance humanism. So the classics were seen very much as literary authorities. And when it comes to genre, that means we've got to go back to Aristotle, to Aristotle's Poetics, but also to Horace's The Art of Poetry. Aristotle is the most significant and the most relevant because he focuses exclusively on tragedy. And it's from Aristotle that Renaissance thinkers derived this concept that you've probably heard of, the concept of the classical unities — the unity of action, unity of time, unity of place. This is the idea that all tragedies should adhere to these three unities. So Ben Jonson, contemporary of Shakespeare, was a fan of this idea. Philip Sidney, the great courtier poet, wrote a text called An Apology for Poetry. And he complained in that, that the writers of his time were not observing the unities.
- 3.2** But Shakespeare doesn't do it. Shakespeare is not interested in that. You could say that the Tempest does observe the classical unities insofar as it has one significant action, arguably. If you take Prospero, reclaiming his role as the Duke of Milan, it takes place within a day, and it takes place in one location, on the island. But I think, apart from that single example, Shakespeare just does not observe the classical unities. He's got no interest in it. If you take something like Macbeth, I mean, that takes place chronologically over a 20-year period. Antony and Cleopatra, a full 10-year period. He's not doing it in a day. However, Shakespeare does fulfill a particular Aristotelian principle, which is that he does limit his tragedies to the high-born characters, people of high status. This is what Aristotle called the nobler sort of men. It has become a cliché to think of tragedy in terms of relating to a fall from grace. But although it's a cliché, there is some truth to that. In King Lear, this is especially prominent.
- 3.3** So I just want to talk to you about, very briefly, a few other terms from Aristotle, because they might come up in the subsequent lectures. And I want you to know what I mean when I talk about them. Firstly, there's the principle of peripeteia, or a reversal of fortune. Most tragedies have this occur in one form or another. If you take Timon of Athens, the Shakespeare play, Timon experiences the loss of all his wealth. Even though up to that point, he's behaved as though he'll never lose his wealth, he does lose his wealth. That's a reversal of fortune. It's explicitly stated in the play because the poet, a character of the poet, says, "Fortune, in her shift and change of mood, spurns down her late beloved."
- 3.4** Another term that's quite interesting is anagnorisis. Anagnorisis, a moment of revelation. Right? So, for instance, when Emilia, in Othello, reveals that she gave the handkerchief to Iago, there is a moment of realization. Anagnorisis. Catharsis is another term. Catharsis is a kind of purging of emotions. It's a term we still use. We often say

that things have a cathartic effect. And Hazlitt said that tragedy "opens the chambers of the human heart." Tragedy, as catharsis, means that it purifies us by moving us into a state of terror and pity. That's the idea of catharsis.

- 3.5 And then we have hamartia. Now this is often mistranslated as a fatal flaw—not quite what it means. People apply it to, for example, Macbeth, to his ambition. They say ambition is Macbeth's hamartia, his fatal flaw, or Hamlet's indecision. But what it really means in classical terms is a character who contributes to his own downfall in some way through an action or through a mistake. So let's park Aristotle at that point. I just want you to be aware of those four concepts because they will become relevant.
- 3.6 However, there are some broad ways of thinking about the notion of tragedy at the time that Shakespeare is writing, which might help you. Put very simplistically, a good way of thinking about it is that Shakespearean tragedy begins with order and ends with chaos. You might consider Shakespearean comedy as the precise reverse of this. A comedy begins with chaos and ends up in a state of order. Usually that is signified by marriage. This is why all Shakespeare comedies end in marriage, with the exception of *Love's Labour's Lost*, when the marriages are postponed. And it's possible that he did that in order to open the gateway for another sequel. And we do know that he wrote a play called *Love's Labour's Won*. So that might be why he did that. But you always get a marriage at the end of Shakespeare comedy.
- 3.7 At the end of *Merry Wives of Windsor*, you get a same-sex marriage. Interestingly enough, someone is duped into marrying a boy. And marriage often contains things at the end of comedy. So you can explore all kind of subversive ideas. But as long as harmony is restored by people getting married, it's absolutely fine. So you can have, for instance, in *Twelfth Night*, Antonio, who is clearly in love with Sebastian—well, that's all very well for the play, but you can't have a gay relationship blooming at the end of a play. That is contained by the fact that Sebastian ends up getting married. And so it's all fine. It almost gives Shakespeare an excuse to explore that subversive kind of relationship.
- 3.8 So let's consider *Macbeth*, if we're going with these terms in terms of tragedy as order becoming chaos. So in *Macbeth*, the play opens with an account of Macbeth's triumphs on the battlefield. He's given new titles. He is esteemed as a hero. And there we have order of a high-born man. By the end of the play, all that is gone. He's a tyrant. He's committed a series of murders. His wife has committed suicide. And he is eventually killed at the moment of his ultimate hubris. Complete fall from grace. So, the key thing to remember, then, when we're talking about Shakespearean genre, is that there aren't any rules, really. Aristotle's *Poetics*, although we think of them as very influential, and although they did seek to describe the key features of tragedy in his own time, that text wasn't actually all that influential by the time we get to 16th-century England.
- 3.9 Now, it was known about. You know, we were, as I say, we were living through the period of Renaissance humanism, when all these old texts were being discovered and

their influence was being disseminated. Philip Sidney, as I said, mentions Aristotle. Ben Jonson likes Aristotle. But we know that Shakespeare is not concerned with those kind of strictures. They are optional, in other words. And even if we settle on Chaucer's definition of tragedy—he's got a very useful definition in *The Monk's Tale*, from the *Canterbury Tales*—as "one who falls from prosperity into misery." That keeps it nice and simple. But Shakespeare even transcends that.

- 3.10** If we do see anagnorisis in his plays, the idea of—it isn't really so much a recognition of an external fact. You know, something like Oedipus, who suddenly discovers that, who his parents are, you know, he suddenly discovers that he has, in fact, married his own mother and killed his own father. That's going to be an awkward conversation. That's an anagnorisis, I suppose. But in Shakespeare, it's more about self-realization. Something occurs to a character that they didn't know before. We're going to see that very, very crucially in *King Lear*, as we take a closer look at it.
- 3.11** So there is a very famous line in *King Lear* that most people know, even if they haven't read the play, and it goes like this. "As flies to wanton boys are we to the gods? They kill us for their sport." It's pretty bleak. Now, that line is uttered by the Duke of Gloucester, who, in the previous scene, has just had his eyes plucked out. So you can understand his pessimism at that point. And there are many references to the gods in *King Lear*, but not a God. I think there's one reference to God in the whole play. Actually, gods are continually evoked, because this is pre-Christian England. It's set roughly 8th century BC. But are the gods really to blame? Are we just flies that are killed for sport by these boyish, impish gods? Is it really their fault? I mean, in *Macbeth*, we see how fate dictates the course of the action, if you choose to interpret it that way. But providence is another matter, a guiding hand from God.
- 3.12** Well, Shakespeare seemed to have quite a firm grasp of human nature, and in particular, he had a very firm grasp of the truth, the grim truth, that human beings don't really require gods to make their lives as awful as possible. They do it for themselves. And indeed, the evil that we see in *King Lear*, the evil that predominates in *King Lear*, very much is coming from the men and the women that inhabit the play, not from this external supernatural force. I'm going to speak in a later lecture about the nature of evil in Shakespeare's work, and I'm also going to ask you to keep one eye on the notion of moral ambiguity, which is very important. But he doesn't tend to reduce characters to mere ciphers of good versus bad, heroes and villains. This isn't something he generally does, but I would say that in *King Lear* we get a bit more of that. We find that the usual chiaroscuro of black and white, dark and light, it's lacking in this landscape.
- 3.13** The moral representation tends to fall down in these very stark contradistinctions. There are quite clearly good characters. There are quite clearly evil characters. That's not to say they don't have their own moral ambiguities. If you take the way the Duke of Albany changes during the play and finds some sort of redemption, that gives you an

example of that. In William Hazlitt's book, *The Characters of Shakespeare's Plays*, he quotes Schlegel as saying that Shakespeare "unites in his genius the utmost elevation and the utmost depth." The utmost elevation and the utmost depth. I think that's King Lear in a nutshell.

- 3.14** As I say, there are characters that broadly align with good. If you think about Lear, Cordelia, Edgar, Kent, the fool. On the other side, we have characters who seem almost irredeemable. Goneril. Her ratlike, repugnant steward Oswald, one of the most awful characters in Shakespeare. You've got Regan and the Duke of Cornwall, of course. And above all, Edmund. And I think, with the exception of Iago in *Othello*, Edmund comes closest to a kind of personification of malevolence. And yet, even he, towards the end of the play, when he is dying, tries to make amends. He tries to redeem himself by saving Cordelia—although, as he does so, he points out that it is against his nature to do so. And, of course, the attempt fails in any case. Cordelia does not survive.
- 3.15** By the way, Harold Bloom, the critic Harold Bloom, believed that Edmund was a representation of Christopher Marlowe. Or perhaps a representation of one of Marlowe's villains. He writes very interestingly about the influence of Marlowe on Shakespeare. It's worth reading. Another good writer on that is A. L. Rowse. And Bloom said that Edmund "out-lagos Iago." Being a strategist rather than an improviser, he says he is "the coldest personage in all Shakespeare." Colder than Iago? I'm not so sure about that. We will get to Iago when we move on to *Othello*.
- 3.16** Now, most of you are going to be familiar with the story of King Lear, the basic story. An elderly king decides to retire and to divide his kingdom between his three daughters. One thing to note is he's a very successful king. He's reigned for an awful long time. The country is not at war. Very unusual aspect. And this is very important because Lear, as a character, is often maligned by his critics. People don't really warm to him, not really until Act 3. He starts out as being quite prideful, quite impetuous, certainly vain. But I think it is important to acknowledge that he is a good king. He is a successful king. And he is a well-respected king. He's particularly respected by the likes of Kent, for instance. We see through Kent's eyes what a noble figure Lear is. Lear's nobility is important. Otherwise, the fall does not have an impact.
- 3.17** His two eldest daughters, Goneril and Regan, have already married very well. Right, they've married to the Duke of Albany and the Duke of Cornwall. Another sign of success. The king of France and the Duke of Burgundy are vying for the hand of Cordelia, the youngest daughter. All of this suggests a successful reign. Now, I've spoken about the way in which Shakespearean tragedy takes this kind of harmonious situation, breaks it apart, reduces it to chaos, annihilates it. King Lear is quite exceptional in that this disintegration begins right at the opening of the play. And it all begins because of a single mistake that King Lear makes, which arises from his vanity, his pride.

- 3.18** He's already decided, really, how his kingdom is going to be divided. He's already made that choice. We know this. But he insists on putting on a kind of show, a public show, where he wants his daughters to each, one by one, publicly declare how much they love him. OK? It's pure vanity, isn't it? And in turn, he says he's going to reward them with their share of the kingdom. So first, Goneril stands up, and Goneril says, "Sir, I love you more than words can wield the matter; dearer than eyesight, space, and liberty; beyond what can be valued, rich or rare. No less than life; with grace, health, beauty, honor; as much as child e'er loved or father found; a love that makes breath poor and speech unable." Now, this is obviously hyperbolic. Does it really, does her love really make her speech unable? She is, after all, speaking. "Beyond all manner of so much I love you."
- 3.19** Not very convincing, is it? And Cordelia stands there, and in an aside, which is a Shakespearean conceit where a character says something and the others do not hear, Cordelia says, "What shall Cordelia speak? Love and be silent." Cordelia knows she's not going to be able to lie in the way that Goneril just has. So Goneril is duly rewarded for a flattery. She gets her third of the kingdom, and Regan comes up next to perform. Regan. And she decides to build upon what Goneril has said and thereby exceed these false declarations.
- 3.20** So Regan says, "I am made of that self mettle as my sister." I'm the same. So everything that she's just said, I'm the same. "And prize me at her worth. In my true heart, I find she names my very deed of love—only she comes too short." In other words, when my sister spoke, she wasn't, she was, well, speaking for me effectively, but she didn't do it well enough. So this is pretty shameless. So it's like going up there and saying, "Oh, what she just said, but better." She says, "That I profess myself an enemy to all other joys, which the most precious square of sense possesses, and find I am alone felicitate in your dear highness's love." Right. It seems unlikely.
- 3.21** Cordelia, another aside. "Then, poor Cordelia—and yet not so, since I am sure my love's more ponderous than my tongue." I'm sure my love is more profound, more permanent, than what I can speak. So she says, "Poor Cordelia, not poor Cordelia," because her love is authentic, whereas Goneril and Regan are happy to dissemble. They don't really love their father. This is one of the horrible realizations of the play, is about what happens when parents are not loved by their children. And it is about facing that horrible reality that some kids do not love their parents. There are continual references to ingratitude being "worse than the serpent's tooth." You'll remember this.
- 3.22** And Goneril and Regan are happy. They've got no compunction about declaring how much they love him, if it serves their purposes. Regan's statement, I think, is particularly ridiculous. She says she professes herself an enemy to all other joys because she loves Lear so much that she's incapable of loving anything else. That is so improbable that you would hope that Lear can see through that. And surely he does. But it's his pride that he's relishing this, because it's a public declaration. It's public

praise. He's enjoying—his ego is being satisfied too much. So it doesn't matter that they're lying, and it doesn't matter that Lear knows that they're lying. He doesn't know that they don't love him. But he knows certainly that she has other things she might be capable of loving.

3.23 Anyway, it comes to Cordelia's turn, and this is the key moment. This is, I suppose, the reversal of fortune, the *peripeteia*. When it comes to Cordelia's turn, well, she's the only one who really does love him. She's the only one who really does honor him. But she also owes a duty of love and honor to the man who will become her husband. And really, what this is, on her part, I think, this reluctance to perform —what it is is a gentle rebuke to her father, I think. It's a refusal to engage in what today we would call virtue signaling. She doesn't want to be a virtue signaler, right? She is virtuous. She does not need to declare her virtue. And therefore we get this exchange.

3.24 Lear says, "What can you say to draw a third more opulent than your sisters?" What can you say to get a better third of the kingdom? "Speak." And Cordelia says, "Nothing, my lord." Lear: "Nothing!" And Cordelia says, "Nothing." Lear says, "Nothing will come of nothing. Speak again." He wants her to say something praiseworthy and, of course, she doesn't. And following this exchange, he turns her away. She, as we know, marries the king of France, who leaps to her defense. And Lear's most faithful servant, the Earl of Kent, tries to stand up for Cordelia, but so angry and humiliated is Lear that he also banishes Kent.

3.25 Now, that word "nothing", you heard it there numerous times. The word nothing recurs in the early parts of *King Lear* constantly. It's as frequent as the word blood appears in *Macbeth*. Shakespeare often leaves these little thematic fingerprints, I suppose, in the text. Nothing. Why nothing? This is a play that has been called nihilistic, a play that has been called godless. Nothingness. It's a play that, it can swallow you up in a sense of complete despair, in a sense of the complete futility of human existence. This word, nothing, says so much.

3.26 Now, this particular exchange, "Nothing shall come of nothing," is then echoed in Act 1, Scene 4, by the fool. The fool is a very interesting character, very important character. You know that traditionally the court jester is able to say whatever they want and they won't lose their head. That is the privilege of the fool. You always know a tyrant because the first thing they do is they kill the comedian. They kill the fool. A lot of people are trying to do this at the moment, metaphorically speaking, and it is a sign of tyranny. Authoritarians cannot bear to be laughed at. The fool is the only person at court who can say to Lear, "This is where you're going wrong. This is what makes you an idiot." And he can get away with it. OK? Very important character.

3.27 Now, when there's a point at which the fool is doing one of his many silly little songs, and it's a song which is a litany of clichés, axioms, the kind of thing that Polonius would say, but in song form. And we now have this. Kent says, "This is nothing, fool," as in, "This, all of this stuff, is just clichés, nothing. Pointless." The fool says then, "Tis like the

breath of an unfeed lawyer. You gave me nothing for it." He says to Lear, "Can you make no use of nothing, nuncle?" Lear says, "Why, no, boy. Nothing can be made out of nothing." We have the echo of this theme. The fool, of course, is the great truth-teller. OK?

3.28 Now, there are some risks. Lear actually threatens him occasionally with whipping, but he is tolerated, and he bluntly tells Lear, "You're an idiot. You should be the fool. You should wear my jester's cap, my coxcomb. You're the one who's given away your kingdom. You've divided it now in two with the two daughters who hate you. You're an idiot." He says it very, very bluntly. He's threatened with whipping, but he says it anyway. And then he says, "Truth's a dog must to kennel. He must be whipped out when the Lady Brach may stand by the fire and stink." Brach is a word for bitch. So while the truth-telling dog is thrown outdoors to the kennel in disgrace—perhaps a premonition of the hovel in the storm in which they later huddled together—the Lady Brach, the bitch of flattery, she can warm herself by the fire, her stink permeating the household. That's what he's saying to her, to Lear.

3.29 And when Lear fears that he might be going mad because of how his daughters have treated him, this is a major fear of Lear. He says, "I will lose my mind." He's terrified of it. And, of course, it does happen, because this is the play in which the very worst things happen to the best people. It is even worse that he anticipates his lunacy. Now, the fool, however, doesn't console him. The fool just keeps reminding him that it is his own fault. OK, he says to him, "You can cry about this all you like, but it's too late." I'll give you an example. He compares Lear's state with this folk tale. Lear is crying out, "Oh me, my heart! My rising heart." He keeps talking about this hysterical condition where he feels his heart is moving around his body. Because the origins of hysteria are the idea of the womb moving around the body, which is where we get the phrase hysteria, hysterectomy. You know, it's connected to it. It's also connected to the idea of why people felt at this time that women were capable of hysteria, of high emotional states. OK? That's where that cliché comes from.

3.30 He talks about his heart moving around his body, and he cries down. He wants the heart to go down. He feels himself going mad. The fool says, "Cry to it, nuncle, as the cockney did to the eels when she put them in the paste alive. She knapped among the coxcombs with a stick, and cried, 'Down, wantons, down!'" Takes a little explanation. The idea is, a cockney chef is baking a pie of eels. But she doesn't want to hurt the eels. She doesn't want to beat them to death before putting them in the pie. So she just puts them in alive. And then as they keep writhing up, she just hits them on the head, the coxcombs, the jester's hat, and says, "Down, down, down." OK, so the fool is mocking the idea of one who is kindhearted, too kindhearted, and then has to pay the price.

3.31 The fool also mentions the cockney's brother, right? And this is one who, in pure kindness to his horse, buttered his hay. This is a very well-intentioned gesture. You like your horse, you're going to butter the hay. But of course, a horse does not like buttered

hay. And any more than Regan and Goneril will be grateful for their father's kindness, or indeed repay it when he asks for shelter. King Lear is the closest that Shakespeare comes to representing a nihilistic worldview. I've said that it could be described as a godless time, or at least a time of many gods, the kind of gods that we might have read about in Milton's *Paradise Lost*—in hell, when he describes the counterfeit gods, in other words, demons. All of the ancient gods of classical antiquity in Milton are explained away as being demons in disguise, effectively. This is the pagan world that we're inhabiting now in *King Lear*.

- 3.32** But not only does Shakespeare present to us through *King Lear* a world without the blessing of Christ, he allows us to descend into a kind of hell on earth, most notably the famous raging storm of Act 3, Scene 2. Again, people who haven't read the play know of this storm. It's depicted in all sorts of famous paintings and artwork. It's one of the most powerful and disturbing and destabilizing theatrical scenes ever penned. So after being turned away by both sisters, Lear finds himself outside in the storm, raging against the elements, and he cries out, "Blow, winds, and crack your cheeks! Rage, blow, you cataracts and hurricanoes, spout till you have drenched our steeples, drowned the cocks! You sulfurous and thought-executing fires, vaunt-couriers of oak-cleaving thunderbolts, singe my white head; and thou all-shaking thunder, strike flat the thick rotundity of the world. Crack nature's molds, all germens spill at once that makes ingrateful man."
- 3.33** So he's talking here of germens—germs, seeds, the seeds of life. It's a sense that he's lost everything. He's lost his mind, he's lost his kingdom, he's lost the only daughter that he loved. And so what he is saying is, humankind may as well be wiped out. All the seeds of life might be destroyed, and it wouldn't matter. "Crack nature's molds." We don't need to reproduce anymore. And even the end of the world itself—he's calling on thunderbolts to "strike flat the thick rotundity of the world." But of course, the elements owe him nothing. He is a king. But against the storm, what is he? He's just another insect to be crushed. And he acknowledges his impotence here. He acknowledges that he owes the storm nothing.
- 3.34** He says, "Rumble thy bellyful; spit, fire; spout, rain. Nor rain, wind, thunder, fire are my daughters. I tax you not, you elements, with unkindness. I never gave you kingdom, called you children. You owe me no subscription. Then let fall your horrible pleasure. Here I stand your slave, a poor, infirm, weak and despised old man." Lear has come to the realization of his folly remarkably quickly. Already at this point in the play, he knows that he has wronged Cordelia. It has driven him mad. But Lear finds clarity through his insanity. This is a very interesting innovation because Lear's madness didn't exist in any previous versions of the story. *King Lear* is a very old story. It's been told many times. Shakespeare adds this element. He makes him mad, in order to lead him to the possibility of redemption.

- 3.35** Shakespeare has Edgar, the son of Gloucester, perform madness as Poor Tom, which, when Lear sees Poor Tom, this is a frightening and enlightening experience. Suddenly he sees this naked wretch as some kind of philosopher. He asks him that common philosophical question. "What is the cause of thunder?" Lear realizes it doesn't matter about his clothes and the trappings of nobility. He removes his clothes. He becomes naked in the storm, like Poor Tom. And it's through their shared madness that he sees that the dignities of rank and nobility, these are all just illusions. In this mindscape, they're able to put Regan and Goneril on trial, a fantasy trial, with a joint-stool.
- 3.36** In madness, you see, at least there is the possibility of justice. If you live in an unjust world, perhaps only insanity can make it just. The fool also talks like a madman. But maybe it takes a madman to confront the truth. We're all held back by social convention. Sometimes the truth is unutterable. But if you let go of that, if you have no inhibitions, if you have no regard for decorum and convention, maybe the truth comes out, and we're back to Hamlet, aren't we? Where madness serves a function. It's the means by which the horror of reality can be momentarily escaped. It's why people get drunk, I think.
- 3.37** By the time Cordelia rejoins Lear in Act 4, he is fully repentant. He's gone through this incredible process, through the storm, through madness, through rejection. And he is broken. And when he sees Cordelia, he can't believe that he is seeing her. He can't believe it's her. I think this is one of the most poignant scenes in all of Shakespeare, and it occurs at the end of Act 4. And Cordelia says, "You must not kneel." Lear says, "Pray do not mock. I am a very foolish, fond old man, fourscore and upward, not an hour more nor less. And to deal plainly, I fear I am not in my perfect mind." He's emerging from the insanity, but he thinks that it's lingering. He's terrified of this.
- 3.38** He says, "Methinks I should know you, and know this man." Presumably Kent. "Yet I am doubtful, for I am mainly ignorant what place this is; and all the skill I have remembers not these garments, nor I know not where I did lodge last night. Do not laugh at me, for as I am as a man, I think this lady to be my child, Cordelia." Cordelia says, "And so I am, I am." Lear says, "Be your tears wet? Yes, faith, I pray; weep not. If you have poison for me, I will drink it. I know you do not love me; for your sisters have, as I do remember, done me wrong. You have some cause. They have not." And she simply says, "No cause, no cause." Lear says, "Am I in France?" Kent tells him, "In your own kingdom, sir." Lear cannot believe it. He just says, "Do not abuse me."
- 3.39** It really is an astonishingly painful scene, because we hear his terrible self-realization. He cannot allow himself to accept what he now sees. His loving daughter returned, willing to forgive him. She already has forgiven him. There was nothing to forgive. And those lines tear at us. We end up sharing in his agony. Those horrible lines. "Pray do not mock. Do not laugh at me. I know you do not love me. Do not abuse me." He's pleading with us, as well as her. It is heart-wrenching. This great king has fallen so low. And this is his moment of realization. This is his anagnorisis, if you want to use the Aristotelian

term. This is an idea that the critic Peter Sacchar has written about, that this is this key moment in the play.

3.40 Now, King Lear, as a play, is relentlessly tough on the audience. Also, it's relentlessly tough on its characters. Just when you think things can't get any worse, they get worse. And it happens again and again and again. Now, which makes it very unsettling. And it makes it very strange when it's performed. It feels actually like a kind of trial. You're watching this play, and it's almost like a test of endurance. And you think, why am I sitting through this? Now, I think a modern equivalent is a film by Michael Haneke called Funny Games. I don't know if you've seen this film. It was made in 1997. It was remade 10 years later in English. And this is a film that tests your endurance. It's a film about two young men who break into a family's house, a married couple and their small boy, and proceed to torture them psychologically, physically, and eventually murder them.

3.41 And it is brutal and horrible and grim. But during the film, the two home invaders, they keep turning to the camera and they look at you, the audience, one of them says, "I know whose side you're on. I know you want them to win. It's not going to happen." They're effectively asking you, "Why are you watching this? Why are you sitting through this? This is a horrible film. Why are you watching it?" It is Michael Haneke effectively berating you for enjoying violent films, and having his cake and eating it, because he's also giving you a really violent film. It's an odd film. It's not his best, actually. But I think it's interesting. It's interesting because it depicts gruesome violence and then berates you for watching the film.

3.42 And we might get some of that when we watch King Lear. We might get a sense of that as well, that Shakespeare is just putting us through the worst thing he can imagine. Right? I do get that sense from it because the horror just doesn't let up, right? It feels like we're being brutalized deliberately. First, the king is told by his daughter Goneril, he can't have his knights staying there. He's got to cut his retinue in half. Eventually, Regan is saying, "Well, why do you even need one knight? Why not nothing?" Right? And then that inhospitality, that ingratitude, it's repeated. It doesn't just happen once. It happens with Goneril, but then it happens with Regan. Same thing. It's compounding the horrific experience. The only daughter he did love and who loved him is off in France. His retainer, Kent, he's banished, although he comes back in disguise to serve him. But he gets put in the stocks and humiliated, which also, by extension, by proxy, humiliates Lear.

3.43 Goneril and Regan turn Lear out into the storm with his fall. Lear goes mad. He rages at the storm. And even when he is eventually reunited with Cordelia, the ensuing conflict results in her death. She is hanged. He dies of a broken heart while cradling her corpse. Now, none of this happens in the earlier versions of Lear. Cordelia actually lives. Lear becomes king again. He regains his crown. Shakespeare changed it, right? Why? We really should think about that. Does he just want you to suffer? Is that all it is?

- 3.44 By the way, it's not just that all of this happens to Lear. All of it happens twice. There is a secondary plot. There is a subplot with the Duke of Gloucester, which entirely mirrors the plot of Lear. The things that happened to Lear happen to Gloucester. The ingratitude of the child happens again to Gloucester, by his bastard son, Edmund, who concocts this plot where he pretends that his brother Edgar has written him a letter conspiring against the father. And the father believes it. Again, like Lear, the father makes a bad choice, trusts the wrong child. It is the same plot played out twice, right? Shakespeare is trying to grind you into the dirt with this stuff. And, of course, what happens to the Duke of Gloucester? Well, he's accused of treason for assisting Lear's flight to France, and Cornwall tears out his eyes.
- 3.45 And even in that scene, it gets worse as he goes along. It's not as though his eyes are just torn out, and that's the end of it. No, one eye gets torn out. And then a servant of Cornwall says, "I can't let you do this." There's a fight. This goes on for a while. The servant is killed, and only then does he tear out the other eye. It's like everything is protracted. Every horrible thing is drawn out as long as possible. Now, some people have found that gratuitous. I mean, it's certainly the most violent on-stage scene, I think, in Shakespeare.
- 3.46 Tolstoy hated this play. Tolstoy wrote a very famous essay attacking the play. One of his objections is that he felt that the plot contains too many implausible events, inconsistencies. I've already warned you against this. This is the wrong way to read Shakespeare. Shakespeare wasn't writing realistic novels. Realism is not of interest to him. King Lear is a poem. Now, you know—and he's right. The plot line is implausible. There's no way that the Duke of Gloucester would believe that one of his sons has written to the other son to conspire against him. Why would he write the letter? They live in the same house, right? It's totally implausible. But it doesn't matter, because the point of it is not the plausibility of the scenario. The point of it is to re-echo the plot line of Lear. Right. Very important that you understand that.
- 3.47 To give you another example of this, we have the scene in which Gloucester, having been blinded, decides to kill himself. He is led to a precipice, or what he thinks is a precipice, but it isn't. It's just a floor. And Edgar, who is disguised as Poor Tom, leads him here and says, and describes the view of the precipice and the sheer drop, and simulates death. Gloucester thinks he has fallen, but he simply stands and he's alive and well. No one would believe that, but poetically, this is really effective —the simulated death and his spiritual rebirth that comes about because of it. Very powerful. By the way, if you want to read the best rebuttal to Tolstoy's essay, it was written by George Orwell in 1947. Fantastic essay. Well worth reading.
- 3.48 Now, let's have a closer look at Lear's death scene. This is very important. It's one of the most unbearable scenes in Shakespeare. It's horrible. Now, he's cradling the dead Cordelia. None of this was inevitable, by the way. So, I mean, I've mentioned tragic inevitability. It didn't have to happen this way. The play could have ended very

differently. Shakespeare chooses that this is how it's going to end. He walks in, cradling the dead Cordelia, and listen to what he says. He says, "She's gone forever. I know when one is dead and when one lives. She's dead as earth. Lend me a looking glass. If that her breath will mist or stain the stone, why, then she lives."

3.49 So he's moving from a recognition that she's dead to this desperate illusion that, no, she might be alive. He wants to hold a mirror to her mouth to see if the breath appears. He goes from one extreme to the other. He then puts a feather to her mouth, and he thinks he sees it move. He says, "This feather stirs. She lives." We don't know if he has an actual mirror, an actual feather. In some productions, he does. In some productions, he's imagining these props. Either way, you get this sense of, he can't quite believe she's dead. One moment, and then another moment, he's completely accepting the horror that she is dead.

3.50 And then he says, "A plague upon you, murderers, traitors all. I might have saved her. Now she's gone forever. Cordelia, Cordelia, stay a little." It's an incredibly touching line. "Ha? What is thou sayest? Her voice was ever soft, gentle, and low, an excellent thing in woman." He hears her speak. She can't speak. She's dead. Or is she? He doesn't know. He's all over the place. And then that heartbreaking final moment, and he says, "And my poor fool is hanged." Does he mean that his fool is dead? We haven't heard from the fool for quite a while. A couple of acts, maybe. Maybe the fool is dead as well. Why not? It's that sort of play. Or is he using the word fool as a term of endearment for the daughter, for Cordelia? That was common at the time, possibly that. Most critics think he is talking about Cordelia here. Or is he confusing the two? There was a theatrical tradition that the fool and Cordelia were played by the same actor in Jacobean times. That would make sense.

3.51 And he says, "No, no, no life? Why should a dog, a horse, a rat have life, and thou no breath at all? Thou'lt come no more. Never, never, never, never, never." We often talk about Shakespeare's heightened poetic imagery, but sometimes it's just the simplicity of the language that is most potent. That word never, repeated five times. Very moving in its simplicity, because there are no other words for this horror. Or if there are words, he cannot find them. And finally, at the end, there is this incredible ambiguity. Does she stir? Does he think she stirs? He says, "Do you see this? Look on her. Look, her lips. Look there, look there." And he dies. Now, we don't really know what he saw, but I suppose it doesn't matter. What we do know is that he has died of a broken heart.

3.52 Now, we're accustomed in literature to this notion of poetic justice, right? So, in fact, we're really accustomed to it. Whenever we go and see films, we expect the bad guys to get their comeuppance. It's really normal. We're a bit dissatisfied when that doesn't happen, I think. Poetic justice. Now, William Shakespeare generally isn't interested in poetic justice, I suppose. In the comedies, you get an element of that. Don John, in *Much Ado About Nothing*, gets his comeuppance. The villains generally do. Malvolio

does. But like I say, that has ambiguity as well. But life doesn't work like that. And in King Lear, the very worst things happen, as I say, happen to the best people.

3.53 Now, Samuel Johnson, who is one of the most renowned critics of Shakespeare, one of the most astute critics, he hated this. He didn't like the play because it doesn't have poetic justice, and people found it very uncomfortable. So much so that the play was rewritten in 1681 by a man called Nahum Tate. And he changed it. He changed the ending. So, not only does Cordelia live, she gets married to Edgar. King Lear gets his throne back. The fool isn't in there. Just changed it. He makes the whole play happy, gives it a happy ending. And I think theater-goers were relieved by this, because that was the version of the play that lasted on stage in England for the next 160 years. People didn't watch Shakespeare's version. David Garrick, the very, very famous Shakespearean actor, only ever played the Nahum Tate version of Lear. It just wasn't there. By the time Hazlitt's writing about it, it's just been basically rediscovered, I suppose. So, and Samuel Johnson preferred Nahum Tate's version. It was the sanitized version, because Shakespeare had offended his perception of poetic justice.

3.54 Now, by the time we get to the end of Act 4, I think most of us want the play to end. Not because we're bored—well, I hope not, anyway—but because things seem to have gone back to normal. We get a sense of restored order, right? Gloucester has been reunited with Edgar. Edgar has cured Gloucester of his despair. That horrendous character, Oswald, who I really hate, he's dead, which is great. And, you know, and Cordelia and Lear are reunited, and it's really beautiful. But no, we have to watch Act 5, don't we? And everything falls apart, and everything becomes worse than ever it was. However, there is another way to look at it. And I go back to that book I mentioned, Shakespearean Tragedy, written in 1904 by A. C. Bradley, because he puts across a really good argument about this.

3.55 His argument is that the essence of King Lear is about the notion of redemption. This play, as I've said, presents us with a nihilistic, bleak, mephitic world where the worst things happen. And even when things get really bad, it goes further. There's even—that's even commented on in the play, because Edgar, at the start of Act 4, he says, and I quote, "Yet better thus and known to be condemned than still condemned and flattered. To be worst, the lowest and most dejected thing of fortune, stands still in Esperance," as in hope, "lives not in fear. The lamentable change is from the best. The worst returns to laughter. Welcome, then, thou unsubstantial air that I embrace. The wretch that thou hast blown unto the worst owes nothing to thy blasts."

3.56 Being at your lowest ebb is fine, because things cannot get any worse. But who enters immediately? His dad, with his eyes ripped out. So, he acknowledges at that point that actually you can never say things aren't going to get any worse. OK? Living a virtuous life is no protection against bad things happening to you. What is Shakespeare trying to say here? What's going on? Why the continual references in this play that liken mankind to beasts, to grubs, to insects? Why does Lear look at the naked Edgar

disguised as Poor Tom and say, "Is man no more than this?" And then he says, "Unaccommodated man is no more but such a poor, bare, forked animal as thou art." Is he suggesting that we are condemned to live and die in quick succession, for no purpose whatsoever, in a world where the gods don't care? Is there an implication that the relentless evil actions of his characters are not so much immoral as amoral, because we are all just beasts?

3.57 But Bradley says no. Bradley says this is not the way to read the play. And I think he's got a point. You could read it either way. I think the play is effective either way. But this is his point. He says there is a point to the suffering in *King Lear*. He says it isn't merely the gods toying with us. We're not just flies to the gods, as Gloucester says. This is what Bradley says. I'm going to quote it in full because I think it really hits the nail on the head.

3.58 He says, "There is nothing more noble and beautiful in literature than Shakespeare's exposition of the effect of suffering in reviving the greatness and eliciting the sweetness of Lear's nature. The rage of the storm," writes Bradley, "awakes a power and a poetic grandeur surpassing even that of Othello's anguish. Lear, whose sight is so purged by scalding tears that it sees at last how power and place and all things in the world are vanity except love; who tastes in his last hours the extremes both of love's rapture and of its agony, but could never, if he lived on or lived again, care a jot for aught beside. There is no figure, surely, in the world of poetry at once so grand, so pathetic, and so beautiful as this."

3.59 Now, I've quoted that in full because I think he's right. I think Shakespeare seems to ask us throughout this play, how do we deal with the tragedy of existence? So Edgar, throughout the play, is in disguise as Poor Tom. He's been calling out all the time. You'll remember he continually talks about the fiend. He's been chased by the fiend. He describes the fiend as this devil that is seeking us out, right? He says to his father, he says, "His eyes were two full moons. He had a thousand noses. Horns whelked and waved like the enrag'd sea. It was some fiend." So there is a fiend, and it's not the devil, and it's not death. It's despair.

3.60 Our understanding of our own mortality makes this inevitable. We are the only creature who knows that we are going to die. And so, there is a sense in which we're always on the brink of despair, pretty much all of the time. Everyone, at some point in their life, will ask themselves, what is the point? What is the point of anything? What is the point of living? And perhaps that spirit of despair is the fiend that Edgar mentions so frequently—this omnipresent, malevolent spirit that is haunting us always, this nagging doubt of the purpose of our own lives. But through the suffering of Lear, we might glimpse that there is another way. Or maybe this notion that the play offers redemption is just another illusion. Maybe Bradley is wrong. Maybe it is as nihilistic and godless as we initially thought.

- 3.61** After Lear and Cordelia are defeated and captured, Edgar rushes in, and he tells his father the news. This is Act 5, Scene 2. And I'm just going to close with this. Edgar says, "Away, old man. Give me thy hand. Away. King Lear hath lost, he and his daughter taken. Give me thy hand. Come on." Gloucester: "No further, sir. A man may rot even here." Doesn't matter where I go. I'm going to die anyway. You're going to die. Everything's going to die. Edgar says, "What, in ill thought again? Men must endure their going hence, even as their coming hither. Ripeness is all. Come on." And Gloucester says, "And that's true, too." Yes, life will be full of horror. That is unavoidable. And, yes, we must endure. What other choice do we have?
- 3.62** Thanks very much. Any questions?
- 3.63** You mentioned a few times that Shakespeare kind of breaks these literary rules or kind of maybe blurs the boundaries a wee bit with them. Do you think that's intentional to create these more autonomous, realistic characters? Or do you think that it's just a natural consequence of he's creating these autonomous characters, and so naturally, these literary rules get broken because it's more reflective of—?
- 3.64** Yeah, I think that's very interesting. I think, to be honest, it's probably that Shakespeare is a free thinker. He's a great artist. Artists don't generally like to be confined. I think that's really what it's about, you know. Great artists always move things forward. And that said, you know, the parameters of literary convention can be really wonderful things within which to create and within which to flourish. If you need evidence of that, just read Shakespeare's sonnets. You know, these are very strict sonnets. They're written with the octave and the sestet, the right number of lines, iambic pentameter; all of the rules are obeyed. But he completely revolutionizes the form in a really interesting way.
- 3.65** I think, when he comes to the plays, yeah, he's working within certain parameters, certain conventions of the time, and he seems to delight in modifying those conventions as he goes along. Reinventing it. I suppose, shocking people, ensuring that the audiences and the readers are not complacent, I think, is the mark of a true artist. I think what he does is not just reinvent the genre, he improves the genre. So I think it could be as simple as that, that it's to do with the creativity of the mind of genius.
- 3.66** You mentioned that he's never gone to the university. Do we know how he felt about it, whether he was upset about not being able to go to the university or not? And do you think it played a role in his authenticity that he wasn't, for the lack of a better word, indoctrinated into?
- 3.67** Well, we don't know what he thought about anything, really. You know, playwrights today, we know a lot about them. They're celebrities, you know. They write books and do interviews. We don't have any diaries of Shakespeare. We have accounts from his friends. In the First Folio, which I mentioned, there's lots of tributes written to Shakespeare from various friends and other colleagues in the theater industry. There

are some things that we learn from that. He's continually referred to as "gentle, gentle Shakespeare." His character appears to be one who was gentle, accommodating, that kind of thing. But we really don't know all that much. Various stories have been passed down. What he felt about not going to university, we don't know at all. He couldn't because he was married, anyway. But like I said, it wasn't, you know, that was a route of, a particular type of route. For instance, the clergy would take that route.

3.68 We don't know whether he resented Anne Hathaway. A lot of it is just surmise. What I do find interesting when it comes to Anne Hathaway, you know, he'd married this older woman when he's 18. I get this is total speculation, right? I get the impression he didn't like her all that much, and I could be completely wrong, and I'm willing to acknowledge that straight away. But the thing is, he moved to London and barely saw her for his entire adult life. After the twins were born—he had the three kids, twins and the other child—went off to London, became an actor. He was probably bisexual. The sonnets would suggest he was in an affair with a young man. When he dies, he leaves most of the money to Susanna and John. He leaves his wife the second-best bed. Although it was a nice bed, a lot of people will say, "The second-best bed? That was the best bed, and that was a bed for the guests." Yeah. I mean, you know, it's not—in fact, if you look at the will, the reference to the second-best bed is in between lines. It's like an afterthought.

3.69 We don't get the impression that he liked her all that much. And the other thing about that is, if you go to his grave, which I would urge you to do, he's not buried with his wife. I think that's kind of interesting. They'd normally be in the same plot, but you don't get that. You actually get a curse. There's a curse on Shakespeare's tomb. It's the last poem he ever wrote. Let me see if I can get this. He says, "Good friend, for Jesus' sake, forbear to dig the dust enclosed here. Blessed be the man who spares these stones, and cursed be he that moves my bones." What he's saying is, "You can't open this grave and put my wife in." Maybe, maybe. I don't know. But I just think there's something to it. It's a lot of fun speculating about Shakespeare because there's quite a lot of information about it, but there are huge gaps. So that, to answer your question in a roundabout way, is, I don't know.

3.70 You mentioned Shakespeare and sonnets, that they were written within certain parameters. I wonder, is there some sort of importance of tempo-rhythm in his place to convey certain emotional charge? And if so, are there any patterns in terms of how the tempo-rhythm would change when we would go into a theme of revenge or despair or fear or love?

3.71 Absolutely. In fact, Shakespeare's attention to detail when it comes to rhythms, meter, verse, form, is really, really pronounced. And broadly speaking, the convention of the time is that plays are written in iambic pentameter. What we mean by that is, there are 5 metrical feet per line, 5 beats per line, 5 stressed syllables, iambs. So to give an example, it would sound like dun-dun, dun-dun. Right, and that's the line. That's the

line form. Now, that's the basic kind of broad structure. Of course, Shakespeare's continually changing that and adding in different stresses at different points, but he does broadly follow that.

3.72 But having said that, often in the plays, the characters speak in prose, and this does denote something. So, the verse is for generalized dialogue, but also it lends a kind of gravitas to what is being said. When you have low-born characters, the fool, for instance, or the plebeians in Julius Caesar, then they speak in prose. They don't have the verse. I'm going to come onto this at a later lecture when I talk about Julius Caesar, because I think it's very important. So he does really observe this kind of thing. When we come to editing Shakespeare, it can be quite difficult, because the compositors sometimes miss the verse and they write it in prose, and the editors have to kind of work out whether a certain passage is prose or verse, because it's blank verse, of course. A lot of the time it doesn't rhyme. Sometimes it does. Richard II is full of rhyme. Romeo and Juliet is full of rhyme. But there are choices made about rhythm, and there are choices made about verse form, that reflect what is going on in the language.

3.73 And you get a kind of, a lot of broken rhythms. So the way Coriolanus speaks, he has a very broken kind of style. He struggles with eloquence. That's quite important for his character, because Coriolanus, his main flaw is that he cannot speak to the people. He cannot get them on side. He doesn't want to. He's totally dismissive of them. So it's quite apt that he should speak in this kind of broken, staccato form. So there's all these sorts of decisions that Shakespeare makes. Romeo and Juliet, another good example. In Romeo and Juliet, when they meet, they speak a sonnet to each other. They speak the different parts of what, if you put them together, it becomes a sonnet. Shakespeare is always thinking about how people speak and why nothing happens by accident. There's incredible detail within that, within the rhythms. I'm glad you raised it, because I think it's something that we should all be thinking about. And particularly in terms of performance, it matters.

3.74 My question is on the topic of retribution in the play, because Lear goes through madness and then is reconciled. You see, Gloucester is naive, has his eyes taken out, but then sees more than when he doesn't. And there's a genuine sense of retribution which you don't see in, let's say, for example, the Mayor of Casterbridge, where Mr. Henchard has a retribution that he imposes on himself but doesn't change his character. And you see that play out at the end. How does that retribution inflict in the story? Because the ending doesn't actually align with the actual retribution. Because that's where I got lost with the play, because I understood the understanding of genuine retribution. But then self-imposed retribution didn't seem to allow for the same thing when you see Poor Tom at the end. He actually, during his madness, understands. He looks at his own life and sees the things that he did wrong, but then ends up, as you know, at the end, being the ultimate virtuous character in that play. So I lost the understanding of the idea of retribution.

- 3.75** Is that because you wanted there to be a sort of secure form of retribution in this play? Did you want, in other words, poetic justice?
- 3.76** I don't know if I wanted poetic justice. I think I wanted an understanding of what the ultimate —how that retribution should be done. Because maybe not poetic justice, but I was trying to figure out where the diff—because there's different levels of retribution. We have someone who goes through madness, someone who has their eyes taken out, but then becomes a better person. And ultimately, you know, Edgar goes into, like, does what, you know, *The Gulag Archipelago*, where they actually, Solzhenitsyn takes and looks at his own life and sees where he's done wrong, and then ultimately ends up as the most virtuous person.
- 3.77** That's the problem, is it's entirely unpredictable, isn't it? You know, sometimes the characters can go through something that purifies them, makes them better, even though it is a terrible thing. Sometimes the evil characters will prevail. You know, there's no way in this play to predict how it's going to happen and who it's going to happen to. It doesn't take a purely dismal view. I mean, you mentioned Thomas Hardy. I think *Mayor of Casterbridge* has the most depressing final line of any novel I've ever read. I'm paraphrasing here, but it's something like he says, "Well, life is just a sequence of terrible things with occasional glimpses of niceness." He says, I can't remember what he says, but it's something like, it's just horrible. You just think, what is wrong with Thomas Hardy?
- 3.78** But in Shakespeare, there is some retribution. There is some justice. I mean, look, Goneril and Regan don't get away with it. You know, Goneril poisons Regan and then can't bear it and so kills herself. Well, fair enough. They're not very nice. Oswald dies. Edmund dies at the hand of the brother that he has wronged. There's all sorts of ways in which there is traditional retribution within the play, and that does satisfy us to an extent. It would satisfy us more if, when Oswald said, "I want to do something to make amends; let's save Cordelia," if he didn't at the same time say, "even though it's not really in my nature to do so," and even though it's too late. I mean, he delays too long, so she dies anyway. So it's not—I suppose what I mean is that the play is not satisfying our instincts for what we see as traditional retribution. It doesn't do that. But I actually think that that's its strength, not a weakness.

Lecture 4: Macbeth's Madness

At a glance — Macbeth — free will, fate, and ambition.

- 4.1 Imagine a world without free will. Imagine a world where every decision you think you've made has actually been decided for you and that you are reduced to a puppet in a cosmic game of fate. This is how the Calvinists saw themselves, as either a member of the elect or the damned, subject to predestination. The ancients often depicted the gods as puppet masters, toying with humankind. Oedipus, having been informed by an oracle that he will murder his father and have sex with his mother, sought to escape his fate by leaving his home in Corinth and traveling to Thebes. Of course, he didn't realize that he was an adopted child, and that his actual parents were already in Thebes. So in trying to avoid his destiny, he basically sealed it.
- 4.2 Even today, we have determinists who insist that the notion of individual choice is an illusion, that our brains are elaborate computers following a program, that our consciousness is not so much the ghost in the machine, but just the machine. This is a creed that surely leads us to despair. But what if it were true?
- 4.3 Now, as ever, literature offers us a vision of this reality. In Macbeth, Shakespeare presents us with the horror of a world without free will. Our protagonist is seemingly predestined to commit his dreadful deeds. And although he is continually conscious that what he is doing is wrong, he cannot find a way to deviate from the path. I want to suggest in this lecture that the singular horror of Macbeth is one that is perhaps only matched in the despair of King Lear. It's a different kind of horror, but it is potent nonetheless. I suspect that there's a good reason why the word Macbeth has become a taboo in the theater. It's a curse. Actors hate hearing about it. They instead call it the Scottish Play, as a euphemism. It's very bad luck to say the word Macbeth in the theater. Let me give you some historical context before we get into it.
- 4.4 Macbeth, the real-life Macbeth, he reigned as King of Scotland from 1040 to 1057. If you think about it, Shakespeare is nearer to us, historically, than he was to the actual Macbeth. And the events of the play take place across two decades, but Shakespeare telescopes these events into a two-hour piece. And the text we have got of Macbeth is almost certainly a performance text. It's a text that's in the Folio, about half the length of Hamlet, one of Shakespeare's shortest plays. Very, very rapid. And this pace has a really important dramatic effect. The scenes are often short, as they are in Antony and Cleopatra, although Antony and Cleopatra is a much longer play. But unlike Antony and Cleopatra, the pace of Macbeth, it's relentless, it's unbearable. We actually want it to slow down. We want to take a breath from time to time.
- 4.5 Even the porter scene, which many see as this momentary comedic respite, it's really no such thing. It's every bit as ominous as what has preceded it, maybe even more so by virtue of the porter's drunken, flippant nature. He hears knocking, and he thinks it's

the knocking on the gates of hell. What could be more ominous than that? We're going to return to the porter later on. But stylistically, I want you to consider that Macbeth is one of Shakespeare's darkest plays, both thematically and literally. It has that same pervasive sense of darkness that we saw in King Lear. Of all of Shakespeare's plays, these are the only two plays that I cannot imagine being set during the day. They are nighttime plays. All of the scenes feel like they're set at night.

- 4.6 As I've argued in relation to King Lear, these feel like godless texts. In Macbeth, we feel somehow as though we are retreating to a time before God's command of "let there be light." Both Lear and Macbeth stumble onto terrifying pathways of chaos and self-annihilation. The light of God cannot find them as they descend further and further on the winding trail towards moral oblivion. Even if we accept that Lear finds ultimate redemption, something which we definitely can't say for Macbeth, the path he takes is one that few of us would envy.
- 4.7 Now, this all makes more sense in King Lear. King Lear, as I said, is a pre-Christian play, pagan England, 8th century BC. Macbeth, though, is a different matter. We are rooted firmly in the Catholic landscape of medieval Scotland. Scotland was Catholic until the Scottish Reformation of 1560. It's in this context, in the full fervor of medieval Catholicism, that we get a protagonist, a hero, and a villain in one, who performs acts of homicide, infanticide, and regicide. Is it possible to find sympathy with a man like Macbeth? OK, well, let's find out.
- 4.8 Let's begin at the beginning. Shakespeare often opens his plays by throwing us into the middle of the action, momentarily disorientating us, only to provide more secure exposition in a second or a third scene. This is one of his recurring techniques. At the beginning of Coriolanus, for instance, you've got the hungry crowds who are rioting. At the start of Julius Caesar, you've got the people celebrating out on the streets. Romeo and Juliet starts with a brawl between the young Montagues and the young Capulets. Hamlet opens with night watchmen who are encountering a ghost. So again and again, we are propelled into these unfamiliar worlds, and we must familiarize ourselves as the play goes on.
- 4.9 The opening of Macbeth is one of the most stunning and memorable examples of this. Three witches on a blasted heath. Thunder, lightning, they speak. "When shall we three meet again? In thunder, lightning, or in rain?" "When the hurly-burly's done, when the battle's lost and won." "That will be ere the set of sun." "Where the place?" "Upon the heath." "There to meet with Macbeth." "I come, Grimalkin." "Paddock calls." "Anon." "Fair is foul, and foul is fair. Hover through the fog and filthy air."
- 4.10 So three supernatural creatures, and they are speaking in paradoxes, right? "The battle will be lost and won." Of course, that is literally the case. In all battles, there is a victor and a loser. They say, "Fair is foul, and foul is fair." Everything beautiful to them is ugly. Everything ugly is, to them, sublime. This is why, one supposes, that the first witch offers only three options. They're going to meet either in thunder, lightning, or in rain.

A sunny afternoon with a warm caressing breeze is not on the table. They have their familiar spirits. They're named —Grimalkin, Paddock. These creatures are capable of flight, of levitating through the fog and the filthy air. We know already that they have clairvoyant powers. They know when and where they will encounter Macbeth. It's going to be on the heath. It's going to be before sunset. We know that Macbeth has been in a battle, what they call the hurly-burly.

- 4.11** All of this information is conveyed in 11 lines. That's it. The scene starts and it finishes very rapidly, and we've taken in all this information. Shakespeare is known for his expansive quality, for his epic scale. But here, we see that he is also a master of economy. More than that, he's created an atmosphere so baleful, so otherworldly, that we're already experiencing that sense of discombobulation, one that Macbeth is soon to feel for himself. Even the rhythm of their language tells us that they are not of this world. Now, throughout the play, the characters, when they do speak in verse, will be speaking in iambic pentameter. This is the convention of the time, convention of all dramas of the time.
- 4.12** Phrases like, "A horse, a horse, my kingdom for a horse," from Shakespeare. That's obviously Richard III. "If music be the food of love, play on." That's Twelfth Night. "Uneasy lies the head that wears the crown." You can hear the iambic pentameter rhythm in all of Shakespeare's most famous phrases. Now, of course, not all of Shakespeare's lines are strictly iambic. He plays around, but this is a broad rule in his plays. But compare that to the witches. They don't speak in iambic pentameter. They speak in trochaic tetrameter.
- 4.13** OK, so whereas an iamb has a stress on the second syllable—"Shall I compare thee to a summer's day?" You can hear it—a trochee has the stress on the first syllable. "Fair is foul and foul is fair." "When the hurly-burly's won," right? And unlike the pentameter line, which is five stressed syllabus, five metrical feet, the tetrameter line has four. "Fair is foul and foul is fair." So you can all hear it, right? This is why we need to pay some attention to verse form and meter, prosely, when we think about Shakespeare. It's actually very important. Now, that trochaic tetrameter structure —there's actually lots of poems from this period that were written in that form. Now, Shakespeare's sonnets are all written in iambic pentameter, except for Sonnet 145, which is, for some reason, written in iambic tetrameter.
- 4.14** But for a trochaic tetrameter, you might look at Shakespeare's poem, The Phoenix and the Turtle. I don't know if you're familiar with this poem. "So between them love did shine, that the turtle saw his right, flaming in the phoenix's sight. Either was the other's mine." You can hear it, trochaic tetrameter. The Phoenix and the Turtle. It's not a turtle in the way you're thinking; it's a turtle dove, birds. This is one of the most enigmatic poems he ever wrote. It's about the death of love. But the verse form is what I'm interested in here, that the trochaic tetrameter —there's another poem from this period, which goes, "As it fell upon a day, in the merry month of May." This was a poem

that was attributed to Shakespeare for many, many years. I mean, centuries. It's actually written by a poet called Richard Barnfield.

- 4.15 But in the context of the plays, the witches, speaking in trochaic tetrameter, rather than iambic pentameter, marks them out as being different, as being ethereal, as being from another world. And this is, of course, very noticeable when Macbeth and Banquo engage in direct discourse with the witches. This is Act 1, Scene 3. Banquo says, to the witches, "If you can look into the seeds of time and say which grain will grow and which will not, speak then to me, who neither beg nor fear your favors nor your hate." Can you hear in that last line, "your favors nor your hate?" The pentameter line is not complete. The witches complete it for him. They say, "Hail, hail, hail!"
- 4.16 And then the tetrameter begins. You can hear it. "Lesser than Macbeth, and greater." "Not so happy, yet much happier." You can hear the four beats per line, right? "Thou shalt get kings, though thou be none. So all hail, Macbeth and Banquo!" "Banquo and Macbeth, all hail!" And then we shift back to iambic pentameter for Macbeth and Banquo. Macbeth says, "Stay, you imperfect speakers, tell me more. By Sinel's death I know I am Thane of Glamis, but how of Cawdor? The Thane of Cawdor lives," and so on and so on. So the witches, in other words, speak in this frolicking, fairy tale cadence. And that's not to suggest that their presence is flippant or comedic, but it is interesting.
- 4.17 If we look at the only account of this play from an audience's perspective during Shakespeare's lifetime, so this is an astrologer called Dr. Simon Foreman. Now, this guy was involved to some degree in the investigation into the Gunpowder Plot. He was an advisor to the Privy Council. He saw a performance of Macbeth at the Globe Theater. He even gives us a date for it, which was 20th of April, 1610. He wrote an account of the play. It's very, very valuable because this kind of thing is very rare at the time.
- 4.18 In his account of the play of Macbeth, he describes the witches as "three women fairies or nymphs." Now, of course, we don't have detail of the costume or the demeanor of how this would have been played. But it would seem that, even though these creatures—they're bearded hags, they've got beards. Banquo says so. "You should be women, but your beards forbid me to interpret that you are so." But to a Jacobean audience, they nevertheless fall into this category of fairies.
- 4.19 Now, directors often struggle with how to represent the witches. You don't want any inadvertent laughter. That's the first thing. The witches have become a cliché. Three witches around a cauldron. I think our instinct is mostly to laugh. That idea of the three witches, it's commonplace now. Think of Bette Midler in Hocus Pocus. I mean, that film probably wouldn't exist if they weren't drawing from that Shakespearean tradition. But when Shakespeare does it, in 1606, this hasn't been done to this extent before. Not that he invented the idea of witches around a cauldron, but nevertheless, it wasn't the cliché that it has now since become.

- 4.20 But maybe the witches don't need to be particularly malevolent in appearance. Maybe they're more sinister if they're not. If you think of, there was a film of Macbeth from 2010 by Rupert Goold, and he depicted the three witches as rather pretty-looking nurses. There's Roman Polanski's film in 1971, which, by the way, was produced by Hugh Hefner, funded by Playboy magazine, which might explain why one of the witches gets naked. But it has one young witch and an old witch and another witch of middle age, trying to represent the full scale of human life.
- 4.21 In the late 1700s, there was a craze for paintings and sketches of Shakespearean plays, and the witches were a particular favorite. People drew them an awful lot. There's a portrait by Daniel Gardner, which depicts three very influential women of the time as the witches—these women, Elizabeth Lamb, Anne Seymour Damer, and Georgina, Duchess of Devonshire—and they are rather prepossessing witches. They look pleasant. It suggested that they may have even commissioned this painting. They wanted to be depicted as the witches. There are no hooked noses or warts anywhere.
- 4.22 But if you compare this to a sketch by John Runciman, who envisages the witches as bold, pointy-eared monstrosities, or indeed, Henry Fuseli's trio, that have the look of old men with intense stares and accusatory pointing—when I see that image, I imagine them there uttering that famous line from Act 4, Scene 1. When Macbeth approaches, what do they say? "Something wicked this way comes." Now, of course, Shakespeare, as I say, didn't invent this theme of the witches. What I'm saying is that Shakespeare popularized the idea of these witches, these hags. But the question as to their function in the play remains unanswered.
- 4.23 It's very important in terms of when we're talking about fate, when we're talking about to what degree does Macbeth have a choice, that we think about this, whether we think about the witches, because they're always there in the background, aren't they? Once you've seen them, they inform everything that's going on. So in their first meeting with Macbeth and Banquo on the blasted heath, they first greet Macbeth as "Thane of Glamis, Thane of Cawdor, and Macbeth, that shalt be king hereafter." That's how they greet him. Three titles. So he's already the Thane of Glamis. We already know that. At this point in the play, we, the audience, know that he's also Thane of Cawdor. He doesn't know that because the previous Thane of Cawdor has been declared a traitor, and Macbeth has been rewarded with his title. Ross has been dispatched to inform him.
- 4.24 So what does this do from an audience's perspective? This first, it confirms to us that the prophecy that he will be king, hereafter, is also likely to be true. We know that; Macbeth doesn't know that. Macbeth soon comes to that realization when Ross turns up with the news that he is now Thane of Cawdor. So Macbeth, in other words, is always playing catch-up with the audience. We're always in a state of dramatic irony. We always know something that the characters do not. Now, we've already been introduced to the witches. We know they're supernatural and prophetic beings. Their

early declaration, they say they will meet "ere the set of sun." Ere, E-R-E, always means before. They will meet ere the set of sun. That's not just a guess. They know it to be true.

4.25 As there are three of them, we might be inclined to think of them as the Fates, the Parcae, the Sisters of Fate of ancient Greek mythology. We call them the Weird Sisters. You've heard that phrase, the weird—after Holinshed referred to them as the weird sisters. That word weird is this old Anglo-Saxon term, the concept of fate. And the word evolved. Eventually, we use the word weird to mean strange or bizarre or odd. It comes from the same word, though. It's just evolved over the centuries. But in the Folio text, Shakespeare calls them the wayward sisters, and it gets amended to weird in various additions.

4.26 But that matters. If the word weird means fate, and these are the weird sisters, does that mean that they are the Sisters of Fate? Is that literally what it means? Does that mean, therefore, that they don't really have any control over Macbeth's destiny, but they simply impart it to him? Why then bother telling him at all? What's the point? If he's going to do it anyway, why do they need to get involved? Is it some diabolical sadism for its own sake? Is that what's going on? Well, maybe. I mean, look, we know that they are quite sadistic. They are. At the top of Act 1, Scene 3, they're boasting to each other of killing swine. One produces a pilot's thumb, having maliciously unleashed her powers to wreck the sailor's ship. Maybe it is just evil for its own sake. Maybe it's as simple as that.

4.27 Hazlitt calls them "hags of mischief, enamored of destruction," he says. We don't know where they've come from. We don't know why they should exist at all. But why else would they seek out Macbeth to reveal his future, unless they derived some pleasure from his torment? Think about it. It's a question that we're being asked, really, by the play, and there are no right answers. But the question does remain, doesn't it? Would Macbeth have murdered his cousin, King Duncan, had he not been told that the throne would be his? Please note that the witches don't tell him to do it. They don't say, "You're going to kill Duncan." They say, "You're going to be king." It is his own mind that takes him to the position of committing regicide. It's the conclusion he immediately reaches, and it is immediate.

4.28 So have they planted a seed? I'm not so sure. Have they merely identified something that was already on his mind? I think that's more likely, right? I mean, certainly, Lady Macbeth's immediate response to his letter—he immediately writes to his wife and says, "Look, I've met these witches. They say I'm going to be king." Straightaway, he does that. The first time we see Lady Macbeth, she's reading aloud this letter. The implication, I think, is that they have discussed this before. Perhaps the witches are maybe giving him the gentle encouragement he needs to pursue a course of action that he has already fantasized about. Macbeth is, after all, famously ambitious.

- 4.29 And yet, and yet, he is a good man, isn't he? He's the best of men. We established this in the second scene. We've seen the witches. They've gone, floated off, and then we're straight into a captain, covered in blood, on the battlefield, recounting Macbeth's valiant deeds in battle. He's just killed the rebel Macdonald, "unseaming him from the navel to the chops." That is to say, slicing him open from the navel to the chin before decapitating him and displaying his head on the battlements. It's pretty violent, but of course, it's par for the course for a medieval warrior. And Duncan's response to this news tells us everything. He says, "Oh, valiant cousin, worthy gentleman." And this is the very same man who's going to commit the ultimate crime, the violent usurpation of the throne. Very important. Macbeth, high status, but not just high status, a good man, the best of men.
- 4.30 Right. Now, we've talked about fate. So what of the influence of Lady Macbeth? Some would argue that she plays a role analogous to Eve, tempting Adam with the fruit from the tree of knowledge. But I think that the interpretation of Lady Macbeth as some kind of just evil termagant is unsophisticated. For a start, would you get the sense that their marriage is a good one? I mean that sincerely. Harold Bloom was very fond of saying that they were the happiest married couple in all of Shakespeare's work. I don't think he was being facetious. I think he was right.
- 4.31 When we first see Lady Macbeth, she's reading aloud the letter from her husband, OK? She reads, "They met me in the day of success." This is the witches. "And I have learned by the perfectest report that they have more in them than mortal knowledge." So what's happening here theatrically? This is the first time we've seen Lady Macbeth, but we're not hearing her words. We're hearing Macbeth's words. She's reading aloud her husband's words. In our mind, we are conflating the two. They are one. That's the theatrical impact of this opening gesture. We understand their intimacy because of what the letter says.
- 4.32 I'm sure—I don't know if any of you are married, but you would probably keep that to yourself, wouldn't you? I don't know if you would rush off and tell your spouse that you'd just seen three bearded hags who have told you that you're going to be king, particularly at this time. But Macbeth doesn't hesitate. He writes to her straightaway. We can see the deterioration of their relationship clearly later on, when he starts keeping secrets from her. It's very different. When he sends the murderers to kill Banquo and Fleance, he says, "Be innocent of the knowledge, dearest chuck, till thou applaud the deed." I'm not going to tell you. Just trust me. I'm not going to tell you. It's completely different to how he was earlier, when this most extraordinary thing happened and he wrote to her without even thinking about it. It's not that he no longer trusts her, but he has taken a path so dark that he can only conceive of walking it alone. Surely another testament to the extent to which he loves her.
- 4.33 But let's go back to this first introduction when Lady Macbeth appears, OK? So her soliloquy, having read the letter, is very, very revealing. She says, "Glamis thou art, and

Cawdor, and shalt be what thou art promised." So she's already saying, "You're going to be king. We'll make this happen." OK, straightaway. "Yet I do fear thy nature. It is too full of the milk of human kindness to catch the nearest way. Thou wouldst be great, art not without ambition, but without the illness should attend it." She knows that she's going to have to prompt him. She's going to have to nudge him down this diabolical path for his own sake. The impression that we're left with is that they have discussed this possibility before. This is not a new idea.

4.34 It's not that Lady Macbeth is a fourth witch, which is often how she's portrayed. But she is one with whom Macbeth is so intimate that they've shared their darkest thoughts, their darkest desires. That is a close relationship. It's a hallmark of a close relationship when you can share all your secrets. Now, when a servant enters and tells Lady Macbeth that Duncan is arriving that very night, "The King is coming to stay," she doesn't hesitate. She doesn't think about it. She doesn't wrangle, as you would normally get in a soliloquy. Straightaway, she says, "The raven himself is hoarse that croaks the fatal entrance of Duncan under my battlements." She knows what's going to happen. It's no moment of reflection or consideration.

4.35 And although she has accused Macbeth of being "too full of the milk of human kindness," she is also aware that she has that quality to the same degree, as well. I mean, this is the thing. They often portray Lady Macbeth as this evil villain, someone who's just innately evil. I think it's completely wrong. This soliloquy tells us this. In order for her to commit this deed, she's going to have to make herself cruel. I don't think that the murder of a kinsman comes naturally to either of the Macbeths. And later on, remember, she tells us that she could not have killed Duncan while he slept because he too closely resembled her father. There is some essential humanity here. And at this moment, when she learns the news that Duncan is imminently going to arrive, this is an Act 1, Scene 5. In order to make herself suitably sociopathic to commit this act, she has to call on evil spirits to support her. She can't do it herself.

4.36 She says, "Come, you spirits that tend on mortal thoughts, unsex me here." Get rid of all of my femininity. Get rid of all of my compassion. "Unsex me here and fill me from the crown to the toe, top-full of direst cruelty. Make thick my blood. Stop up the access and passage to remorse that no compunctious visitings of nature shake my fell purpose, nor keep peace between the effect and it. Come to my woman's breasts and take my milk for gall, you murdering ministers, wherever in your sightless substances you wait on nature's mischief. Come, thick night, and pall thee in the dunkest smoke of hell, that my keen knife see not the wound it makes, nor heaven peep through the blanket of the dark to cry, 'Hold, hold.'"

4.37 It is an astonishing soliloquy. She's having to call on diabolical supernatural forces. That is the kind of play we are dealing with here. It's really strange to me that this would have been originally performed by a boy whose voice hadn't quite fully broken. I don't know how a boy could do a role like this justice. I mean, child actors are terrible at the

best of times. But this is such a difficult role, such a powerful role. Same goes for all of Shakespeare's women. I can't envisage it. Cleopatra, Rosalind, Helena, Cordelia, Beatrice. How does a boy do that? I don't know. Anyway, that's a side point.

4.38 Now, in Lady Macbeth's case, "the milk of human kindness," she says, "needs to be replaced." Her breastmilk needs to be replaced with poison, "with gall." She says it. It's a perverted image. All aspects of her femininity need to be eliminated. This is important because later when Macbeth loses his nerve, doesn't want to go through with it, what does she say to him? She says, "Are you a man?" That's her go-to. She challenges his masculinity. And again, "what beast was it then that made you break this enterprise to me?" Why did you commit to this murder if you wouldn't carry it out? She says, "When you durst do it, then you were a man." And this works. This is the key moment.

4.39 We have heard how, metaphorically, she wants her mother's milk to be substituted for poison. But now she reminds us that she actually was a mother. This is what she says. She says, "I have given suck, and know how tender 'tis to love the babe that milks me. I would, while it was smiling in my face, have plucked my nipple from his boneless gums and dashed the brains out, had I so sworn as you have done to this." So she takes the most tender moment a mother can have. Now, we know that the historical Lady Macbeth did have a child in a previous marriage. You can look her up. Her name is Gruoch. But this image that, had she agreed to go through with this murder, as Macbeth has done, she would rather have ripped the baby away from her breast and smashed its brains out onto the floor. I mean, it's so perverse, so unnatural, so against all of her mother's instincts.

4.40 So what else can Macbeth do? He has to comply. And yet for all that, I don't want to put the blame too squarely on Lady Macbeth, insofar as we shouldn't assume that Macbeth would not have committed the murder without the influence of his wife. So I've already suggested that they'd probably discussed this outcome even before the witches appeared. This is supposition, of course. Don't have any evidence for it. But if we assume that the witches are not so much hags of fate, maliciously taunting humankind with their knowledge of what must be, but rather, reifications of preexisting latent desires, I think that makes more sense.

4.41 It's almost as though Macbeth has brought them into being. I think it's quite an interesting idea. If you consider his reaction upon hearing that he is the Thane of Cawdor, therefore, the first prophecy has already turned out to be true. What is his reaction? What does he say? He says, "This supernatural soliciting cannot be ill, cannot be good. If ill, why hath it given me earnest of success commencing in a truth? I am Thane of Cawdor. If good, why do I yield to that suggestion, whose horrid image doth unfix my hair and make my seated heart knock at my ribs against the use of nature? Present fears are less than horrible imaginings. My thought, whose murder yet is but

fantastical, shakes so my single state of man that function is smothered in surmise, and nothing is but what is not."

4.42 Think about that phrase. Commit it to memory. "Nothing is but what is not." I think it's absolutely chilling. Reality is totally subverted. Nothing is but what is not. The horror of the play is that it brings impossibilities to life. We've all felt that. We've all had those moments where we feel like we're living in a fiction. Something happens so extraordinary, and you say to yourself, "This cannot be happening." We've all had it. But here, Macbeth's imagination has herded him into a cage of the unimaginable. He cannot even grasp onto a sliver of his former life. Nothing is but what is not. Everything is turned upside down. Straightaway, his hair is unfixed, his heart is beating. Straightaway, once the prophecy of Thane of Cawdor is fulfilled, his bodily reaction is to consider what happens next, and he knows what he's going to do. So let's not just put this on Lady Macbeth's shoulders. Macbeth knew from the very moment the prophecy was fulfilled.

4.43 Now, regicide is a theme, it has often been noted, that would have had particular resonance at this time for the then-King of England, James I, who was, of course, James VI of Scotland. You'll know about this. When Queen Elizabeth died in 1603, James came down from Scotland and he became king. No one could understand him, by the way. He had a very thick Scottish accent. People in the court really struggled with that. Now, it was said that he was so terrified of assassination, he used to sleep with pillows up against his body, so that if an assassin crept in at night and stabbed him, it might miss his body.

4.44 It wasn't paranoia. As I said, he had good justification. There were plenty of people who wanted him dead, just as there were plenty of people who wanted Queen Elizabeth I dead. You might remember famous Lopez trial, the doctor who was accused of attempting to poison her. Whether he did or not is another question. And of course, the Gunpowder Plot, 1605. So Macbeth is written a year after Guy Fawkes and his co-conspirators tried to blow up Parliament, and they almost succeeded. They would have killed everyone. It would have been an astonishing coup. We still commemorate this by burning the Guy on the 5th of November. Isn't that weird? It's odd. It feels like anti-Catholic propaganda, anyway.

4.45 Now, there are various allusions in the play that make us understand why Shakespeare might have written this for the new king. This is the first play he's writing for James I. Well, it's a Scottish play for a Scottish king. Would he have written a Scottish play? Otherwise, probably not. There are good reasons for doing it. After the murder of Duncan comes a scene with the drunken porter. There are other allusions here that I want to draw your attention to. So the drunken porter hears the knocking of Macduff and Lennox outside, and he, in his drunken state, casts himself as the guardian of Hell's Gate. This is a famous scene because a lot of people don't understand what he's talking about. The jokes haven't aged particularly well. A lot of people cut this scene in

performance, or they rewrite it as a recent RSC production did. I wish they wouldn't do things like this.

- 4.46 There's something really powerful about this moment. He thinks he's admitting the souls of the damned to Hell, just at the moment that Macbeth has killed Duncan. The murder has just happened. Now, what does he say? He mentioned that one of the spirits at the gate, he says, is a farmer, "a farmer that hanged himself on the expectation of plenty," which is likely a reference to Father Henry Garnet, one of the conspirators, a Jesuit plotter. He used the alias of farmer during the Gunpowder Plot. He mounted a defense, subsequently, which was known as equivocation. What does the porter say? "Faith, here's an equivocator that could swear in both the scales against either scale, who committed treason enough for God's sake, yet could not equivocate to heaven. O, come in, equivocator."
- 4.47 Now, we don't often find these topical references in Shakespeare. They're very unusual. And as I say, a lot of the humor is lost. When the porter lets in an English tailor—"come hither for stealing out of a French hose"—none of you are laughing, but it's a funny joke. It's a reference to the relative tightness of certain types of breeches at the time. Very funny. As I say, this stuff often gets cut. Some of you will have studied Macbeth at school. One of the first things you learn is the porter scene is comic relief. At the play's highest intensity, you have a funny scene. Maybe so, maybe so. But I think, dramatically, it achieves so much more than that.
- 4.48 I would say that, in reimagining Macbeth's castle as hell itself, the scene plunges us further into this deranging vision of a world unmoored from its axis. The porter misinterprets the knocking at the gate in the most sinister way, perhaps even more sinister because of his drunken ramblings. This is a common thing that's going on at the time. There are various noises that night, and they keep being misinterpreted. The world is not what we think. "Nothing is but what is not." Everything is inverted.
- 4.49 So what does Lennox say to Macbeth? Lennox says, "The night has been unruly. Where we lay our chimneys were blown down, and, as they say, lamentings heard in the air, strange screams of death." For Lady Macbeth, the shrieking of the owl is—what does she say? "The fatal bellman, which gives the sternest goodnight." For Macbeth, the sound of a bell is interpreted as a diabolical invitation. He says, "I go, and it is done. The bell invites me. Hear it not, Duncan; for it is a knell that summons thee to heaven or to hell." Sounds being misinterpreted, a world that is impossible to hold on to, a world that seems like it's teetering into the supernatural. That's what's going on here.
- 4.50 Now, when Duncan is killed, when Macbeth approaches the sleeping Duncan, he hears the King's sons, Malcolm and Donalbain, in the next chamber. We know this because he comes back and he tells Lady Macbeth this, right? And these voices that he hears have the effect of taunting spirits in the night air. He says, "There's one did laugh in his sleep, and one cried 'Murder!' That they did wake each other. I stood and heard them, but they did say their prayers and address them again to sleep. One cried, 'God, bless us!'

and 'Amen' the other, as they had seen me with these hangman's hands." He imagines them waking up in the next chamber and praying that they'd heard him, that they can see him. He says, "Listening their fear, I could not say 'Amen' when they did say, 'God bless us.'"

4.51 What does Lady Macbeth say? "Consider it not so deeply." Don't worry about it. She's not going to address these concerns. She's not going to entertain these fantasies. She wants to be rooted in the real world. That's what she wants. That's what she needs. It doesn't work, does it? Because she's the one that goes mad, and she's the one that dies. She's the one that obsessively tries to clean the blood from her hands in her mad somnambulant state. She knows that for Macbeth to dwell on this is going to ensure his self-destruction. It's going to drive him mad. It's going to be his unraveling. And there follows this extraordinary exchange. So Macbeth says, "But wherefore could I not pronounce 'Amen'? I had most need of blessing, and 'Amen' stuck in my throat."

4.52 Lady Macbeth says, "These deeds must not be thought after these ways. So, it will make us mad." And he says, "Methought I heard a voice cry, 'Sleep no more. Macbeth does murder sleep,' the innocent sleep." And then he gets caught up in idioms. He's stuck. He's stuck. He cannot imagine where to take these thoughts. So he just keeps repeating synonymous phrases. He says, "Innocent sleep, sleep that knits up the raveled sleeve of care, the death of each day's life, sore labour's bath, balm of hurt minds, great nature's second course, chief nourisher in life's feast."

4.53 And Lady Macbeth has to put a stop to this, has to drag him back to the real world, has to rescue his sanity. She says, "What do you mean?" And Macbeth cannot stop. He says, "Still, it cried 'Sleep no more' to all the house. Glamis has murdered sleep, and therefore, Cawdor shall sleep no more. Macbeth shall sleep no more." He's spiraling here. You can hear it in the language. He's losing his grip on reality. And the voices of Malcolm and Donalbain have morphed into these chattering phantoms of the mind. Macbeth is haunted by his own deed in the very act of its execution.

4.54 And Lady Macbeth is desperately trying to draw him back to reality. She says, "Who was it? Who was it thus cried?" But it's too late. Macbeth's existence is no longer rooted in reality, and it hasn't been for some time now. The air-drawn dagger. There was that allusion. He saw this dagger floating in the air that he followed to Duncan's chamber. And of course, later he will see the ghost of Banquo, who's his next victim. But the murder of Duncan is the crux. This is the peripeteia of the drama. This is the threshold. And it's not even the case that this conflict within Macbeth's soul, this disordering of nature, is restricted to the man himself. It's as though, in this play, that his inner torment is extended to the realm of the play at large. This is why I quite like the idea that he has, in effect, conjured the witches into existence through his own macabre fantasies. I find that very convincing.

4.55 Of all the tragedies, with the exception of Hamlet, Macbeth is the one that is most mediated through the central character. OK, but as he changes, the world around him

changes too. Everything, everything becomes destabilized. As he says, "Nothing is but what is not." And many days after the murder, Ross and an old man, they start sharing stories about the strange things that they have seen. A falcon killed by a mousing owl. That shouldn't happen. That's not how nature works. Duncan's horses break out of their stalls and eat each other. Horses are vegetarian, certainly not cannibals. We're no longer in a world where the laws of nature apply. It isn't Macbeth that sees the horses eat each other. It's Ross. It's the people around him. It's the people who are still meant to be in reality. Everything spills out of Macbeth's mind and infects the world at large. That's what's fascinating about this play.

- 4.56** And the unnaturalness of Macbeth's act of killing Duncan, it has a curdling effect. He is journeying to hell, and he is bringing hell back with him. And crucially, at all times, he knows that what he has done, and what he will continue to do, is against his nature. One murder leads to another. "It will have blood," he says. "Blood will have blood," that recurring word. Blood occurs with incredible frequency in the play. And Banquo will be next, of course. Now, Banquo, his closest friend, who he was with when he met the witches—he was there, he heard the prophecy. But of course, he has to kill Banquo. Why? Because the witches gave another prophecy, didn't they? The witches told Banquo that his descendents would be kings.
- 4.57** When Macbeth kills Banquo, his real target is Banquo's son, Fleance. From his perspective, it makes sense. So the witches' prophecy has come true. He is Thane of Cawdor. He did become king. They also said that the descendents of Banquo will be king. They said that Macbeth will not have children who are kings. So Banquo has to die. His son, Fleance, has to die. What does he say, he says, "I am in blood stepped in so far that, should I wade no more, returning were as tedious as go o'er." That's a visual image. We can imagine Macbeth wading through a river of blood. He's reached the point at which it would be quicker to carry on than to return. So he may as well keep going, may as well keep killing, keep wading into deeper and deeper horror.
- 4.58** Now, the figure of Banquo was very, very significant at this time, particularly for King James I. There's an image in the New Cambridge edition of Macbeth, which has some very good annotations. In the introduction, the editor reproduces an image of a family tree from a book by John Leslie, who's a Scottish Catholic bishop and historian. This is an old, old reproduction. It's called Concerning the Origin, Behaviour, and Achievements of the Scots. The image shows the Stuart family tree. That culminates in King James VI of Scotland, who later became James I of England. Leslie started working on this book while he was imprisoned in the Tower of London in 1570 for supporting Mary, Queen of Scots, in her claim to the throne.
- 4.59** And this family tree, which is depicted in the image as a literal tree, shows Banquo at the base of the trunk, and directly above you see Fleance. And then up towards the top of the tree, in the outstretched branches, you have James VI. And so you see a direct line from Banquo all the way to James. And irrespective of whether that is true or not,

King James definitely believed it to be true. He thought he was descended from Banquo. And this gives him an investment in the character of Banquo and his son Fleance.

4.60 It's probably why Shakespeare changed the sources. Remember I said that Shakespeare was using the second edition of Holinshed's Chronicles, which came out in that key year, 1587, when Shakespeare moved to London. Now, in the sources, Banquo is a co-conspirator in the death of Duncan. That's what Holinshed says. Now, Shakespeare can't do that. If King James I flatters himself that he is descended from Banquo, something's going to have to change here. And so Banquo becomes the good guy. That's how he does it.

4.61 And how could it be otherwise? If you think about, James was the patron of Shakespeare's company. Remember, Shakespeare was with the Lord Chamberlain's Men. As soon as the Queen dies and the King comes down, he starts to patronize the company. It becomes the King's Men. In other words, Shakespeare is fully dependent on King James for his income. He's not going to annoy him. Now, most of the evidence does suggest Shakespeare wasn't any kind of sycophant. He wasn't a court toady, but he wasn't going to annoy his patron unnecessarily.

4.62 And anyway, it is actually more dramatically interesting. This is why I don't think he's a sellout for doing this. I think it's much more interesting to have Macbeth's friend, Banquo, become a mortal enemy, to return as a ghost. It heightens this sense of this great war hero losing all support, the more he ascends in power. First he kills his king, his cousin, Duncan, who he loves, then his best friend, Banquo, then Lady Macduff and her son. Eventually, his wife kills herself. Increasingly throughout the play, he's becoming more and more isolated until, by the time you get to Act 5, he's completely on his own, completely.

4.63 This connection between King James I and Banquo, this is really important. You might remember in Act 4, it makes a very explicit appearance, because in the first scene of Act 4, Macbeth returns to the witches for reassurance. He wants to know that everything's going to be OK. This is that famous scene where they tell him that "none of women born can harm Macbeth." That makes him feel invincible until he's fighting Macduff, and he realizes that Macduff was "from his mother's womb untimely ripped." But anyway, let's leave that for now. So he goes back to the witches. He wants reassurance, and they show him a vision of eight kings, and each king is holding a glass or a mirror, and he also sees Banquo in the image.

4.64 And what he's seeing there is the line of descendents from Banquo, all the way down to a final specter holding a mirror. There is a tradition that this mirror in court would have been held up to King James I, so James could see himself as the last in the line of the descendents from Banquo. Now, maybe that's fanciful, but even so, it's very clear that the idea that Banquo's line would continue, and the man who killed the king would get his comeuppance, this would go down very well in the court of King James.

- 4.65 Finally, I want to say that the unique terror that this play inspires is largely because there is no consolation to be found in the world of Macbeth. There's no catharsis. We don't leave feeling purged of our fears. Instead, it instills in us fears that never really subside. You could argue that there is a happy ending to the play, I suppose. Macbeth is slain; Malcolm is king; the line of Duncan is reestablished. But wait, we know, don't we, that Banquo's line is the one that prevails, not Malcolm's. There's at least one more revolution to come, isn't there? If a man as noble as Macbeth can become a tyrant, then what hope is there for anyone? There's a really interesting moment at the end of Roman Polanski's film of Macbeth, which is from 1971. The last scene of his film sees Donalbain, who's Duncan's second son, going off to the mountains to see the witches. It's going to happen all over again. That's the implication of that final scene.
- 4.66 Anyway, we have shared too deeply in Macbeth's conceptualization of despair on hearing about the suicide of his wife. Does he mourn? Does he cry out? Not a bit of it. He doesn't do anything like that. He is numb by this point, completely numb. Godlessness has seized his soul. He sees nothing now but the futility of life. What does he say? "Tomorrow, and tomorrow, and tomorrow creeps in this petty pace from day to day to the last syllable of recorded time. And all our yesterdays have lighted fools the way to dusty death. Out, out, brief candle. Life's but a walking shadow, a poor player that struts and frets his hour upon the stage, and then is heard no more. It is a tale told by an idiot, full of sound and fury signifying nothing."
- 4.67 Now, the great question of existentialism is, why don't we kill ourselves? The very fact that we are living and breathing tells us that we have invested something in the condition of existence. King Lear finds redemption in his sorrow. But surely we cannot live with Macbeth's philosophy. His mind is "full of scorpions," as he puts it, and he exposes those things to us. So what kind of nightmare is Shakespeare compelling us to experience? Maybe we are all Macbeth. Certainly, as we watch the play, we are so immersed in his thoughts that it is almost as though he is thinking on our behalf. It's quite an astonishing achievement and a deeply unsettling one. This sensation of a man falling into a vortex, unable to stop. It's a sensation that we all share it. We feel like we could be Macbeth. We could have done these evil things. If a man so noble can do it, then why couldn't we?
- 4.68 This is what the critic Wilbur Sanders calls "falling in space." That's the experience that Macbeth is going through. Hazlitt says, "Macbeth is driven along by the violence of his fate like a vessel drifting before a storm." Macbeth is the vessel. He is falling in space. We are following in his wake as audience members. Like the other tragedies, we know the outcome, but the difference here is that we sense that we are participating in it. In Julius Caesar, we observe the conspirators. We know what's to come. In Macbeth, we are the co-conspirators. We are at one with Macbeth. We see the dagger of Macbeth's imagination as much as he does. And worse still, we sense that we could seize it ourselves.

- 4.69 Thank you very much. Does anyone have any questions about Macbeth?
- 4.70 How far do you believe that Shakespeare was appealing to James I when writing the play, as he would have evidently believed in the divine right of kings, which obviously would go against Macbeth usurping the throne?
- 4.71 Yes, very good question. I think absolutely he's trying to appeal to James. There's no evidence for this. There's no written documentation for this. But if you think about, the coincidences are slightly too great. There's all these references to the conspirators who attempted to kill James, who attempted to blow up Parliament. There's the fact that this is a play set in Scotland, which is not typical of Shakespeare. There's the fact that it opens with witches. King James was obsessed with witches. They were the things he loved the most. He wrote a book about witches. All of this stuff seems designed to appeal to him. Banquo, as I said, is or was believed to be one of his ancestors.
- 4.72 When you take all of that together, and you might say, "Well, that's very circumstantial," but if you take all that together, it does strike me that it must be the case. Not that he was trying to appeal to him necessarily in a sycophantic way, but more that he realized that this story would appeal to him. Maybe this is a story that Shakespeare had read in Holinshed and thought, "I would like to dramatize that, and what better time to do it than we have a new Scottish king on the throne—one who, as it happens, is funding my entire company?" I think we have to be realistic about it. I think there is that.
- 4.73 In terms of the divine right of kings, that's an interesting concept, isn't it? The phrase itself isn't one that would have been used at this time. That came later, but the concept was certainly there. James wrote a book about his divine right. James certainly believed that the king was God's representative on Earth, and therefore, should be treated as such. Now, you might be implying that there's something at odds between that and the depiction of a man who kills the king. But actually, maybe the reverse is true insofar that maybe, by showing Macbeth as this villain, as someone who commits the ultimate acts of evil and is punished for it and doesn't get redemption in the way that King Lear does, and ends up with that "tomorrow, and tomorrow, and tomorrow" speech, just saying that life is futile, "we're all just a poor player strutting and fretting on the stage for no purpose whatsoever."
- 4.74 Maybe, in writing a play that seemingly punishes Macbeth for committing the ultimate crime, a crime that is in collusion with dark supernatural forces, that would actually appeal to James. It would appeal to his view of the divine right of kings. How dare Macbeth do all of this? It is right and proper that this noble man should become this evil, hated, isolated tyrant. So I think all of those things are compatible. But as I say, we don't know for sure. We'll never know for sure, but we can speculate.

Lecture 5: Restless Romance

At a glance — The 'restless romance' plays and Doyle's work with Katherine Duncan-Jones.

- 5.1** While I was studying for my doctorate, I was fortunate enough to work with Katherine Duncan-Jones, who wrote a fantastic book called *Ungentle Shakespeare*. It's very much worth your attention. She was one of my supervisors at Oxford, and she very sadly passed away last year. Now, Katherine taught me how to read 16th-century handwriting, what they call secretary hand. I have one particular memory when she took me to the Duke Humfrey's Library at the Bodleian Library, and she was attempting to show me how to read this very difficult handwriting. Many of the letter formations are quite different from they are today. She gave me a manuscript. She didn't tell me what it was. She brought it out of the vaults. She put it in front of me. I hadn't seen it before. She left me there to transcribe a particular passage.
- 5.2** I was there for about an hour, and she came back and she seemed a bit surprised that I'd barely got through any of it at all. I was quite a slow learner back then. But I do remember vividly this passage. This was from the *Arcadia* by Sir Philip Sidney, who was the famous courtier soldier-poet of the Elizabethan Age. Now, the *Arcadia* is an extended prose romance, which was written in the late 1570s. This particular passage that I had transcribed was from the second Eclogues, where a group of shepherds are having a little song and dance. It's the thing you would expect from a pastoral piece set in ancient Greece. And the dance is framed as a confrontation. The shepherds call it "the skirmish betwixt reason and passion." It's like a modern barn dance where they arrange themselves in a square; they weave in and out of each other. But there are these two teams, one team representing reason, the other team representing passion. These two ideas are seen as antithetical.
- 5.3** And so reason sings, "Thou rebel vile, come to thy master yield." Passion replies, "No, tyrant, no; mine, mine shall be the field." And it's a call and response structure, each side trying to make the other side submit. Reason sings, "Weakness you are, dare you with our strength fight?" And passion replies, "Because our weakness weakeneth all your might." Now, the reason I'm telling you this, is this dualism of reason and passion was a Renaissance commonplace. You will find it everywhere in the poetry, the drama, the philosophy of the period.
- 5.4** We do still think of love as a conflict between reason and passion. We think about love as being a kind of illness. You'll hear people talk about being lovesick. We talk about broken hearts. These ideas have never changed, and I think that's because they point to a cross-cultural trans-historical human reality about emotional attachment. And so in the Renaissance, love was seen as being in direct conflict with reason. In those lines that I quoted, those lines that I transcribed that day in the Duke Humfrey's Library, Sidney has reason calling passion a rebel, one who attempts to overthrow the natural way of things. Passion claims that reason is a tyrant, a form of suppression. Reason

dismisses passion as weakness, but passion retorts that their weakness "weakeneth all your might." So as one side becomes more prominent, the other must retreat. So this is a zero-sum game.

- 5.5 Now, Shakespeare often wrote of love. We all know this. It's there in most of the work in one form or another. All of his poems are about love. A Lover's Complaint is about a woman who's seduced and abandoned. The Phoenix and the Turtle, which I mentioned in a previous lecture, that's about the death of love. Shakespeare's Sonnets, of course —those are some of the most moving declarations of love ever committed to paper. His two great narrative poems are, of course, about sexual obsession. One is called Venus and Adonis, which depicts the sexual obsession of a woman for a man, for comedic purposes. The other is the Rape of Lucrece, which depicts the sexual obsession of a man for a woman, and you end up with tragic effects there.
- 5.6 Now, all of the comedies are about love, of course, and the tragedies deal with it, too. Hamlet claims that he loved Ophelia. Othello certainly loves Desdemona, and she loves him. The tragedy, of course, depends upon that. As we have seen, even Macbeth and Lady Macbeth appear to have a loving marriage until he starts killing everyone and she goes mad. At that point, it's become quite dysfunctional. Then, of course, Shakespeare wrote two major love tragedies, which I want to focus on today, Romeo and Juliet, and Antony and Cleopatra.
- 5.7 Now, these two plays represent Shakespeare at the beginning and at the end of his career. So he wrote Romeo Juliet in the early 1590s. Antony and Cleopatra emerges in the Jacobean period, in around 1607. I don't think it's accidental that the first play is about a pair of young lovers, and the latter play is about a pair of mature lovers. Shakespeare has matured along with these characters. Juliet is 13. That's very clear in the text. Romeo is a couple of years older than that. Antony is about 53. When he dies, Cleopatra about 40.
- 5.8 Now, in both cases, however, we get this notion of a conflict between reason and passion. And in both cases, reason succumbs to passion. And in both cases, the outcome, of course, is tragic. But the stakes are much higher for Antony and Cleopatra by virtue of the status of both of the protagonists. Cleopatra, obviously, is Queen of Egypt. Antony is one of the Triumvirate, the Great Triumvirate. So, much higher stakes than a young teenage couple from middle-class families, bourgeois families. And most significantly, of course, we see in Romeo and Juliet, the blossoming of a new love. In Antony and Cleopatra, they're already in love. They've already been having an affair. We join the play. The play opens late on, at a late stage, in their relationship.
- 5.9 Now, Shakespeare is often interested in the influence of women over men. In The Taming of the Shrew, you see Bianca has this incredible impact on men. Everyone wants to marry her. The problem is, you have to marry off her elder sister first before anyone can have her. That's the basic plot. In The Merchant of Venice, for the chance to marry Portia, the suitors have to solve a riddle, and they're willing to risk this, even

though the consequences are pretty severe, because if they get the riddle wrong, they have to forswear marriage forever. They have to say they will never marry again. One of the reasons why the story of Troilus and Cressida probably appealed to Shakespeare is that the Trojan War was entirely caused by the sexual appeal of Helen of Troy. And as we've seen, Lady Macbeth, and arguably as well, the witches, they have an influence over men, over Macbeth, insofar as they are able to dictate the way in which that he ends up acting, the way he performs the worst possible crimes.

5.10 But usually the appeal is sexual. When we're talking about the influence of women over men in Shakespeare, a lot of it is sexual. That clearly represents an elevation of passion over reason. The Dark Lady in the sonnets, we call her the Dark Lady. She's the subject of the last 28 of the sonnets. Remember, the first 126 are written to the young man, the last 28 to the Dark Lady. Katherine Duncan-Jones, who I mentioned earlier, she used to say that the last 28, that that was—it had numerical significance. Twenty-eight is relating to the number of days in the lunar calendar. It's tied into menstruation, I suppose. But the Dark Lady is clearly a sexual being. She is infected with venereal disease. She is not the idealized male love of those early sonnets.

5.11 Very occasionally in Shakespeare, we see a different kind of feminine influence. I think one of the most compelling female characters, one that I would love to play if I were female, is Volumnia. Volumnia is Coriolanus's mother. She's a fascinating character. She exerts so much influence over her son. She effectively created Coriolanus. Coriolanus is the warrior that he is because she is so hard-edged and determined and sometimes brutal. I think her influence over her son exceeds even that of Lady Macbeth's influence over Macbeth. Although you might say this can't be compared to the other examples I've given because we're talking about sexual relationships, actually Coriolanus' relationship with his mother, Volumnia, is insistently sexualized in the play.

5.12 I'm not suggesting it's incestuous. I'm not suggesting anything is going on, but they keep using imagery that characterize each other as if they were having sex. For instance, when Volumnia first appears, we see her chiding Coriolanus' wife, Virgilia, because she is pining away. She's crying because Coriolanus is off fighting in the wars. Volumnia says something very bizarre. She says, "If my son were my husband, I should freelier rejoice in that absence wherein he won honor than in the embracements of his bed where he would show most love." It's an odd thing for a mother to say about her son.

5.13 And Coriolanus, as well, seems to think of his mother as a wife. So if you consider the analogy that he reaches for at the very moment of his banishment, in which he casts Volumnia as a wife to his Hercules. He says, "Resume that spirit when you were wont to say, if you had been the wife of Hercules, six of his labors you'd have done, and saved your husband so much sweat." Now, we might dismiss these striking and strange formulations as mere passing fancies, except that they keep being reinforced in the play, and Volumnia does this in very explicit terms. She says, "Hear me profess

sincerely. Had I a dozen sons, each in my love alike, and none less dear than thine and my good Martius', I had rather had eleven die nobly for their country than one voluptuously surfeit out of action." So why that antithesis? Is it not peculiar that her mind leaps to the image of a son evading his duties on the battlefield for the sake of sexual gratification? Now, it's very, very odd. It's very odd.

- 5.14** Antony and Cleopatra is a bit more straightforward insofar as they are in a sexual relationship, and there are huge consequences to that. Shakespeare is drawing on the commonplace notion that a man's love for a woman has an emasculating effect. In *Coriolanus*, it's much cruder because it's about lust, rather than love sickness. It's very weird to hear a mother berating an imaginary son for having sex when he should be fighting. That's very odd. However, before I get on to Antony and Cleopatra, I want to do this chronologically. I want to start with his earliest love tragedy, with *Romeo and Juliet*. Early in his career, remember, he had written *Titus Andronicus*, which some like more than others. It's mostly successful, I think. It was certainly popular. *Romeo and Juliet* is probably his first tragic masterpiece, I would say.
- 5.15** I've said before that one of the features of classical tragedy is, of course, the notion of inevitability. We all know. We all know what's going to happen in *Romeo and Juliet*. We know it before the play begins. The story is familiar to all of us. It was famous then. It had been told many times. But if you didn't know, I mean, if you did happen to go along to a production of *Romeo and Juliet* not knowing what happens at the end, there's a prologue right at the start, which tells you straight off the bat, they're both going to die. Forget about it.
- 5.16** So the chorus says, "Two households, both alike in dignity in fair Verona, where we lay our scene. From ancient grudge break to new mutiny, where civil blood makes civil hands unclean. From forth the fatal loins of these two foes, a pair of star-crossed lovers take their life. Whose misadventured piteous overthrows doth with their death bury their parents' strife. The fearful passage of their death-marked love and the countenance of their parents' rage, which but their children's end, naught could remove, is now the two-hours' traffic of our stage; the which, if you with patient ears attend, what here shall miss, our toil shall strive to mend."
- 5.17** Remember what we said about *Macbeth*, how in that first opening scene with the witches, an awful lot of information is conveyed. Here in this prologue, with these rhyming couplets, very beautiful language, it tells us everything. It tells us we are in Verona. We know that the lovers are star-crossed; that is, their fates are against them. The stars have not aligned. We know that they're going to commit suicide. They take their life. The prologue is clear about that. We know that their families, the Montagues and the Capulets, are at war. It is described as an ancient grudge. These two families have been at loggerheads for an awful long time. We also know that the deaths of these two lovers at the end will "bury their parents' strife." In other words, when they

die, that will be the resolution of the conflict. That will resolve it. It's pretty much told you everything that's going to happen in the play in the first minute of the play.

- 5.18** Now, these words are spoken by the chorus, which is a conceit that you probably know from Greek tragedy. You have a figure or a group of figures who will comment on the action while it's going play, so a choric figure is one who is a surrogate for the audience. It's commenting on what they see happening as it's happening. The chorus here tells us that Romeo and Juliet's love is "death-marked", this interesting hyphenated compound, death-marked. It serves the function that it describes. In other words, by telling us their fate, it means that we observe the progression of their love with a continual sense of their inevitable ends. So Eros and Thanatos, they are engaged in their perpetual dance throughout this play. Eros and Thanatos, I mean by that, love and death.
- 5.19** Now, even in their moments of heightened ecstasy, we, the audience, know that Romeo and Juliet are doomed. They do not know that they are doomed. Again, we are in a state of dramatic irony, and this, of course, adds a certain poignancy to the play. I suppose what it does is it reminds us as audience members of the ephemeral nature of love. No loving relationship can last. People either break up or they die. Now this, we should not be too despairing about.
- 5.20** I often am reminded when I think about this of when I was at school. I was in a school play. I played a role, Pizarro, in Peter Schaffer's play, *Royal Hunt of the Sun*. And there's a line that he says that I've always remembered where he's talking about the nature of love. He says, "Imagine a fixed sunset, the last note of a song that hung an hour or a kiss for half of it." Pizarro's point is that pleasure has to be finite for it to be pleasurable at all. We have to know that it's going to end for it to mean anything. However, Pizarro reaches the conclusion that we are cheated by time, and that love and life is futile because there is death in everything. That's what he takes from that.
- 5.21** Now, I don't believe that *Romeo and Juliet*, as a play, has a particular message, but if it did, it wouldn't be that. It wouldn't be the idea that, because we're going to die, there's no point in falling in love. It would be, I think, very different from that. Romeo and Juliet have one night together as husband and wife. Their mutual desire is satisfied as quickly as it is extinguished. But that is why we find it so exhilarating, and that's also why it is so precious.
- 5.22** Now, Richard Dawkins, you all know who he is. He called one of his memoirs *Brief Candle in the Dark*. What he's doing there, he's not lamenting the shortness of life. He's not saying, "Look how pointless it is because life just starts and ends." He's celebrating how privileged we are to exist at all. I mean, the odds of any of us existing are near impossible. And this reminds us of how precious life is. Furthermore, the odds of any of us falling in love. These things matter because they are ephemeral. If you want a different view, you should read *Waiting for Godot*, by Samuel Beckett. There's that famous line. "They give birth, a stride, a grave. The light gleams an instant, then it's night once more." Very depressing. The image of a pregnant woman striding a grave.

The baby drops out. A bit of light. Into the grave. It's all over. I used to write that on birthday cards. I did it to remind friends of their mortality.

- 5.23** So yes, life is fleeting. We all know this. But love, even more so, even more so. And yet, it is made more valuable by the inevitability that it's going to end. And love is also the experience that we, I think most of us, find most difficult to articulate. And that's why we need poetry. The closest I've ever come to a perfect articulation of this universal human impulse is in Shakespeare, specifically in the sonnets of Shakespeare, the first 126, and in the poetry of Romeo and Juliet. So let's have a look. Let's consider what Juliet says in the famous balcony scene in Act 2, Scene 1. You will all know these lines by heart already, I'm sure.
- 5.24** "My bounty is as boundless as the sea, my love as deep. The more I give to thee, the more I have, for both are infinite." Now, think about that. There's a reason that is so famous. Could you change a single syllable in that and improve it? It's not possible. It is a kind of perfect articulation. It can't be paraphrased. If it is paraphrased, it becomes denuded of its power. In other words, that which it is attempting to express is intricately bound up with the way that it is expressed, through the poetry of that. What he's saying, think about it again. "My bounty is as boundless as the sea, my love as deep. The more I give to thee, the more I have, for both are infinite." The love is not transactional; it is not conditional. It is rather a glimpse of the numinous, a transcendental experience. In other words, death cannot kill it.
- 5.25** Juliet is describing a sensation that is unending, that goes beyond the here and now. This is a girl on a balcony, her lover below. It's just as well that they are young. As I say, she's only 13. He's probably around 15. Because one cannot rationalize a bounty as boundless as the sea. That is not rational. One cannot explain the infinite. First love, in other words, can be the purest love because there is no reason there. There is only passion there. They haven't become jaded with age and experience like I have. Now, on this point, it is interesting to draw comparisons with Romeo as apparent first love. Remember, before Romeo and Juliet get together, you know he's in love with someone else, isn't he? Rosaline. You all remember this from studying the play at school, presumably. But Rosaline isn't a first love at all. Not at all.
- 5.26** It's a really important aspect of the play that we have this contrast, because the significance of the love that Romeo feels for Juliet matters more because we've seen him feigning or with this teenage infatuation for Rosaline at the start of the play. So this is what Romeo says, Act 1, Scene 1. This is about Rosaline. "She'll not be hit with Cupid's arrow." He's complaining that she won't sleep with him. "She hath Dian's wit, and in strong proof of chastity well armed, from love's weak childish bow, she lives unharmed. She will not stay the siege of loving terms, nor bide the encounter of assailing eyes, nor ope her lap to saint-seducing gold. O, she is rich in beauty, only poor that when she dies, with beauty dies her store."

- 5.27 Now, what you're seeing there is a catalogue of romantic conventions. OK? You know when people are in love and they use clichés, don't they? It's almost like they're not really speaking for themselves. This is a perfect example of this. Rosaline will not be "hit with Cupid's arrow." She's guarding her chastity like Diana. The terms of his love are expressed militaristically. So he talks of her assailing eyes, the siege of loving terms. These are all familiar clichéd tropes. And then there's the commonplace of the love object swearing to chastity. That is also very, very common. Romeo says, "When she dies, with beauty dies her store." She is so beautiful. Rosaline is so gorgeous, when she dies, beauty itself will die as a concept if she hasn't reproduced.
- 5.28 Now, Shakespeare uses precisely that conceit in the first 17 of his sonnets, where he is urging the young man to marry. He's not doing that because he wants the young man to have a wife as such. He's doing it because he says he's so beautiful, he's the pinnacle of beauty, if he doesn't marry and have another child, have a son, his beauty won't be preserved forever. That's the conceit there. It's developed in all sorts of surprising ways. But in this case, in Rosaline's case, in Romeo and Juliet, it's deployed for its own sake. He says things like, Rosaline will not "ope her lap to saint-seducing gold." So he's imagining a sexual transaction there. He is melancholic, but it's a very kind of adolescent melancholia, isn't it? It's a teenage tantrum, I suppose. And it is, of course, pretentious—a teenager's sexual urge performed as high romance. We've all seen that. I used to be a school teacher. I've seen it many times. And it has all the figures of speech that you would expect.
- 5.29 Now, Romeo's best friend is Mercutio, key character. He's absolutely right to mock Romeo for this infatuation, let's call it, for Rosaline. He does mock him, ruthlessly, at the party that they gatecrash at the Capulets' home. Romeo, at the party, has seen Juliet. It is love at first sight, and he's run after her. Mercutio undercuts this moment. He's left with Benvolio, and he calls out for Romeo because he's run off. He calls out for Romeo, and he does it in this funny way. He pretends he's a magician, summoning a spirit. The idea is that, if you say the name of the spirit, it will appear. So he uses all these different names for Romeo. He shouts, "Romeo! Humours! Madman! Passion! Lover! Appear thou in the likeness of a sigh. Speak but one rhyme, and I am satisfied. Cry but, 'Ay, me.' Pronounce but, 'love' and 'dove.' Speak to my gossip Venus one fair word, one nickname for her purblind son and heir."
- 5.30 Now, he means there Cupit, of course, the purblind son of Venus, who Romeo himself evoked earlier on. But note that Mercutio is mocking the idea of lovers' sentimental poetry there. He mentions the basic rhyme of love and dove. I don't know if you've read *Much Ado About Nothing*. You might remember when Benedick is trying to write a love poem for Beatrice. Do you remember this? And he says, "I can find out no rhyme to 'lady', but 'baby', an innocent rhyme; for 'scorn' 'horn', a hard rhyme; for 'school' 'fool', a babbling rhyme. Very ominous endings. No, I was not born under a rhyming planet."

- 5.31 Now, according to Mercutio, Romeo is simply an idiot. He's fallen for a girl. And Mercutio imagines that Romeo will appear in the likeness of a sigh. You can imagine the idea of how lovers sigh. The sighing lover is another commonplace image. But there's nothing transcendental in Mercutio's conceptualization of love. It's all clichés, it's all performance, it's all ritual, which makes this ritualistic summoning of Romeo all the more apt. But more than this, Mercutio sees love as a guise for sex. He has the kind of cynicism about love that Thersites has in *Troilus and Cressida*. He thinks we're all whoremongers and whoremasters. Mercutio, very cynical and funny with it, the kind of friend you would want to have, the kind of friend who grounds you.
- 5.32 Like I say, he sees these rituals as just basically people wanting sex. A lot of people do see that, do see the rituals of love as just a prelude to sex. Flowers, a candlelit meal, a walk along the river. People see that's something you have to go through to get sex. It's very cynical. Every society has its own conventions about love. We used to call it courtship. You could argue that these conventions are simply a kind of attempt to apply the sheen of civilization to something that is visceral, instinctive, animalistic, messy—making sex respectable. You could say that that is what the discourse of love is all about. That's what a cynic would say. That's what Mercutio would say. That's what Thersites would say, that sex is just this animalistic, primitive force, sonnets and flowers and golden rings that makes it palatable.
- 5.33 That is, as I say, how Mercutio sees it. Shakespeare is keen to see that view represented. We don't know what Shakespeare thought about that. I don't agree with that in any way, by the way, just to say. I hope that most of us don't. I think it's far too cynical. But let's carry on looking at what Mercutio says when he's performing this faux-summoning of Romeo. He says, "I conjure thee by Rosaline's bright eyes, by her high forehead and her scarlet lip, by her fine foot, straight leg, and quivering thigh, by the demesnes that there adjacent lie." Well, it couldn't be much more explicit than that, could it? I mean, he doesn't mind being anatomically specific there.
- 5.34 Also, of course, this is a parody of a very well-known poetical form of the time called the blason. Love poetry often deployed this idea of the blason. It's very Petrarchan. It's the idea of when a lover compartmentalizes the object of his or her devotion. So, he will describe each part of a beloved's face. You know the kind of thing I mean? Her golden hair, her eyes like stars, her lips as red as roses. You break down each element of the individual's face. And lovers were expected to write poetry of this kind. This is totally predictable. The reason why Mercutio mocks it is because it is a cliché. And so Shakespeare, although he does sometimes borrow these tropes, he also likes to gently ridicule those same tropes.
- 5.35 So for instance, in *Twelfth Night*, Olivia itemizes her own body. She does the blason for her her lover. She says, "I will give out diverse schedules of my beauty. It shall be inventoried, and every particle and utensil labeled to my will, as, item, two lips, indifferent red; item, two gray eyes, with lids to them; item, one neck, one chin, and so

forth." She's mocking, right? It's a joke about the rather jaded poetical convention, but it also insinuates that the love object, and what she might object to this, is that the love object is being commodified, treated like something to be sold or bought.

5.36 Now, then you've got Biron, by the way, in *Love's Labour's Lost*, another early comedy. In that, he says he won't degrade himself by writing the blason, writing this poetry. He says, "When shall you hear that I will praise a hand, a foot, a face, an eye, a gait, a state, a brow, a breast, a waist, a leg, a limb?" That's in Act 4. In the 106th sonnet, Shakespeare employs the same idea. He talks of the ancient poets and their "blason of sweet beauties best, of hand, of foot, of lip, of eye, of brow." And this is the convention that Mercutio is mocking.

5.37 Now, in modern parlance, we'd say Mercutio is keeping Romeo grounded, but he's also a reminder of—well, that Romeo, in finding Juliet, has moved beyond this. He's a reminder of the journey of Romeo. Mercutio is concerned with sex. Mercutio is not concerned with love. I don't think he understands it. And he assumes that Romeo, like all teenage boys, is the same. Let's quickly go back to this conjuring ritual. I think it tells us so much. So Benvolio tells Mercutio to stop shouting, to stop making an exhibition of himself. And Mercutio replies, "This cannot anger him. It would anger him to raise a spirit in his mistress' circle of some strange nature, letting it there stand till she had laid it and conjured it down." It's a double-entendre. So, I mean, this is—Mercutio is filthy. He says, we've got a magician. He's talking about a magician raises a spirit in a circle on the floor. That's the convention. But a spirit is slang for penis. Romeo's spirit will be raised in his mistress's circle, her vagina. It will stand, that is, become erect until she has conjured it down.

5.38 And he carries on like this. He says, "Now will he sit under a medlar tree and wish his mistress were that kind of fruit as maids call medlars when they laugh alone." And a medlar is a type of fruit which the Elizabethans thought resembled the female genitalia. And of course, meddling has sexual connotations. Mercutio then says, "O, Romeo, that she were, O that she were an open-arse, and thou a poperin pear." That doesn't need much explanation, really. A medlar was also known as an open-arse. The shape of the poperin pear is obviously phallic, lends itself to another double-entendre, pop her in, poperin. Now, I'm mentioning all of this not to be gratuitous. Mercutio is being gratuitous. But I'm saying this because I want to remind you that this is locker room chat. That's what's going on here.

5.39 I once heard Germaine Greer talking about *Romeo and Juliet* as just being a bawdy play. She was being quite dismissive and funny about it. I think she's brilliant, by the way. But yes, and it is. It is vulgar. It's more vulgar than people remember, I think, particularly through this character. But that is really, really important. It's a bit like if you think about the *Canterbury Tales*, Chaucer's *Canterbury Tales*. We have the vulgarity of the *Miller's Tale*, which is very, very sexually crude, which has the effect of elevating the *Knight's Tale*, which has high romance, high love. It's the contrasts that

give us the impact. We have the degradation of someone like Mercutio, degrading love as a form of sex or as a concealment for sex. Then we have true, transcendental, celestial love, as depicted so beautifully in the relationship of Romeo and Juliet. I think it's a very effective thing.

- 5.40** The reason why Troilus and Cressida is so cynical is because you don't get that. You don't get that alternative perception. Sex throughout that is always, or love, is always just a guise for sex. It's always grotesque. It's always degrading. So the effect of those two plays is very, very different. If you think, how can you really—how can you reconcile Mercutio talking about genitalia in the way he does? How do you reconcile that with "my bounty is as boundless as the sea, my love as deep"? It doesn't work, does it? The two—it can't be done, and I'm pleased about that.
- 5.41** Now, of course, sex can be transcendental in itself. This is something that Shakespeare explores here. The sexual act between Romeo and Juliet is not degrading. It's elevating, it's heightening, it's spiritual. Romeo's journey, in other words, is from adolescent lust to a higher form of love. OK. By the way, Mercutio is also really important because he offers that anticipation of their fate in that very chilling line. When he dies, the moment of his death, he curses them. It's a very famous line. "A plague on both your houses," and it's a very powerful moment, not least because I think we've warmed to Mercutio quite extensively.
- 5.42** OK, now, there are some who, in reading the play, find that it's all about immaturity. Some people take the view that this is just about young people who are mistaking lust for love, young people who lack the experience to see it for what it is. And many, many, many critics have pointed out that the mechanisms of the play actually suggest a comedy. The narrative structure, the things that occur, all are suggestive of a comedy plot. There's the coincidences. You've got the servant with the letter about the Capulet party, the Capulet feast. Romeo and Benvolio just happened to run into this guy. Coincidences like that tend to happen in comedy of this time. There's the Friar's scheme of a sleeping potion which will make Juliet appear to be dead, which seems a little farcical, if you stop to think about it for a moment. There's the message from the Friar that informs Romeo of the plan, but that arrives too late. Again, that's another comedic idea.
- 5.43** Then there are other comic characters. There's Mercutio we've spoken about. There's the cantankerous Nurse, who's a brilliant character. She arranges the marriage. She's very compelling. We don't really have time to go into her here, but fantastic character. Indeed, you've got the whole setup. Two middle-class rival families hate each other. Two of their children fall in love. It is the stuff of comedy. It should be, but it's not. The critic, Peter Sacchar, has talked about this, that the play evades the comedic, and the way that it evades the comedic is because of the sublime nature of the poetry of the piece. That's why Romeo and Juliet works brilliantly as tragedy, rather than descending

into farce, because nobody had written about love in this way before—or since, I should add.

- 5.44 And of course, we'd normally be right to be a bit cynical about a story of two teenage lovers because there's no gravitas in that dramatic setup. But it is undeniable, I think, that the poetry that Shakespeare grants to these lovers, and particularly, I should say, the words that he gives to Juliet, takes it into another metaphysical realm. I think it's very difficult, actually, to read their scenes as just the mere folly of youth. I don't think it's coherent, and I don't think it's honest. Great poetry, as I've said, is often about expressing the inexpressible, finding a language for feelings that we can't otherwise express, and thereby making them comprehensible. When people fall into cliché, that's because they don't know how else to find the words to express the feeling. That doesn't mean, by the way, that bad poetry means that the feeling is not authentic. Of course, it doesn't mean that. It doesn't signify that the emotion isn't real.
- 5.45 We've talked about the conventions of love as though it's a ritual, a performance. But consider another possibility. When someone sends a tacky love poem, "Roses are red, violets are blue," etc., it's perfectly possible, isn't it, that the emotion that they feel is every bit as profound as that as Romeo and Juliet. Why not? I mean, Oscar Wilde wrote in his essay, *The Critic as Artist*, that "all bad poetry springs from genuine feeling." If you've ever seen epitaphs in a graveyard, some of them are very mawkish, but you know that they are deeply, deeply mourning of these people they have lost. But Shakespeare, of course, doesn't do bad poetry, unless he's deliberately doing bad poetry for his characters. He's obviously the best of poets. So, yes, he can mimic bad poetry when he wants to. But when he writes for Juliet, he gives her the language of the heavens.
- 5.46 And more than this, he contrasts her with Romeo. Romeo really struggles with this. Romeo really struggles to find the words. He doesn't have the eloquence, the gift that Juliet does. So Romeo keeps falling back on cliché, and Juliet interrupts him. Let's go to that balcony scene again, very famous scene. Romeo says, "Lady, by yonder blessed moon I vow, that tips with silver all these fruit-tree tops." And Juliet stops him and says, "O, swear not by the moon, the inconstant moon that monthly changes in her circled orb, lest that thy love prove likewise variable." And so Romeo says, "What shall I swear by?" Juliet says, "Do not swear at all, or if thou wilt, swear by thy gracious self, which is the god of my idolatry, and I'll believe thee." So in the entirety of the balcony scene, she's guiding him. She's leading him beyond the tropes of love into the experiential thrill of something truly heavenly.
- 5.47 I think where the postmodernists get it wrong, well, I think they get it wrong in lots of ways, but I think it's their insistence that love, like every other human experience, is entirely constructed through the language that we use to express it. I think that's flat-out wrong. Because these emotions would exist. They would still exist if we were a species of mutes. What Shakespeare achieves in *Romeo and Juliet* is a language of love

that brings us as close as possible to the feeling that inspired it. Sorry, just to restate what I said earlier, he gives us a glimpse of the numinous. That's what I think Shakespeare does better than any other writer.

- 5.48** Now, James Joyce described sentimentality as unearned emotion. I think that's a very good definition. But there's nothing sentimental in *Romeo and Juliet*. Their language is not, as Hazlitt put it, "an insipid interchange of sentiments lip-deep, learnt at second-hand from poems and plays." It speaks to an authentic devotion that most of us will be lucky enough, I hope, to feel in our lifetimes. So I want to move on from Shakespeare's first love tragedy to his last love tragedy. Now, we can see during this process, from *Romeo and Juliet*, if you read them back to back, it's an interesting exercise. *Romeo and Juliet* through to *Antony and Cleopatra*, you can see that his artistry has matured, and so too the theme. The young lovers become mature lovers.
- 5.49** Now, if you wanted an alternative title for *Antony and Cleopatra*, I think you could do worse than borrow from that text that I quoted at the start, Sidney's *Arcadia*, the "skirmish betwixt reason and passion." I think that gets to the heart of what *Antony and Cleopatra* is all about. It's what's going on in the play. *Antony and Cleopatra* is a sequel to *Julius Caesar*, if you like. I'm going to get onto that play in the next lecture. But it's a very different kind of tragedy. *Antony and Cleopatra*, it's one of the longer plays. It's very fast-paced, however. There's lots and lots of very short scenes, even though it is, chronologically, it takes place in a long—it's a decade, roughly a decade. I've mentioned before, I think, these rapid scene divisions, and that this is really appropriate because it has a reflective quality of the frenzied intensity of the love between the two main protagonists.
- 5.50** It's very much an innovative play. The critic, M. R. Ridley, pointed this out. He said, "The story of *Antony and Cleopatra*, as narrated by Plutarch," the source, "is not in its essence dramatic at all. There is no proper forward progress, and so no plot; it is merely a series of oscillations on the part of Antony." So what's happened is, Shakespeare has taken this story from Plutarch, this true story, as it happens, and has created a new imagining of this famous relationship. That's the one that stuck, hasn't it? I mean, if you think of *Cleopatra*, you do think of Shakespeare's *Cleopatra*, don't you? That's the image that stuck. I mean, even that iconic cinematic image of *Cleopatra* in the films, that's Elizabeth Taylor in the 1963 film *Cleopatra*, not Amanda Barrie in the 1964 film, *Carry on Cleo*. Although I should say that the makers of *Carry on Cleo* used exactly the same set because it was left over, and they wanted to save money, which is quite funny.
- 5.51** But we do think of Shakespeare. That depiction of *Cleopatra* is not like what *Cleopatra* looked like. We think of her as the most beautiful woman in the world. We think of Elizabeth Taylor. By the way, that film, the Joseph Manckiewicz film of 1963, is not based on Shakespeare, but it clearly draws from Shakespeare in the way that it is written, in the way that it is presented. This often happens with Shakespeare. What

Shakespeare writes about historical figures tends to stick, doesn't it? When you think of Richard III, you think of, "Now is the winter of our discontent." You think of the hunchback killer of the princes in the Tower. You think of Shakespeare, which is why a lot of the big obsessives about Richard III are insistent that it was all Tudor propaganda. They say, "Oh, we didn't have a hunched back." They were very gutted when they found his skeleton in that car park in Leicester. And in fact, he did have a hunched back. They were upset about that. Anyway, I'm getting off-track.

5.52 Now, Ridley, the critic I quoted there, makes the point that Antony and Cleopatra only really works because Antony is depicted as a man whose fate matters to the world. So he's the great triumvir. You remember what happens. Octavius, Lepidus, and Antony form the Triumvirate. They have control of all the western provinces of the Roman Republic. After the Battle of Philippi, this extends to the eastern provinces as well. That's the battle that appears in the last few scenes of Julius Caesar, where Brutus and Cassius die. They had this huge spread of territory across the globe between the three of them, a major global power. This matters in the play because Antony's intense obsession for Cleopatra brings him down. There are global consequences to this love affair.

5.53 Now, for her part, Cleopatra dominates the play as much as she dominates Antony. She is a marvelous character. She is one of Shakespeare's best characters. She is direct, she's waspish, she's conceited, she's witty, she's rash, she's unintellectual, she's iconic, she's a woman of infinite variety, she is the beautiful and majestic serpent of the Old Nile. There is no one else like her in English drama. And unlike King Lear, this play sustains this notion of tragic inevitability. We know what's going to happen, and we know what's going to happen because we know our history, don't we? We know that Mark Antony will miscalculate at the Battle of Actium. He will fall to Octavius. We know that Octavius is to become Augustus, the first Emperor of Rome. We know that Antony will kill himself, believing that Cleopatra is dead, which is a historical account that obviously echoes the fate of Romeo. We know also how Cleopatra dies, don't we? You don't even have to know the play. If you know your history, she dies by allowing an asp to bite her and poison her.

5.54 Now, this historical inevitability gives the play its grandeur. So the stakes could not be higher, really. We want to know, when we watch this play, we want to see how Shakespeare is going to depict these monumental events. And he doesn't disappoint. The death of Cleopatra is breathtaking. It's one of the most iconic scenes ever written. As the asp bites into her flesh and releases its poison, she cries out to Charmian, "Dost thou not see my baby at my breast, that sucks the nurse asleep?" It is the conflation of the magisterial and the profoundly human that marks this moment out as so impressively potent. We see this grandeur. I mean, even though Cleopatra can be rash and she can be truculent and all the rest of it, she has an innate majesty about her. We

see this. It's encapsulated very famously in a short speech by Enobarbus. This is from Act 2, Scene 2, and he describes her appearance on the Nile.

5.55 He says, "The barge she sat in, like a burnished throne, burned on the water. The poop was beaten gold, purple the sails, and so perfumed that the winds were lovesick with them. The oars were silver, which to the tune of flutes kept stroke, and made the water which they beat to follow faster, as amorous of their strokes. For her own person, it beggared all description. She did lie in her pavilion—cloth of gold, of tissue—o'er-picturing that Venus where we see the fancy outwork nature. On each side her stood pretty dimpled boys, like smiling Cupids, with diverse-colored fans whose wind did seem to glow the delicate cheeks which they did cool, and what they undid, did." The opulence of that, the luxury of that, the splendor of it, the grandeur, as I say. The reality of Cleopatra outdoes what the artists can do even in their depiction of Venus. That is what Enobarbus is saying. She is desire. She is beauty. She is Egypt.

5.56 Even in the opening of the play, we have a distillation of everything that we're about to see unfold. This is much like the prologue of *Romeo and Juliet*, which I mentioned earlier. Now, these lines, it's not a prologue. It's delivered by the character of Philo, and it tells us everything we need to know. These are the words. "Nay, but this dotage of our General's o'erflows the measure. Those his goodly eyes, that o'er the files and musters of the war have glowed like plated Mars, now bend, now turn the office and devotion of their view upon a tawny front." OK, so his eyes glowing like not armored but plated Mars, the god of war. That's what Antony is. He's a warrior, and now he's bending. His eyes are turning to a tawny front, the darkened skin of Cleopatra.

5.57 "His captain's heart, which in the scuffles of great fights hath burst the buckles on his breast, reneges all temper, and is become the bellows and the fan to cool a gypsy's lust." And then, "Take but good note, and you shall see in him the triple pillar of the world transformed into a strumpet's fool." The triple pillar of the world, the Triumvirate, the triumvir, transformed into a fool for this strumpet. This very dismissive line about Cleopatra. And she's often represented in this way by the people in Antony's army because they can see that their general is completely losing the plot over this woman and that they will no longer be winning the battles that they ought to win. And this speech by Enobarbus really pushes the might, the sheer power of Antony, his captain's heart, when "in the scuffles of great fights hath burst the buckles on his breast."

5.58 Now here, they become depleted. His temper reneged, he becomes the "fan to cool a gypsy's lust." The phrase gypsy, tawny front. So we get this association of dark skin and sensuality. This is why the Globe Theatre very recently applied a trigger warning to the production of *Antony and Cleopatra*. They really did that. They put an online disclaimer that says that the playwright is guilty of "misogynoir", which is one of those nonsensical modern terms. Those terms just signal fealty to an ideological belief system, the very belief system that has been such a disaster for the arts. But I'm getting on my high

horse now. So let's move on, because I do think Shakespeare himself is more interesting than any of his vandals.

- 5.59** Now, Antony himself is a study of how, when we are in love, we become risk-takers; we become obsessives. Everything else in life becomes unimportant. So love is therefore a kind of madness. This is why—we've all seen it. We all must know people who've left their spouses of many decades and run off with a new paramour, endangered their relationship with their children, their livelihood. They lose it all. They don't care because the intensity of love is such that people don't think anymore. They kill for love. They die for love. It can be the most concentrated and inexplicable of all human experiences. And here is Antony, the great triumvir, saying he doesn't care about Rome. That's how far he's gone.
- 5.60** He says, "Let Rome in Tiber melt," the River Tiber in Rome. "Let Rome in Tiber melt, and the wide arch of the ranged empire fall. Here is my space. Kingdoms are clay. Our dungy earth alike feeds beast as man. The nobleness of life is to do thus," and he kisses Cleopatra. At the same time, he knows that his passion for Cleopatra is destroying his reason. Remember I said we could call this "the skirmish betwixt reason and passion." Antony knows it. I think a lot of people who are in love and behaving foolishly know they are behaving foolishly. There's a really good book by Hazlitt. I keep mentioning Hazlitt because I think he's the best critic of Shakespeare. He wrote in the early 1800s.
- 5.61** He wrote a book about a woman he fell in love with, called *Liber Amoris*, book of love. He has humiliated himself. He's fallen for this younger woman. He ruined his reputation. He wrote this book saying what he had done. You can tell when you read it, she doesn't care about him, but he keeps persisting. He's so obsessive, and he's willing to give up everything. It's such a common experience. Antony is doing the same. But like I say, he knows it, in the way that Hazlitt knew it. He knew he was humiliating himself, couldn't help it, and didn't care. Antony says—this is Act 1, Scene 2—he says, "These strong Egyptian fetters I must break, or lose myself in dotage." I've got to stop doing this. But he doesn't, does he?
- 5.62** There's also a marked disparity between love and masculinity. In *Romeo and Juliet*, Romeo says, he says it quite explicitly, in Act 2, Scene 1, he says, "O sweet Juliet, thy beauty hath made me effeminate, and in my temper softened valour's steel." Then we've got in *Antony and Cleopatra*, Antony says that his "sword has been made weak by affection." So this theme of Antony's metaphorical emasculation at the hands of the beloved, this is a light motif that recurs throughout the play. We keep getting these images that he has become emasculated through his contact with Cleopatra. His lieutenant says, "Our leader's led, and we are women's men." That's Act 3, Scene 7. And Scarus, who reports on Antony's retreat, he says, "I never saw an action of such shame. Experience, manhood, honor, ne'er before did violate so itself."
- 5.63** And what does Caesar say? "He hath given up his empire to a whore." And then after the battle is lost, Antony blames Cleopatra directly. He comes back and he says, "You

did know how much you were my conqueror, and that my sword, made weak by my affection, would obey it on all cause." Cleopatra cries out, "Pardon, pardon!" And Antony doesn't hesitate. Straightaway, he reverses his entire position. He says, "Fall not a tear, I say. One of them rates all that is one and lost. Give me a kiss." One of your tears is more important than me losing this battle. Reverse straightaway. That's all she has to do, is cry out. Her influence is so bewitching, hypnotic, all-encompassing. He kisses her and says, "Even this repays me."

- 5.64** In other words, Cleopatra's love for him and his love for her has the effect of instantaneously reclaiming him. They are the center of the universe. Nothing else matters at all, and that is the case in both *Romeo and Juliet* and *Antony and Cleopatra*. Shakespeare is dealing with transcendental love, the transcendental heights of love. And when you are in love, Shakespeare seems to say, nothing else matters.
- 5.65** Thanks a lot. Perhaps we can have some questions about *Romeo and Juliet*, *Antony and Cleopatra*, or love more broadly. I'm very experienced.
- 5.66** I was going to ask, what is it in your opinion that makes the—or what is it about the human condition that explains the enduring popularity, enduring appeal, of love tragedies? Perhaps with reference to your earlier original question, what is in particular about Shakespeare's?
- 5.67** Yes, it's a very good philosophical question. I think, really, the reason is what I attempted to outline in the lecture, that we don't have words for it. I think we rely on poets, we rely on greater minds than ours to find a way to articulate the feelings that we all share. I think the reason why Shakespeare is so important in this regard is those dreaded words I said at the very start of this series about universality. Shakespeare's timelessness, the word that modern critics seem to hate, the idea—they've got this idea that everything is a social construct. They've been completely imbued with postmodernism.
- 5.68** So they would say that we cannot possibly understand the emotions that someone at Shakespeare's time felt because we are in a different time and place and we are just cultural products. I don't think that's true. I don't think the evidence tells us that this is true. One of my favorite things in literature is reading ancient works, works from centuries before I was born, and finding that they are sharing the exact same experience that I am. There's a really good poem by Arnold called *Dover Beach*, where he's standing on the shore and he's looking at the sea and he's imagining the ancient, the classical writers hearing the same, Aegean shore. Nothing changes. This is something that Shakespeare's love tragedies in particular remind us. Nothing really changes.
- 5.69** I've seen all of these experiences, the things that we've seen Romeo do, Juliet, Antony, Cleopatra. I've seen those relationships up close with people I know. They don't speak as eloquently about them, but the emotion is the same. And I think whilst Shakespeare

does remind us of the infinite variety of humankind, we are all very, very, very different people. There are these strands that connect us, which are these transcendental experiences. And those are the things that I think we should be focusing on more generally on a philosophical point, that focus on our similarities. We're all human beings. We all have these things in common. I think through Shakespeare, because he was that unique genius, could find a way to convey those ideas in verse. That's why it's valuable, and that's why I think we keep returning to him. If these emotions weren't cross-cultural, weren't trans-historical, weren't timeless, I don't think we'd keep going back to him.

- 5.70** I wanted to ask you about the concept of the divine feminine in Shakespeare around that time, because you had, obviously, Juliet has the divine tongue, which Romeo doesn't. You have Portia showing her love in the Merchant of Venice that Bassanio doesn't match when he gives away the ring, etc. Obviously, this is when there's a female on the throne that is helping Shakespeare as well. There's that context as well. But why do you think there's such a love for the divine feminine in Shakespeare? Because all of the women in Shakespeare are incredibly powerful, incredibly strong, and none of them are weak, ephemeral characters like you've seen in other places. They all have incredibly powerful parts to play. Desdemona, Ophelia, Beatrice, they're all incredibly strong-willed people. Why do you think that is?
- 5.71** It's a very interesting question because, at the time, women in literature were often caricatured as either virgin or whore. Very, very simplified representations. Shakespeare doesn't do that. You're right. I think the closest he comes to doing that is Taming of the Shrew. But even that is really more complex than people give it credit for. Yeah, well, he wasn't a misogynist. I think that's clear. His characters, even writing at a time where women were completely considered second-class citizens, valued much less, you're right. Harold Bloom used to say that he seemed to prefer women. He seemed to value, respect women more. His women have intellect, agency. They are all individual characters—Rosalind from As You Like It, for instance, an incredible character, Cleopatra, and even Lady Macbeth, just an incredibly wonderful, complex character. So, yeah, you're right.
- 5.72** I don't know whether it points to a perception that he had of the divine feminine, of the idea of an idealization of women. I think it more points to the idea that Shakespeare could see all manifestations of humanity. This is why I'm going back to what I say about the individual characters that he creates. I think he is able to see the world through so many different kinds of eyes and, be that male or female, it clearly didn't matter to him. He could do both equally well. I know some feminist critics would disagree with me and say that the depiction is—well, I think they tend to simplify the depictions that he achieves. But I think you're right. I think there is something in Shakespeare that isn't going to fall back on caricature. It might be as simple as that. He has an allergy to caricature. He doesn't want to make individual ciphers that represent

something else. He wants them to be living, breathing human beings. He does that with the women as much as he does with the men, I think.

- 5.73** I wonder, who do you think has come closest to Shakespeare in terms of writing love tragedies and creating characters that have a bit of a chance of becoming timeless in modern days?
- 5.74** It's a really good question. I would say no one. I mean, this is the problem. I don't think —this is why I keep returning to Shakespeare when it comes to this. I mean, there are other representations in literature of the intensity of love and the experience of love that are moving, that are profound. If you think about the last chapter of *Ulysses*, this is the chapter that is written without any punctuation. His wife is lying in bed, Molly Bloom is lying in bed. I'm sorry, he's lying in bed and he feels the outline of her shape in bed. That's very powerful. That's very heartbreaking. What else is there? The Hazlitt book that I mentioned, although it's not a work of fiction, I suppose that would fall into that category.
- 5.75** But where are—I mean, it's a good question. Where are the great stories of love? Can you think of any in film, even? In modern playwriting? I don't think anything really comes close. I think that's why we need this. I think that's why we need to go back. If you go back early, if you go back to the ancients, you could say that the relationship of Jason and Medea, for instance, what that does capture is the absolute intensity of the relationship, similar to Antony and Cleopatra, I suppose. But of course, she ends up killing the kids and it doesn't work out. I think what happens is, you catch glimpses of it in other people's work. I've seen glimpses of it in E. M. Forster's novels. I've seen glimpses of it in Forrest Reid's novels. I've seen glimpses of it in a modern context, I suppose, in Kazuo Ishiguro's novels, who is a great, I think, poet of love and loss who writes in novelistic form.
- 5.76** But again, all of these things are just, I suppose, scraps. I haven't read anything that has the sustained power of Shakespeare's sonnets, say. I think even in his own lifetime, I'm racking my brains now, but maybe *Astrophel and Stella* by Philip Sidney has some of that. But again, there's an element in that that it's about—you know, Petrarch, I suppose, the sonnets to Laura. But again, it doesn't reach those heights that Shakespeare does. I suppose my answer is, I've never come across anything that comes close. I know that's probably not what you wanted to hear, but can anyone think of anything that comes?
- 5.77** I was just going to mention the relationship between Grushenka and Mitya in the *Brothers K* is definitely something that—I mean, that's more actionable, I suppose. It's not like—
- 5.78** Yeah. Like I say, I think there are examples. I think it's a very individual thing as well, isn't it? It's something where it has to be your response to the relationships that we see. Do you know what I want to do? I want to go and think about this and maybe

come back and—because I think there are other books I could think of that do come close, but off the top of my head, I can't. I think it's quite revealing that I can't, isn't it?

Lecture 6: Caesar's Consequences

At a glance — Julius Caesar, populism, and political consequence.

- 6.1 The word populist is often said with a sneer. In a thriving democracy, one would have thought it would be laudable for political figures to appeal directly to the concerns of the people. Yet populism is widely derided as a cynical desire for the approval of the common man, whipped up by hostility towards the elite and the scapegoating of minorities for society's ills. Now, despite some efforts to reclaim the term, the word populist, I think we'll all agree, is generally used as a pejorative in the commentary of today. I wonder why the concept of populism ought to be so distrusted. The often rapid rise and fall of political movements spearheaded by charismatic figures is nothing new.
- 6.2 Shakespeare captures the unpredictability of these developments in Henry VI: Part 2, with Jack Cade, Jack Cade's Rebellion of 1450, against the high taxes and prices levied against property owners in Kent. Like many of the populist figures of today, Shakespeare's Cade is able to harness a generalized disdain for the elites. That seems to be the principle aspect of populism. One of Cade's rebels shouts out, "The first thing we do, let's kill all the lawyers." Now, you can imagine some of the more militant members of the anti-capitalist Occupy Wall Street campaign of 2011, they might have said a similar thing. "Let's kill all the bankers." You can imagine it a similar effect there.
- 6.3 Now, the seismic nature of recent populist movements that we've been seeing over the past few years has tended to be amplified by a disproportionate response by members of the political and media class. I think what I'm saying is that, rather than reflect on why it is that so many in the public are desperate for change, many commentators have been driven to emotive reactions. We've heard this typified in what they call Trump derangement syndrome or Brexit derangement syndrome. That's how these things manifest, and they tend to manifest as a fear of democracy. I don't care which side of those debates that you stand on. I think we can all see that the reaction is sometimes almost hysterical, to the point where they start saying that the public are too capricious. The electorate cannot be trusted with making these important decisions.
- 6.4 I'll give an example. There's a book by the political philosopher Jason Brennan called *Against Democracy* that was written in 2016, that key year of both Brexit and Trump, in which he argues that voters are too fickle, too ill-informed, too easily manipulated to be entrusted with major decisions. Do you remember that phrase during the Brexit campaign, low information voters? I actually find it quite chilling. And in this book, Brennan favors what we might call an epistocracy. Epistocracy, the rule of the knowledgeable, which is a notion reminiscent of Plato's idea of philosopher kings. Opponents of that view, by contrast, remind us that it is natural and healthy for politicians to fear the people, that that's the way it ought to be.

- 6.5 Now, the British socialist, Tony Benn, he was fond of asking five key questions regarding democracy. He used to say, and these are the five questions, "What power have you got? Where did you get it from? In whose interests do you use it? To whom are you accountable? And most importantly, how do we get rid of you?" And I think that final question really strikes at the heart of what it means to live in a democracy, to live in a society free from tyranny. Because in a democracy, those in political authority are our servants. They're the servants of the people, and they should be able to be dispensed with at the collective whim of the people. So whereas populism is seen as a woeful scourge on society, I think, isn't simply a sign that there are lots of people in power who would rather that we didn't hear that final question that Tony Benn asked, "How do we get rid of you?"
- 6.6 Now, the reason I mention all this is because it is directly relevant to what Shakespeare explores in *Julius Caesar*. Shakespeare grapples with this Leviathan of populism in a manner that I think was unprecedented at this time on the English stage. His history plays, for instance, explore his fascination with the relationship between monarchs and their subjects, even going so far as to dramatize the deposition of Richard II. I mentioned this in a previous lecture. We know, or at least there's a strong case to be made, that when Shakespeare's *Richard II* was published, it was censored by the Master of the Revels. This would have been in the mid-1590s. The deposition scene taken out, it's seen as too inflammatory, too provocative. It wasn't published, as in, that deposition scene didn't get published until after the death of Elizabeth I.
- 6.7 And while the theatrical representation of a deposed monarch was definitely controversial during Shakespeare's time, well, I mean, you could be killed, you could be executed for mocking the monarch, Shakespeare could then, could sidestep this, and he did so in a very clever way. He wasn't worried about censorship because he turned his eye to ancient Rome. This is what he did. So, two of his Roman plays in particular, *Julius Caesar* and *Coriolanus*, these raise significant questions about the enduring appeal of populism and its unpredictable and also potentially chaotic outcomes. And at the same time, I think Shakespeare exposes how our leaders are not immune to that universal human susceptibility to corruption.
- 6.8 So the history of ancient Rome, I don't know how much you know about it. It's not for the squeamish. It is said that Caligula was fond of torture, rape, and incest, and that Caligula was so hairy that he would execute anyone who mentioned goats. Then there's Caracalla, Caracalla who had his own brother slaughtered by the Praetorian guard while his brother was being cradled in the arms of their mother. Nero, Emperor Nero, castrated a slave. This slave boy, he castrated him and then married him, in order to replace the wife that he had kicked to death while she was pregnant. Now, stories of this kind, they might have been exaggerated, of course, by the likes of Suetonius and Tacitus, the historians with a grudge and a flair for the sensational. But the short life

expectancy of emperors, particularly when you get to the 3rd century AD, does show that bloodshed was quite unremarkable in this period of political life.

6.9 Now, most historians will agree that the precedent of political violence was set by the death of Tiberius Gracchus in 133 BC. He was a plebeian tribune. He had attempted to implement agrarian reforms, very controversial reforms, give the land and power back to the people. It would have seen the land redistributed from the wealthy to the poor. I think we can trace the origins of populism to this time. You had a system where the Senate, the Senate was divided into what they called the populares, so those who worked in the interests of the people, and the optimates, those who claimed the authority to impose their value on the population. You can see the echoes when we talk today about the people and the elites. Many of this latter group, the optimates, were aristocratic landowners, and they were obviously keen to protect their own interests.

6.10 Now, on the pretense that Tiberius Gracchus was seeking to impose a tyranny, he was beaten to death. The senators beat him to death with anything they could find. Clubs, sticks, they even used wooden chair legs to do so, and then they threw his body into the River Tiber, which was the typical thing that happened to traitors at this time. But this was the first political assassination of its kind in ancient Rome. It changed everything. It changed everything because, thereafter, in ancient Rome, there was this idea that actually violence could be the right solution to a problem. And that never went away, because after that, there were multiple murders.

6.11 Now, by the time you get to the 3rd century AD, people are turning down the Empire. People are saying, "I don't want to be Emperor," because they know they're going to get killed in a couple of weeks. And of course, there's all of these murders, very gruesome, a lot of bloodshed. And the most famous one of all is Julius Caesar. We all know what happened to Julius Caesar, even if we haven't read Shakespeare's play of Julius Caesar. We know that he is stabbed to death by a group of conspirators at the Theater of Pompey in Rome, which you can still visit. Some people have told me they can still identify the very spot where he died. We all know when he died, don't we? He died in 44 BC, but we know that it was on the Ides of March, the Ides of March, midway through March directly. And of course, this was dramatized most famously by William Shakespeare. I'm going to turn to that play now and see what he does with it.

6.12 So let's begin with a journey to Hell. So when we think about Hell in our collective imagination, it is a realm of smoldering brimstone, isn't it? The burning maw of Milton's *Paradise Lost*, where wretches weep and gnash their teeth, or as Aaron in Titus Andronicus puts it, "a home for devils who live and burn in everlasting fire." But according to Dante, who wrote the *Divine Comedy* — I'm sure you all know the *Divine Comedy* is divided into three parts, Hell, Purgatory, and Heaven — and according to Dante, the most grievous of sinners in his *Inferno*, there is no fire there, because the worst sinners are put at the very heart of Hell, at the center of Hell. Actually, there's no

fire at all. It's actually freezing cold. The reason why it's freezing cold at the center of Hell in Dante is that Satan himself is lying in a lake, a frozen lake. Every time he tries to escape, he flaps his huge bat-like wings and thereby continually freezes the lake which traps him. So the more he tries to escape, the more he secures his own fate. That's the idea there.

- 6.13** By the way, I love the Inferno. I think it's really interesting. I think it's worth reading. I think it's quite funny in an odd way, insofar as what Dante is doing in the Inferno is there's an awful lot of score-settling. So he's depicting the various circles of Hell with the various people who are being punished in the various circles. The usurers are here, the sodomites are here, and so on and so forth. But what he does do is he throws in the people who've annoyed him in real life. He honestly does. He puts his rivals in Hell, getting tortured. It's very funny. In Canto 8, there's this figure which appears full of slime, comes out of the River Styx, and this is a man called Filippo Argenti, who was a member of a rival political faction whose family had seized a lot of Dante's property after he was exiled. So obviously, he's going to get his own back. You shouldn't mess with Florentine poets. They bear grudges.
- 6.14** Now, we might infer, however, that Dante had a particular loathing for traitors. We know this because, if you look at that moment at the center of Hell, when we finally see Satan, he has reserved the most severe punishments for three main people. Firstly, Christ's betrayer, Judas Iscariot, but the other two are Brutus and Cassius, so the two chief conspirators in the murder of Julius Caesar. Now, read that part of the Inferno. It's fascinating. Satan, as I say, massive beast with big wings, frozen in a lake. He has three mouths, three heads, and in each of his three mouths, he is chewing on one of these sinners forevermore. So Judas Iscariot, Brutus, and Cassius being gradually munched till the end of time. It's quite the punishment. You might call them being in a state of perpetual mastication.
- 6.15** Now, it suggests that he didn't like them. He had a real problem with Brutus and Cassius. He didn't like the men who assassinated Julius Caesar. If you're interested, by the way, Julius Caesar does appear in the Inferno. He's in the first circle of Hell, which sounds bad. It's actually quite good. It's the nice bit of Hell, right? Because anyone who is born before Christ has to go to Hell by default. They haven't been baptized. It's really unfair. It's why Virgil is leading Dante through Hell. Virgil is there because, well, he was born before Christ. It's not his fault. It seems a bit harsh. This is why Virgil doesn't guide him through Heaven. Someone else has to do that. It's Beatrice does that. The first circle of Hell in Dante, you get all these great thinkers and people from antiquity like Homer and Socrates and Plato and Aristotle and Cicero. It isn't that Dante doesn't like them; it's that they have to be in Hell.
- 6.16** But he doesn't like Brutus, and he doesn't like Cassius. That's really important. Now, compare that depiction to another depiction a couple of centuries later. If we go to Michelangelo, 1540, he created a bust of Brutus, which you can see if you go to

Florence, or Firenze, and you go to the Bargello Museum, you can find this bust. It's very interesting to look at Michelangelo's depiction of Brutus. The profile, the pose, the attitude, it's all very heroic. Now, at this time, the fashion was very much against the concept of tyranny. Look at the statue, if you get the chance. There's confidence there, there is poise, there's a bit of concealed ruthlessness, there's a single-mindedness in Brutus. He's swinging his head to the side, this abrupt swing of the head. There's a sense of purpose. He's brusque, he's austere, but he's looking somewhere that we can't see. He's looking away from us. We don't concern him. He's above us.

6.17 Now, the Florentine Republic had been defeated in 1531. The Medici family were now in control. Michelangelo was a supporter of the Republic, hated the Medici. I think all of this gets invested in this heroic portrayal of Brutus. So which is the correct interpretation? This is what I'm trying to get at. Are we right to think that Michelangelo was correct, that Brutus is a heroic figure, that he was doing something noble in assassinating Caesar and saving Rome from tyranny? Or is it Dante's perspective, that Brutus deserves to be eternally chewed? OK, so now, frustratingly or refreshingly, depending on your perspective, Shakespeare's personal views on this matter are forever oblique. We just don't know. I've said this a number of times, but like the best of historians, he doesn't make moral judgments about the characters he represents, not even the historical characters he represents. At heart, it is helpful, I think, to think of Julius Caesar as a play about populism and also about the consequences of populism.

6.18 As I've emphasized many times, but I'm going to keep saying it, Shakespeare doesn't write morality plays. He raises questions where we might seek answers. Historians have long argued over the conspirator's justifications for the murder on the Ides of March. Is it really a case of the elites taking matters into their own hands, removing a popular leader? Remember, Julius Caesar was a very definition of a populist leader. He spent a lot of money on the people. The people loved him. And these guys, these senators, got rid of him. And is that what it was, just the elites taking back control? So in production, what you'll often find is that a director will take one side or the other. There are plenty of ways that you can do this. If he or she takes the view that Caesar was a tyrant, which you can back up with the text, right? If you say he's a tyrant who got what he deserved, it's totally possible. You can emphasize this in the way that he is performed, in the way that he is presented, his arrogance, his hubris. You can really bring that to the surface.

6.19 For instance, he has a tendency in the play to refer to himself in the third person. "Caesar will do this, Caesar will do that." But of course, I think what Shakespeare is doing there is drawing on that tradition of the royal "we", the English tradition of the royal "we", which gives him a dignity in doing so. By the way, if you ever read Caesar's own account of the Gallic Wars, he also does the same. He writes about it in the third person. He talks about himself in the third person. Actually, there's a good historical reason why Shakespeare does the same. But interestingly, Brutus and Cassius also do it. They also refer to themselves in the third person. So you can see Caesar as a tyrant if

you want, and you can present him as a tyrant if you want. But alternatively, you can present Caesar as a well-intentioned ruler whose great sin was to cultivate populist support against the wishes of his powerful friends in the Senate. That might be a more interesting interpretation. Well, you could go either way. I'm not really settled on the matter.

6.20 Now, at the moment when Caesar is moving towards his death, he's going to the Theater of Pompey. He doesn't know what's going to happen, and he's approached by Artemidorus. He's getting lots of people trying to give him appeals, give him letters, and Caesar rejects it. This man says, "Hail, Caesar! Read this schedule." And Decius says, "No, you've got another thing to read. You've got other things, you've got other suits to address." Artemidorus says, "O, Caesar, read mine first, for mine's a suit that touches Caesar nearer. Read it, great Caesar." He's going to warn him that he's about to be killed. But Caesar doesn't. He says, "What touches us ourselves shall be last served." There's an ability to that. He's been told that this suit will affect him directly, personally, and he says, "Well, then, I'll leave it till last." It's "I am less important than the state." That's very, very telling. It tells us something about how Shakespeare represents Caesar.

6.21 Now, Shakespeare's principal source for Julius Caesar was Thomas North's English translation of Plutarch, Plutarch's Lives of the Noble Grecians and Romans. His parallel lives of the Greeks and the Romans throughout history. He has biographies of Caesar, and Brutus is in there. There's a biography of Antony, Mark Antony as well. Now, in Plutarch's account, Caesar is prevented from reading the letter, this letter that he's given, warning him of his impending death. He's prevented due to the tumult of the crowd. There's too many people around. And Shakespeare changes this. He modifies it. And what that does is, it suggests that Caesar isn't this self-serving tyrant, that that assumption is incorrect. It's an altruistic gesture in Shakespeare, not in Plutarch, but it's a mistake that costs him his life.

6.22 Now, in the first lecture in this series, I mentioned a production of Julius Caesar in 2017 by New York City's Public Theater. That was an open-air production of Julius Caesar in Central Park. You'll remember because I mentioned that Donald Trump was Caesar. So they represented Caesar as Donald Trump. They dressed him as Donald Trump. He looked the same. I also mentioned another production, a 1937 Orson Welles production, which he called Death of a Dictator. He's having a go at liberals, not being able to stand up to fascists. So for Welles, Caesar was a tyrant. For this production of Donald Trump, they clearly saw Caesar as a tyrant. As I mentioned earlier, they have to adapt and modify the text to make that work. As the theater critic Michael Billington said, these interpretations detract from the moral qualms that Brutus experiences regarding the assassination. Brutus doesn't just do it. He wrestles with his conscience before he does it.

- 6.23** The notion that Caesar is straightforwardly a fascist, I think, works against Shakespeare's text. It's not that straightforward. It also renders Brutus' introspective struggle dramatically impotent. So as in *Coriolanus*, one of the key things about Julius Caesar is the plebeians. His power is dependent on the wishes of the plebeians. *Coriolanus* cannot sustain power because he refuses to talk to the people. He thinks he's above the people, so he won't deign to talk to them, and that's why it all goes wrong for him. Julius Caesar's power has been secured by the plebeians, and it's no accident that this is the first thing we see dramatically in the play. It opens with a street scene. People are in celebration. People are delighted. They're having a triumph. A triumph was a Roman ceremony, usually after the victory in a war.
- 6.24** But what you don't do is have a triumph in civil war. You don't have a triumph when one Roman has defeated another Roman, but that's what's going on here. Caesar has won the civil war. Caesar has defeated Pompey. The people are decorating statues of Caesar with feathers and, I suppose, bunting, or whatever the equivalent at the time was. Just dressing it up. They're absolutely delighted. It is a great opening scene because it's full of life, full of action. You can imagine it on that old, huge Elizabethan stage, a really vibrant moment. The tribunes of the plebs come in. These are their representatives in the Senate, Flavius and Marullus, and they come in and they're trying to stop them all. They're saying, "You can't do this. This was a civil war. You shouldn't be doing this. Go home. Go back to your jobs. Why aren't you working?" He says to a cobbler, "What are you doing?"
- 6.25** And they just give them backchat. They're uncontrollable. The tribunes can't stop them from doing this. So this is the first thing we think about when we see Julius Caesar. This is the first thing we're confronted with, that if the people have a mindset to be in a particular way, they're not easily controlled. Perhaps the plebeians' devotion to Caesar leaves little scope for other loyalties, so they won't be loyal to the tribunes. They certainly don't share the stoic values of the Patricians. And yet what we see in this scene is an example of how graceful rhetoric—rhetoric means the the art of persuasion. It was one of the major topics studied at university of the time. People knew in the Renaissance that if you—it doesn't really matter if you're right or wrong. If you knew how to use language and persuade people, you could get what you want. They knew this. They taught it. There were whole manuals about rhetoric, rhetorical tropes, how to use language.
- 6.26** Shakespeare is a master of rhetoric, and we're going to get to that in a moment. But in this moment, in this first scene of *Julius Caesar*, the tribunes do manage to control the crowd eventually, and they do it through language. So Marullus says, to the people, he says, "You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things! O, you hard hearts, you cruel men of Rome, knew you not Pompey? Many a time and oft have you climbed up to walls and battlements, to towers and windows, yea to chimney-tops, your infants in your arms, and there have sat the livelong day with patient expectation to see great

Pompey pass the streets of Rome. And when you saw his chariot but appear, have you not made an universal shout that Tiber trembled underneath her banks to hear the replication of your sounds made in her concave shores?"

6.27 He's evoking the time when they all had a similar event for Pompey, the man who's just been defeated. This is the caprice of the people, right? So the language of the speech conjures up an image from the past which matches the visual scenes that we're seeing in present. In other words, the cheers that we hear for Caesar today once sounded for Pompey, his enemy. The tears of authority in the Republic are delicate. A populist movement that empowers a single man could topple them for good. Marullus' words in this moment have this desired effect. So before long, the plebeians shuffle away. As Flavius puts it, they are "tongue-tied in their guiltiness." They feel chastened. Now, that would suggest that words have power. You can control the people if you use the right words.

6.28 As I say, the scene is very evocative. We are transported to this heady urban clamor of ancient Rome. I've only ever seen that effect equalled in a book, a novel called *Marius the Epicurean* by Walter Pater. It feels, when you read that book, there are moments when you feel like you're there. It's set about two centuries later, but you feel like you're in Rome. It's quite astonishing. Often not read. It's very overlooked. And Dryden wrote of Shakespeare that, when he describes anything, "the more you see it, you feel it, too." I think that's exactly right. So in *Julius Caesar*, we feel ourselves walking among the plebeians. We feel ourselves jostled by their ever-changing and competing temperaments. They represent this unstable force of nature, a storm into which Shakespeare throws his audience at the very beginning of the play. We're greeted by this immense crowd. They're jubilant in the streets. They're laughing in the faces of their superiors. They're swaying as one under the magnetic charms of their leader Julius Caesar.

6.29 Marullus and Flavius do quickly see them dispersed. But remember, like an ocean might suddenly subside, there's always the possibility of another tempest. These are the crushing masses. What does Caesar say? Caesar calls them "the press" later on. And they ultimately get to decide the future of the nation. They have numbers on their side, after all. And the tribunes decide to remove the various decorations on the statues, the trophies, the laurel wreaths, the other ornamentations that the masses have put there. Flavius explains the reason why. He says, "These growing feathers plucked from Caesar's wing will make him fly an ordinary pitch, who else would soar above the view of men and keep us all in servile fearfulness." In other words, let's stop flattering him with these declarations. Let's stop doing that because, if we do that, he'll soar above. He will become hubristic. Whereas if we take these decorations down, he'll fly an ordinary pitch. He'll be manageable. That's the idea.

6.30 This is an important moment, this analogy of the powerful bird with clipped wings who might soar above the view of men, because it's the first reference in the play to the

idea of Caesar as a god, the idea of hubris. The idea of hubris is very, very important, considering yourself above the gods. Later, they're going to use this as justification for the murder. By the way, we later learn that Flavius and Marullus, the tribunes, have been, and this is a chilling phrase, "put to silence," probably executed. And that's because they removed the decorations. It is a baleful euphemism. And if you want to suggest that Caesar is a tyrant, that's further evidence for your claim. What I'm saying here is, you can play it both ways, and there's evidence both ways within the text.

6.31 Now, an effective staging of this, the way I envisage it, is that you kind of get battered at the start by the sheer crowd, the volume of the crowd, the power, the potential of the demos. You're thrown into the middle of it. I think it's done rather well in the film from 1953. That was Joseph L. Mankiewicz, who also did Cleopatra. I think it's a very good film. It has James Mason as Brutus and Marlon Brando as Mark Antony. It's a very effective film. He does this crowd scene very well. By the way, it's got John Gielgud as Cassius, and I just think he's a wonderful actor. But like I say, the opening, we as an audience member, feel battered by all of this stuff. We are reminded that, amongst the plebeians, we are just a single individual, that their power lies in the people. I think that's the idea.

6.32 Now, a lot of modern productions make it quite sparse. There are good economic reasons for that. You know, Julius Caesar has 40 speaking roles, so you often get doubling. You know what I mean by doubling? The idea of one actor playing multiple roles, which is what they did in the original Elizabethan productions. However, there is something to be said for the film version, or indeed for visual extravagance. There are some fantastic photographs which you can find online of productions by Sir Herbert Beerbohm Tree. He was known for what he called spectacular realism. He would have these huge, detailed sets, sometimes over 100 extras on stage at the same time. There's an image of a production of his of Julius Caesar. Incredible. That thing has gone out of fashion, and nobody can afford it, but it looks fantastic. That's why I think actually the best approach to Julius Caesar is probably just to read it, isn't it? Because your imagination can do the work that directors on a tight budget cannot.

6.33 For the opening scene of Julius Caesar, then, we are reminded that political power is sustained only by those who can enlist the masses to their cause. All politicians know this. All politicians need to be popular. Recently, we've had prime ministers who generally tend to be presidential in style. If you think of Tony Blair, Margaret Thatcher, less so Rishi Sunak, but you know what I mean. More charismatic figures. That's because they know they have to retain the popularity of the people. This has been known forever. It's been known back in ancient Rome. Julius Caesar, very, very popular, very image-conscious. He wore the laurels. I think it's said that he wore the laurels on his head because of his receding hairline. I don't know if that's true. But even so, he knew how to perform. Very, very important. The key to that is rhetoric, mastery of language.

- 6.34 One feature of Shakespeare's plays that seems to come up again and again, I've cautioned against this idea that we should think that we can know what Shakespeare thought by reading his plays. I don't think you can, but there's no doubt that one thing that comes up over and over again is this sense that good governance is really necessary to sustain civilization. But the plays offer no indisputable signposts to what he actually felt, his own sensibilities. But this theme does come up again and again. But at the same time, he's also concerned about the morality of rebellion, as much in the history cycles as in the Roman tragedies. But what it doesn't seem to do is it doesn't seem to come from a contempt for the people. You don't get in Shakespeare this sense of the great unwashed, someone who's looking down on the people, whereas you would get that in a writer like Ben Jonson, his rival, who was a snob.
- 6.35 Now, I think the best explanation for this that I've ever read comes in A. L. Rowse, a historian who wrote on Shakespeare. He wasn't a literary critic, so he has a particularly interesting approach to Shakespeare. He says it isn't so much that he disdains the masses for their stupidity, but rather—and this is the phrase that I really like—rather, "Shakespeare saw through everybody equally." I think that's a really interesting way of putting it. He's not going to glorify anyone. He sees through everyone equally. It's really nicely put. So neither prince nor pauper, patrician, nor plebeian, will escape Shakespeare's analytical gaze. They're all up for criticism. They're all fair game.
- 6.36 Now, there is no passage in Shakespeare, in the entire Shakespearean canon, that more resoundingly confirms his mastery of rhetoric, his rhetorical expertise, than Mark Antony's famous speech to the plebeians after Caesar's assassination. I'm sure you all know this speech. Before he commences, before he does his address, you have a situation where the people are completely behind Brutus and the conspirators. What Mark Antony does is, in fewer than 100 lines, he has not only persuaded them to completely change their position, he's also galvanized them into a state of righteous frenzy. It's not just that they've changed their minds, they've really changed their minds. Now, to better understand how that is achieved, it's worth comparing his speech to the one that directly proceeds it. What we see here is a perfect example of how rhetoric works. Because Antony isn't just speaking to the crowds, he's responding to Brutus.
- 6.37 So what happens? They've killed Caesar. They've stabbed him. He's been stabbed 20 odd times. They've bathed their hands in the blood of Caesar. They've run out crying, "Liberty!" They've gone out to the people. Brutus speaks to the people to explain what he's just done. OK. What Brutus does is he speaks to the masses in prose. Remember what I said? Usually, lower-class characters in Shakespeare usually speak in prose. The higher-class usually speak in verse. Brutus, who usually speaks in verse, now adopts prose as the style. What does that do? It puts him on the level of the masses. It's quite clever. Obviously, he's not doing this consciously. It's something Shakespeare is doing. But he says the following.

- 6.38** Brutus says, "Romans, countrymen, and lovers, hear me for my cause, and be silent that you may hear. Believe me for mine honor, and have respect to mine honor that you may believe. Censure me in your wisdom, and awake your senses, that you may the better judge." Remember, the crowd are upset because they liked Caesar; this man's killed Caesar. So Brutus is coming out to try and get the crowd on side. Now, it's already clear from this—this is in Act 3, Scene 2, if you want to read it—it's clear that Brutus is hoping to empower the crowd, or at least give the impression that he's empowering the crowd. So there's a gentle reminder of his own social standing. He mentions "mine honor." But the tone avoids arrogance because there's an implication that he owes that reputation in part to the wisdom of the people, of his audience. And he appeals to their patriotism. He calls them "Romans, countrymen." He adds a personal touch by calling them "lovers," which here is a synonym for friends.
- 6.39** And then Antony comes on. So Brutus has spoken, and by the end of Brutus' speech, everyone's like, "Oh, OK. Yeah, you killed Caesar, but you didn't really want to. You felt you had to. And so we're on side," and they're all cheering for Brutus. So already the crowd has turned. Mark Antony's task now is to turn them back. And that's what he does. He comes in. Caesar's corpse is there for them to see. And Antony waits for Brutus to leave, which is quite clever. And he begins his speech in a near-identical fashion. So it's not just that he is responding to Brutus' speech, he's improving upon Brutus' speech. This is what he says. You all know this.
- 6.40** "Friends, Romans, countrymen, lend me your ears. I come to bury Caesar, not to praise him. The evil that men do lives after them. The good is oft interred with their bones. So let it be with Caesar." Can you hear it? The cadence. It's gone from prose to verse. This is going to be more elegant. This is going to be more measured, more dignified. And we can't really miss, he's reordered Brutus' opening line, hasn't he? So, friendship is now prioritized. So we had Brutus saying, "Romans, countrymen, lovers." Now it is, "Friends, Romans, countrymen." It's a subtle change, but it's really powerful because Antony's words have a more delicate, rhythmic appeal. We have this sequential expansion from one syllable, friends, to two syllables, Romans, to three syllables, countrymen.
- 6.41** And whereas Brutus seems to be like a leader speaking down to his people, Antony wants them to feel like compatriots. He says, "Shall I descend?" And then he comes down next to them with the body of the dead Caesar. He wants them to see him as his equal, as their equal, not as a superior. Compare it to what Brutus says. Brutus says, "Hear me for my cause and be silent that you may hear." That's an instruction. That tacitly bolsters Brutus' own authority. Antony says something different, doesn't he? He says, "Lend me your ears." You can hear the difference. That confers the authority to the listeners, to the people. That is going to be more enticing, more appealing. It's they who are going to have to decide whether or not Antony merits their attention. Whereas Brutus seems to imply that they're under an obligation to hear him out. It's the difference between a populist and an elite.

- 6.42 His honor demands it. He refers to his honor. And furthermore, it's this same quality, his honor, he says, that compelled him to act against Caesar in spite of his love for Caesar. Friendship, as he has suggested in his "Romans, countrymen, and lovers" speech, should be subordinate to your fealty to Rome. So Brutus says, explicitly, he says, "If there be any in this assembly, any dear friend of Caesar's, to him I say that Brutus' love to Caesar was no less than his. If then that friend demand why Brutus rose against Caesar, this is my answer: not that I loved Caesar less, but that I loved Rome more." It's quite compelling.
- 6.43 "Had you rather Caesar were living, and die all slaves, than that Caesar were dead, to live all free men? As Caesar loved me, I weep for him. As he was fortunate, I rejoice at it. As he was valiant, I honor him. But as he was ambitious, I slew him." Caesar's crime, then, was his ambition. Brutus fears that he would have returned Rome to being a monarchy and would have reduced its citizens to mere subjects. Yet the audience has a further insight into Brutus' motivations, thanks to a soliloquy he delivered earlier in the play. If you remember in the previous act, when Brutus is alone in the orchard, he's speaking to himself. We've spoken about soliloquies before. He's talking about whether or not Caesar needs to die, and he reveals a great deal. This is what he says.
- 6.44 He says, "It must be by his death. And for my part, I know no personal cause to spurn at him." Remember, he's saying this alone, not in front of the crowd. "I know no personal cause to spurn at him, but for the general." For the common good. "He would be crowned. How that might change his nature, there's the question. It is the bright day that brings forth the adder, and that craves wary walking. Crown him: that! And then I grant we put a sting in him that at his will he may do danger with." So if Caesar is guilty of ambition, by Brutus' own admission, it's only ambition in a nascent form. It hasn't yet manifested. And note how the phrasing shifts, from the definitive to the conditional. He is certain that Caesar would be crowned, but only that this might change his nature. It might bring forth his inner adder and provide him with a dangerous sting.
- 6.45 So his declared love for Caesar doesn't seem to extend to the benefit of the doubt. Caesar's tendency towards corruption is asserted, but it is just an assumption, isn't it? And worse still, Brutus concedes to himself that no aspect of Caesar's past behavior supports his own ungenerous view. He says, "The abuse of greatness is when it disjoins remorse from power. And to speak truth of Caesar, I have not known when his affections swayed more than his reason. But 'tis a common proof that lowliness is young ambition's ladder, whereto the climber-upward turns his face; but when he once attains the upmost round, he then unto the ladder turns his back, looks in the clouds, scorning the base degrees by which he did ascend. So Caesar may."
- 6.46 What chilling economy in that line, "so Caesar may." That is the flimsiest of suppositions to justify slaughter. Brutus sees him as a serpent's egg. He says he's "a serpent's egg, which hatched would, as his kind, grow mysterious." Actually, it's not ambition, it's not Caesar's ambition that seals his fate. That's not why they kill him. It's

the perception that he might become ambitious. This is a key aspect. So to put it another way, Caesar is going to be condemned because of Brutus' pessimistic assessment of human nature more broadly, not anything that Caesar has done. And in fact, Caesar has kept—he's shown that he can keep his passion in check. But Brutus is saying, well, look, the lure of power is inevitable. So is there anyone who could be in that role that Brutus wouldn't want to kill? What is this? Is this a reflection on Caesar, really, or is it a reflection on Brutus himself?

6.47 Now, with this in mind, let's go back to Mark Antony's speech to the plebeians. Caesar is dead. His body is in front of us, the corpse covered in blood. This is a rebuttal masquerading as a funeral eulogy. And it's brilliant. It's utterly brilliant. Mark Antony has this repeated insistence that Brutus is an honorable man. He's not saying what he thinks, OK? It's an absolute master stroke. This is what he says. "Here, under leave of Brutus and the rest—for Brutus is an honorable man, so are they all, all honorable men—come I to speak in Caesar's funeral." So he's talking about the conspirators as being honorable men, right? Note it. "He was my friend, faithful and just to me. But Brutus says he was ambitious, and Brutus is an honorable man. He hath brought many captives home to Rome," this is Caesar, "whose ransoms did the general coffers fill. Did this in Caesar seem ambitious? When the poor have cried, Caesar hath wept. Ambition should be made of sterner stuff. Yet Brutus says he was ambitious, and Brutus is an honorable man."

6.48 So Brutus had mentioned honor four times when he gave his speech, and Antony is developing this motif. During the course of Antony's speech, he manages to use the word honorable on 10 occasions regarding Brutus and the conspirators. This feels like ostensible support, doesn't it? But of course, it rings hollow because he unveils the body of Caesar, he pulls away the bloody toga, and you have this visual image of his dead mentor. And that is sufficient. The horror of Brutus' betrayal becomes explosively apparent at this point. And Antony says:

6.49 "Good friends, sweet friends, let me not stir you up to such a sudden flood of mutiny. They that have done this deed are honorable. What private griefs they have, alas, I know not, that made them do it. They are wise and honorable and will no doubt with reasons answer you. I come not, friends, to steal away your hearts. I am no orator as Brutus is. But as you know me all, a plain blunt man that love my friend, and that they know full well that gave me public leave to speak of him. For I have neither wit, nor words, nor worth, action, nor utterance, nor the power of speech, to stir men's blood. I only speak right on. I tell you that which you yourselves do know. Show you sweet Caesar's wounds, poor poor dumb mouths, and bid them speak for me. But were I Brutus, and Brutus Antony, there were an Antony would ruffle up your spirits, and put a tongue in every wound of Caesar that should move the stones of Rome to rise and mutiny."

- 6.50** This is an incredible trick. So Antony is persuading the mourners that they've decided on mutiny for themselves. He doesn't go out there and say, "Brutus and his conspirators have committed an evil act, and you should rise up against them." He does the opposite. He kept saying, "Well, they must have had their reasons. They're honorable men. If I were as eloquent as Brutus, maybe I would say something that would stir you up." And in doing so, he stirs them up. And of course, he is as eloquent as Brutus. In fact, he is more eloquent as Brutus. It is incredibly manipulative and it is incredibly effective. The explicit direction that they shouldn't revolt has the complete opposite effect. He conjures the image of a tongue in every one of Caesar's open wounds, speaking for revenge, crying out for revenge.
- 6.51** Then, this is what really proves his rhetorical brilliance, in the very act of denying, he implicitly levels the blame on Brutus for the uprising he could have incited, had he been so inclined. It's really smart. Now, as I pointed out, and I want to emphasize this, there are no easy answers in Shakespeare's text. As we find ourselves roused by Antony's funeral elegy to Caesar, we're caught up in the plebeian's collective impulse for revenge. We're checked, though, by this. We can't just go along with it. In the film version I mentioned, you see them all starting smashing up the town. It's very exhilarating. You think, "Yes, they're right. Let's take some revenge." But Shakespeare won't let it be that easy, because what happens next? A poet enters. You might recall this, Cinna the poet. Now, there's also a conspirator called Cinna. Just coincidence, has the same name.
- 6.52** This poet enters, and the crowd shouts, "Tear him to pieces." Cinna says, "Well, I'm Cinna the poet." He's on his way to the funeral. He's Caesar's friend. But the crowd has got this bloodlust now. And so this innocent surrogate will do just as well. He says, "I'm Cinna the poet. I'm Cinna the poet." A plebeian says, "Tear him for his bad verses. Tear for his bad verses." He says, "I am not Cinna the conspirator." And a plebeian says, "It is no matter. His name's Cinna. Pluck but his name out of his heart, and turn him going. Tear him, tear him!" It's completely frenzied. It's completely animalistic, right? So then the crowd go on, and they go on to the houses of the conspirators, and they intend to burn them to the ground. But look, they've just torn a man to pieces knowing he's innocent because they're caught up in the bloodlust, and they don't even care. It's not a mistake. They know that it's a mistake. They still do it.
- 6.53** This is what Shakespeare is doing here. He's reminding us that whatever sympathy you might have for the cause, there is a chaotic nature to mob violence. You can't predict where violence will go. Hannah Arendt, she talked about this in a book called *On Violence*, very famously, the idea that once you embark on a violent act, political violence, it's dangerous because you cannot control the endpoint. And that's something that we get from Julius Caesar here. This idea that, when men are thinking collectively, they're not thinking at all. Just as the loyalties of the crowd can vacillate from Caesar to Brutus and back again in the space of one morning, so too is their

bloodlust subject to this same ebb and flow. The endpoint of violence is impossible to predict.

- 6.54** If you think about the conspirators' point of view, they anticipated a new eon of liberty, didn't they? They thought this was going to be great. And what happens? Civil war. In our Disneyfied world of goodies and baddies, we might struggle with the character of Brutus. He's a man who has unleashed chaos, but he's done so with an effort to heal society. I don't think he was lying about that. He's convinced himself that Caesar will become ambitious. We have reservations about that. It doesn't ring true, but he does believe it, doesn't he? I mean, he's very honest. This is something that A. C. Bradley, the critic I keep mentioning, he always goes about Brutus being one of the most honest of all of Shakespeare's characters. So while we do admire Mark Antony for his rhetorical prowess, we understand that Brutus is the tragic hero of this play, one whose complex interior struggles had no precedent at this point in English drama.
- 6.55** And like I say, he might have acted dishonorably, but he did it from the very best of intentions. This is something that even Antony acknowledges. After Brutus has killed himself, Antony says, "This was the noblest Roman of them all. All the conspirators, save only he, did that they did in envy of great Caesar. He only, in a general honest thought and common good to all, made one of them. His life was gentle, and the elements so mixed in him that nature might stand up and say to all the world, 'This was a man.'" That's coming from his enemy. The play, of course, is really Brutus' play. It should be called Brutus rather than Julius Caesar. But of course, that wouldn't be as commercially viable. Caesar actually only speaks 130 lines. He's killed halfway through.
- 6.56** One curious thing that Shakespeare doesn't mention is that Brutus traditionally was thought to be Caesar's son. That's a key thing. We don't know for sure that that's true, and even the historians that report on it say it may not have been true. We do know that, by the way, that Julius Caesar had an affair with Brutus' mother, Servilia. That is true. We know that. But Brutus was born when Caesar was 15. Still possible. It's still possible. We don't know. But what does Caesar do at the moment of his death? He asks Caesar, uses a Latin phrase, "Et tu, Brute." In Suetonius, the Roman historian, he uses a Greek phrase, "Kai su, teknon," meaning, "You too, child." So "Et tu, Brute," and you, Brutus, was actually "And you, child." So it seems that Shakespeare doesn't want to get into this idea, this Freudian minefield of parricide. He doesn't want to go there. He just completely avoids it.
- 6.57** But I think the audience at the time would have known this. And so it adds a kind of extra dimension. If you watch the 1953 film, the brilliant moment where Brutus — Caesar's been stabbed, and Brutus is the last one. He's there with a knife. You can see the look on his face. He doesn't want to do this, but he has to do this. It's really good. Now, if we're going to take the view that the conspirators had some moral justification for their actions, we need to consider the accusations against their ruler. Cassius is the one. He's the one that drives the early parts of the play, isn't he? He's the one that

needs to persuade Brutus of the wisdom of the plot. He needs to get Brutus on side. And he does this by emphasizing that Caesar is a weak man who's been elevated way beyond his capabilities. That he is guilty of hubris. And he does this by relating an anecdote. This is what Cassius says.

6.58 He says, "For once upon a raw and gusty day, the troubled Tiber, chafing with her shores, said Caesar to me, 'Darest thou, Cassius, now leap in with me into this angry flood and swim to yonder point?' Upon the word, accoutred as I was, I plunged in and bade him follow. So indeed he did. The torrent roared, and we did buffet it with lusty sinews, throwing it aside, and stemming it with hearts of controversy. But ere we could arrive the point proposed, Caesar cried, 'Help me, Cassius, or I sink.'" Now, this is not historically accurate. In Plutarch's Lives, Caesar was an especially strong swimmer. That was one of his traits. So what is this? Is this mere bluster from Cassius? Is it a way to diminish Caesar's standing? He actually goes further than this. Cassius says, "He had a fever when he was in Spain, and when the fit was on him, I did mark how he did shake. 'Tis true, this god did shake."

6.59 Now, this is the second time that Cassius has sneeringly referred to Caesar as a god. There's absolutely no reason to believe that Caesar himself would have wanted to be described as a god. There were certain emperors who did. Caligula, for example. Domitian is another one. They wanted to be called a god. But this has not happened now. So Julius Caesar was, of course, deified after his death, but during his lifetime, absolutely not. And we might want to pause to consider the manner in which Cassius recounts the rescue of the drowning Caesar. He says, "Ay, as Aeneas our great ancestor did from the flames of Troy upon his shoulder the old Anchises bear, so from the waves of Tiber did I the tired Caesar." That's quite hubristic, isn't it? The way he's describing himself. "And this man is now become a god, and Cassius is a wretched creature, and must bend his body if Caesar carelessly but nod on him."

6.60 You can hear the resentment. "I once saved Caesar's life. He was screaming like a little girl, and I saved him, and now I have to bow to him, and he thinks he's a god." All of this stuff is coming through, right? But it's Cassius who's making that claim. He's putting words into his mouth in order to condemn him. Caesar has never said he's a god. He's never described himself as such. And by the way, Aeneas was the founder of Rome. So the allusion to the story of how he saved his father from the flames of Troy tells us a lot about Cassius' sense of his own self-importance. The hubris is all his.

6.61 Now, while Julius Caesar was not the first treatment of this subject in English theater, it did quickly become one of the most popular. As I said, Shakespeare's audience would have been completely familiar with the story. This is history's most famous political assassination. But now it's been invigorated with this focus on Brutus, on the most notorious conspirator. For an Elizabethan audience, this would have been the first encounter with an on-stage protagonist whose internal conflicts are laid so bare.

Shakespeare, of course, as we know, did that again and again later on with the development of his soliloquy. That is, as I've said, his great innovation.

- 6.62** The historical Brutus sided with Caesar in the civil war—sorry, sided against Caesar, and then Caesar forgave him in the aftermath. I don't know if you know this feature of Julius Caesar in history. One of his major flaws, I think, is that after the civil war, he said to all the people who turned against him, "You can come back. It's fine." And a lot of those men ended up being the people who stabbed him to death in the Theater of Pompey. It was an error of judgment. That's not something Augustus did. So when Augustus becomes Emperor, what does he do? He kills off any potential rival. He tracks down Julius Caesar's illegitimate son that he had with Cleopatra and murders him, too. That was just a boy. I think he must have been about 18 at that point. Augustus did that. That was maybe the right thing to do. I'm not approving of murder, obviously. But if you go back to that—but Caesar, in letting the conspirators back in or his enemies back in, sealed his own fate. It's interesting to note that historical point.
- 6.63** Now, audiences might have expected Shakespeare to tread a very clear line on the morality of Brutus' actions. To pick a side. No, do you go with Dante's version? Do you go with Michelangelo's? How do we perceive Brutus? We might have expected him to depict him as reluctantly deposing a close friend and mentor who had proven unable to resist the lure of tyranny. But he doesn't do that. He doesn't take sides. He shows us a Brutus racked within a turmoil. In the first scene, in Brutus' first scene, Cassius observes that his demeanor has been altered of late, somehow colder. And Brutus admits this, that he's been "vexed with passions of some difference," that he is "with himself at war." His phrasing is delicate. It's troubled, as though he's navigating thoughts that it pains him to entertain.
- 6.64** In the distance, there's an ongoing rumbling of the crowd, Caesar's triumph, and the noise swells into a roar. And what does Brutus say? This confirms his anxieties. He says, "I do fear that people choose Caesar for their king." This is a very important aspect of Plutarch. There's this very famous scene where they offer a crown three times to Julius Caesar, and he refuses. The suggestion is that he was doing this deliberately as a performance to show to the people he didn't want to be king. Now, all of this does take place in Julius Caesar in Shakespeare's play, but it takes place off-stage, like the murder of Duncan off-stage. It's more powerful that way. It's dramatically counterintuitive, but it does work really, really well, because we have the conspirators hearing the crowd's cheer and misinterpreting what goes on. And then it's just reported by this man, Casca, who comes in and explains that he's just refused the crown on three different occasions.
- 6.65** Now, this is important if you think about the historical context, and this would not have been lost on an Elizabethan audience. Rome began as a monarchy, and after what happened with Tarquin, then it became a republic. And the one biggest fear of the Romans is that they're going to return to a monarchy. It was a big taboo. Any

suggestion—I mean, Julius Caesar, during his lifetime, did gold-plate his chair, so people were worried that, oh, is he trying to become a king again? That seems to be the concern of Brutus and Cassius, that he's going to restore Rome to a monarchy, and they really, really don't want that. Effectively, with the emperors, when you get into the Roman Empire, you have a monarchy, really, in all but name. But they would never use the term. They would never use the term.

6.66 Then many saw these early emperors of the Julio-Claudian dynasty—so Augustus, Tiberius, Caligula, Claudius, and Nero—they saw this as only temporary. They thought they were actually going to go back to a republic. This is why the image of Caesar rejecting the crown is so potent. And all that Brutus needs to hear is the cheers to make him think that's definitely happening. "I do believe," he tells Cassius, "that these applauses are for some new honors that are heaped on Caesar." And that he's correct about that is besides the point. What his words reveal is that he's been tortured by this possibility for quite a while. He says, "How I have thought of this and of these times, I shall recount hereafter." He's already been thinking about this. It's already been in his mind.

6.67 How then should we feel about Julius Caesar? Did he deserve to die? So at Julius Caesar's funeral, apparently, a comet was seen in the sky. That was taken to be his soul flying to heaven. That was used as to justify him being deified, turned into a god. And Ovid alludes to this at the end of his *Metamorphoses*. The dictator, he was perpetual dictator, he was called, even though he lasted a little over a year. He's a flawed figure in Shakespeare, but he's not a laughable figure, is he? He only becomes that way when you hear the testimonies of other people, when you hear Cassius say that he saved him from drowning, etc. And Cassius, of course, had spoken in verse when boasting of how he rescued Caesar from drowning.

6.68 When Casca comes in to tell them about him refusing the crown, he speaks in prose, which associates him with the mob, but also accentuates the farcical nature of the anecdote. There's all sorts of linguistic techniques that Shakespeare uses to destabilize your perception of Caesar. Is he a tyrant? Is he not? It just absolutely depends. Cassius describes him as a sick girl. It seems a bit incongruous, doesn't it? That accusation of femininity doesn't feel like the Julius Caesar that we see on stage. I mean, that would work with Richard II, the accusation of femininity. But it makes us mistrust Cassius. It makes us mistrust what Brutus is saying about Caesar. Shakespeare teases us with the possibility that contemporary accounts of Caesar's infirmity have been embellished. At the same time, he does give Caesar elements of weakness. He's an epileptic, which — he gives him a deafness in the left ear, which I don't believe is in any of the sources. So it gives him these touches of fallibility.

6.69 But actually, I don't think those are there to suggest that Caesar is weak. I think what that's doing is it is serving to humanize Caesar, to make us warm to him in a way. Now, like so many of Shakespeare's retellings of history, he refrains from venturing into

propagandistic territory. The closest he comes to that, I think, is when he caricatures Joan of Arc in the first part of Henry VI. Instead, we must face an inconsistency between how Caesar is presented and how the others speak of him, and Shakespeare completely refuses to resolve that. Like I say, as a writer, he wants to raise questions. He wants to provoke thought. He doesn't want to answer questions for you. Now, I've already cautioned against the temptation to interpret Shakespeare's dramas as morality plays. As audience members, we can choose to take sides here, but our playwright is going to keep wrong-footing us at every stage, challenging our assumptions and forcing us to revise our judgments, even after the curtain falls.

- 6.70** Thank you, everyone. Are there any questions on Julius Caesar?
- 6.71** I'm intrigued by the fact that Shakespeare seems to be on the fence. How did he see himself as a playwright if he was always on the fence?
- 6.72** Well, it's an interesting point, isn't it? I think we're just so used to writers taking a particular stance and using the things that they write to project that stance. I think there's nothing wrong with a didactic piece of literature. Tom Brown's School Days, I think, is one example of an effective novel that is clearly didactic. There's moments in Dickens, aren't there, where he's lecturing the reader. I think particularly of Bleak House, where there's a moment where he says, "The poor don't deserve what you're doing to them." I think that's possible. For me, the best art is that which doesn't attempt to preach at you.
- 6.73** I share Oscar Wilde's view that art and morality have nothing to do with each other. If you read the preface to The Picture of Dorian Gray, which is Oscar Wilde's only novel, actually, he's responding to his critics, basically, in that preface, and he talks about how art and morality have nothing to do with each other. He says, "There's no such thing as a moral or an immoral book. Books are well written or badly written. That is all." I think that's a really interesting way to approach art. I think one of the problems that we have today is people are looking for moral confirmation in writing all the time. We get this all the time when activists talk about problematic representations in art, literature, film. There is no obligation for an artist to either be good or represent morally good characters to you. That's to completely misapprehend the purpose of art, completely. It's not a sermon. Actually, when theater becomes a sermon disguised as entertainment, I quickly switch off.
- 6.74** I like the fact that Shakespeare absolutely doesn't do that. He doesn't patronize you. He doesn't say, "This is the way you should think." When he does present the idea of the good guys winning out and the bad guys getting their comeuppance, he problematizes it. He changes it. He doesn't make anything clear because life isn't clear. That's why he's a true artist, rather than a propagandist. I think if Shakespeare were a propagandist, I wouldn't really be interested in him in the way that I am. So, it's a good question. We don't know how he felt about anything. That's something I really should reiterate. We just don't know what his private thoughts are.

- 6.75 Certainly from reading Julius Caesar, I don't think we know either where he stands on this. As I say, you can read it both ways. You can read that Brutus was right to depose Caesar because Caesar was weak and potentially tyrannical. At the same time, you can read it that Brutus is just one of the elites, the optimates, the people who just want to take power for their own sake, and that it's a good job that he didn't win out. You can see it either way. The fact that you can see it either way is what makes the play so exhilarating.
- 6.76 Thank you. Just to carry on this same question, would you say Shakespeare then just an artist, or would you agree that he might have provoked the audience for critical thinking, maybe, and unexpected unassuming that a certain leader should be a certain way? Or like you've mentioned before, not taking sides, but provoking that critical thinking from the audience?
- 6.77 Yeah, I think his works are provocative. I think some of the great artists do provoke, and they don't allow you to settle into your preconceptions. They don't just simply confirm your preconceptions or echo them back to you. I think that's quite a boring way to be. Yeah, there's some moments in Shakespeare that I think, why have you made that choice? We talked about King Lear, at the end of King Lear. Why does he have him bring Cordelia in dead when that wasn't in the source text? Why are you doing that to us? Why are you putting us through that? There is an element of provocation. You might even call it mischief. I don't know, but there's something to it where he's going to confound our expectations, and he seems to take delight in confounding our expectations. That, to me, just makes him a more interesting artist.
- 6.78 I know some people disagree, and some people wish he'd gone another way. Dr. Johnson, as you know, Samuel Johnson didn't like the ending of Lear. He preferred the rewritten, sanitized version by Nahum Tate, because he said there was no poetic justice there. But I'm not looking for poetic justice in plays. I'm looking to be stimulated. I'm looking for a multiplicity of thought. Shakespeare is presenting to us all sides, all at once, and he's not coming down one way or the other. Or if you think he comes down one way or the other, then you're probably misreading the text. We don't know who or what Shakespeare was, and I love that.
- 6.79 I think we need to be able to divorce the morality of the art from the morality of the artist. People often say, I can't read that book because I know what that person did in real life, or I can't look at that painting because I know what the person did. I mean, a lot of us, I think, are falling for that trap at the moment. Well, Christopher Marlowe killed a man in a duel. William Burroughs, didn't he shoot his wife in the face? Artists do terrible things. Sometimes artists are really horrible people. It said that Michelangelo crucified one of his models so he could replicate the contorted muscles for when he was replicating, when he was depicting Christ on the cross. Now, we don't know if that's true, by the way. It was a rumor. But if it was true, would that mean that we wouldn't enjoy Michelangelo anymore? Would we go into the Sistine Chapel and say,

"Let's paint over all of that"? I don't think so. I think we have to be able to divorce the art and the artist.

6.80 Shakespeare makes it easy because we don't know anything about him. But I've noticed a trend recently where critics are not only trying to say, "Well, this artist did terrible things, therefore let's delete what they've done." But they're actually criticizing characters within the work. We are having people rewriting —publishers are literally tweaking and changing books by Ian Fleming, Agatha Christie, P. G. Woodhouse, Roald Dahl, because they're saying, "Oh, we're offended by certain elements of the representation." Well, so what? I don't care if you're offended. You didn't write the books, and you're nowhere near the talent that these people were, so leave the books alone.

6.81 Again, I went on a bit of a rant there, but I think it's relevant. I think it's relevant. Don't read Shakespeare and get offended by elements of Shakespeare, because the man was born 400 years ago. He might think a little differently to you. And that's what annoys me about the Globe Theatre as they currently are—is that, for some reason, they seem to expect a man who was born in 1564 to have the same values as 21st-century intersectionalists. It doesn't make any sense.

Lecture 7: Othello's Ordeals

At a glance — Othello and its ordeals, returning to the opening question.

- 7.1** At the beginning of this series of lectures, I asked you a simple question. Why is it that Shakespeare, as a playwright, has never been bettered? And I hope that, over these lectures, I've been able to offer you some reasons why this is the case. But in this final lecture, I want to focus on another reason. In Shakespeare, we find a knowledge and insight into the human heart that is unsurpassed. When it comes to matters of morality and the question of evil, there's no one more astute. Alexander Solzhenitsyn famously described "the line dividing good and evil that cuts through the heart of every human being." That's from *The Gulag Archipelago*. For the most penetrating analysis of the endless moral complexities of the human condition, I think it is Shakespeare to whom we must turn.
- 7.2** So in a previous lecture, I discussed Macbeth, often considered one of Shakespeare's most villainous characters. To that, we could add all sorts of villains—Richard III, Joan of Arc from *Henry VI: Part 1*, Aaron from *Titus Andronicus*, Edmund from *King Lear*, Regan and Goneril, also from *King Lear*, Don John from *Much Ado About Nothing*. But above all, we have Iago from *Othello*, Shakespeare's ultimate villain, I would say. But there exists a huge range of distinction here, so these characters can't be satisfactorily bundled into a category of villain in a way that you might do with, say, Count Dracula, or Darth Vader, or Freddy Krueger, or Hannibal Lecter, or Dr. Robotnik from *Sonic the Hedgehog*.
- 7.3** We are accustomed, in popular entertainment, to these reductive conceptualizations of villainy. But Shakespeare's villains are complex. They're individual; they're dynamic human figures, and they come to life in performance because, for all the horror that they cause, their depiction is rooted in truth. They're not mere archetypes or ciphers. They have a life beyond what they represent. Perhaps more importantly, and perhaps more disturbingly, we recognize aspects of ourselves in them. In creating Macbeth, Shakespeare created a new kind of villain, one who's a hero and a victim of fate. He's also "full of the milk of human kindness," as his wife says. Now, you can't say the same for Richard III, who is naturally black-hearted, or Edmund from *King Lear*, whose bastardy and pariah status has made him into a sociopath.
- 7.4** If we compare Macbeth, say, to some of the early villains, if we, say, compare him to Aaron, from *Titus Andronicus*, that distinction becomes very stark. Now, Aaron has no compunction whatsoever about committing evil deeds. In fact, he completely thrives on it. In Act 5 of *Titus Andronicus*, at the moment that Aaron is to be executed, he's offered the chance to repent. Lucius says, "Art thou not sorry for these heinous deeds?" And Aaron says, "Ay, that I had not done a thousand more. Even now I curse the day—and yet I think few come within the compass of my curse, wherein I did not some notorious ill as kill a man, or else devise his death, ravish a maid, or plot the way

to do it; accuse some innocent and forswear myself; set deadly enmity between two friends; make poor men's cattle break their necks; set fire on barns and haystacks in the night, and bid the owners quench them with their tears."

- 7.5 This is almost pantomime villainy, isn't it? But it actually gets worse than that. Aaron says, "Oft have I digged up dead men from their graves and set them upright at their dear friends' door, even when their sorrows almost was forgot, and on their skins, as on the bark of trees, have with my knife carved in Roman letters, 'Let not your sorrow die, though I am dead.' But I have done a thousand dreadful things as willingly as one would kill a fly, and nothing grieves me heartily indeed, but that I cannot do ten thousand more."
- 7.6 Now, so even at the moment of his death, Aaron is able to work himself up into this near-erotic frenzy over these macabre fantasies. The idea that when someone is almost over the death of their friend, he digs the corpse up and props the corpse outside that person's house, carves into the flesh a message from beyond the grave—it is very overblown, very over the top. If you notice within that speech, at the start of the speech, he says that his only regret is that he couldn't have done a thousand more. By the end of the speech, he's saying that he wished he could have done 10,000 more. In other words, it is multiplied by 10 in the course of this short speech. He's working himself up.
- 7.7 Now, this is not a man who has tiptoed along the line dividing good and evil that cuts through the heart of every human being. This is one whose entire existence is propelled by the joy of unadulterated sadism. Aaron, I suppose, is, as an early villain, the closest that we might see to an archetype in Shakespeare. He's nowhere near as sophisticated as some of the later depictions of evil in the Shakespearean canon. But even Aaron is subject to certain pangs of compassion when it comes to protecting his own child. In other words, even when Shakespeare is developing his craft in these early stages, he can't help but improve on the theatrical expectations of the time.
- 7.8 I think a villain like Aaron owes an awful lot to the legacy of Christopher Marlowe. I don't know if you know much about Christopher Marlowe. He was a direct contemporary of Shakespeare, born in the same year, and he died in 1593. He's a fascinating character. There are lots of mysteries surrounding Marlowe. There's a very good book about Marlowe called *The Reckoning* by Charles Nicholl. I would thoroughly recommend that book. But this man is, so much about him is unknown. There's one image of him that survives. Well, we think it's of him. It was discovered at Corpus Christi College in Cambridge in 1952 or 1953. This was an image which, actually, we don't know whether it's Marlowe or not. The image actually states that the age of the sitter is 21, and the date does correspond to when Marlowe was attending Corpus Christi College. So it could well be him, but in truth, we just don't know.
- 7.9 He didn't write many plays because he died young, died in 1593, as I said. His final play was his best, *Edward II*. I think his death is one of the greatest losses to literature. He

was probably homosexual, probably an atheist, probably a spy. I say probably with all of this because all of this stuff is conditional on that. We don't know for sure. But it does seem, given the evidence, that those things are likely. He was certainly working for Sir Francis Walsingham, who was Queen Elizabeth I's spymaster. When he was killed, he was stabbed in the face, above the eye. People often say he died in a tavern brawl. That's not quite right. It was at the house of a widow, Eleanor Bull. In those days, widows and people would serve food and drink within their own houses. So it's like a tavern. But the three men that he was with were all associated in some way or other with Walsingham's spy network. It could be an assassination. We just don't know. We certainly can't trust the testimony of the people there and the man who killed him. It's very, very mysterious indeed.

- 7.10** But the reason I mention Marlowe, and the reason why I think it's so important, is because he is a major influence on Shakespeare. Shakespeare would not write the way that he does if it weren't for the legacy of Marlowe. I think early in Shakespeare's career, he is borrowing from Marlowe. He is developing some of the ideas that Marlowe develops. Some people have argued that Marlowe had a direct hand in the production of *Titus Andronicus*, that he co-wrote it. I suppose if you were going to cite Aaron's speech that I just read, that would be a good point in your defense, because that speech, that could be Barabas speaking, from Marlowe's *Jew of Malta*. For the record, I don't believe that Marlowe did have anything to do with it, but he certainly did have a major influence.
- 7.11** In *As You Like It*, *Touchstone* alludes directly to Marlowe. He uses the line, "It strikes a man more dead than a great reckoning in a little room." A reckoning meant the bill. So that sounds like a reference to Marlowe. And *Phoebe's* couplet as well: "Dead shepherd, now I find thy saw of might, whoever loved that loved not at first sight?" Dead shepherd is a reference to Marlowe. Of course, that line, "Whoever loved that loved not at first sight?", is taken directly from Marlowe's poem, *Hero and Leander*. The thing about Marlowe and his influence on Shakespeare is that it's to do with evil; it's to do with villainy. Marlowe loved the excessive spectacle of violence, and he also loved villains. He seemed to prefer villains to heroes.
- 7.12** If you think about, as I mentioned, Barabas in the *Jew of Malta*, who will poison a whole convent full of nuns. You have *Tamburlaine*, of course, this great marauding conqueror. *Doctor Faustus*, who sells his soul. *Mortimer* in *Edward II*, who's a major villain, very cruel. The Duke of Guise in the *Massacre at Paris*. Shakespeare's *Richard III*, as an early play, I think, is explicitly Marlovian. There's a lot of echoes there. He's a lot like Aaron the Moor, insofar that he finds his own evil acts to be a source of amusement. They love doing this because it makes them laugh.
- 7.13** What does Richard say in his opening soliloquy? He acknowledges his own physical deformity and he says: "And therefore, since I cannot prove a lover to entertain these fair, well-spoken days, I am determined to prove a villain and hate the idol pleasure of

these days. Plots have I laid, inductions dangerous, by drunken prophesies, libels and dreams to set my brother Clarence and the King in deadly hate the one against the other." Straightforward enough, I suppose. But later in the play, when he's haunted in his nightmares by the people that he has killed, he begins to show an aspect to his character that we haven't really seen before.

7.14 He says, "O coward conscience, how dost thou afflict me? The lights turn blue. It is now dead midnight. Cold fearful drops stand on my trembling flesh. What do I fear? Myself? There's none else by. Richard loves Richard; that is, I am I. Is there a murderer here? No. Yes, I am. Then fly! What, from myself? Great reason. Why? Lest I revenge. Myself upon myself? Alack, I love myself. Wherefore? For any good that I myself have done unto myself?" You can hear that the language is torturous. It is turning in on itself in a series of staccato monosyllabic questions. He's interrogating his own mind. He's unearthing the vestiges of humanity that still remain within him.

7.15 Now, a pantomime villain has no such struggles. A Marlovian villain has no such struggles. In other words, Richard III starts out as pure Marlowe and becomes something that is rather more Shakespearean. So there is a clear trajectory in Shakespeare's work. Macbeth, we're going to 1606 there, but roughly for Macbeth is a far more sophisticated character than those early villains, Richard III or Aaron. But this soliloquy in Richard III is, I think, the first step towards Macbeth, towards the capacity for a villain to reckon with himself, to articulate that internal conflict in a way that only Shakespeare could ever really achieve. In other words, Shakespeare begins by emulating Marlowe, and it ends up surpassing Marlowe. Richard III begins with a self-satisfied and self-amused villain who tells us exactly what he intends to do and why he intends to do it. But by Act 5, he's begun that process of self-reflection. That was not a feature of such characters on the English stage before this time.

7.16 Now, I've made this point before I'm going to make it again. Previous playwrights had depicted human conflict, an awful lot of it. But Shakespeare makes these conflicts an internal matter. His characters, and yes, even his villains, are at war with themselves. This is Shakespeare's great innovation. Let me give you just one other example from Marlowe. We, as audience members, we enjoy the villainy of the Duke of Guise. This is the other thing in Marlowe. The characters do some horrible things, but we can't help but enjoy it. The Duke of Guise has this pantomimic quality. He's in the play, *The Massacre at Paris*. He's a caricatured vision of evil. His words don't really suggest much of an interior reckoning. For the Duke, hubris is an irresistible inevitability. Consider the opening of his soliloquy where he talks about his lust for power.

7.17 He says, "Now, Guise"—note that he's referring to himself in the third person—"Now, Guise, begins those deep-engendered thoughts to burst abroad those never dying flames which cannot be extinguished but by blood. Oft have I leveled, and at last have learned that peril is the chiefest way to happiness, and resolution honor's fairest aim. What glory is there in a common good, that hangs for every peasant to achieve? That

like I best that flies beyond my reach, set me to scale the high Pyramides, and thereon set the diadem of France; I'll either rend it with my nails to naught, or mount the top with my aspiring wings, although my downfall be the deepest hell."

- 7.18** It's really interesting. He's suggesting, "Why should I be good? What's the point? What glory is there?" In good, any peasant can be good. It's far more enthralling to be evil, to aspire to be evil, even if it will condemn you to hell. In that speech, there's an allusion to Icarus. I think it's obvious. The aspiring wings of Icarus, who's a key figure of ancient mythology. He's in Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, which, as I said, is a text that Shakespeare knew well. You know the story, don't you? The man who attaches the wings to his body with wax and flies too near the sun and therefore falls. It's about the overreacher, the one who goes too far. It is widely interpreted as relating to the idea of hubris. Hubris, as I've said, being putting yourself above the gods.
- 7.19** Now, the Duke of Guise has made this absolutely clear. He says, "That like I best that flies beyond my reach." I like the things I cannot attain. He says, "I'll rend it with my nails or mount the top with my aspiring wings, although my downfall be the deepest hell." He's got no fear of failure because the danger itself exacerbates his thrill. He gets off on it. It is the cold narcissism of someone who would rather obliterate the world entirely than see it ruled by somebody else. Hitler felt much the same way about the German people when he was in his bunker, when he knew that everything was lost. If he was going to die, then his country and his people could die with him. It is a singular feature of narcissists.
- 7.20** Macbeth is not a narcissist. Macbeth is an entirely more complex figure. Shakespeare offers us an insight into his internal conflicts. As I pointed out in a previous lecture, he doesn't commit the acts of villainy lightly. He really struggles with them. He doesn't wish to proceed. But the power of the tragedy is that he is reluctant to take the path that is determined for him, but he has to take it anyway. And of course, it is interlaced with this really troubling sensation that we might well have done exactly the same as him.
- 7.21** So now I want to move on to *Othello*. I've left *Othello* to last because I think it is an incredible piece of work. It often gets missed off the list of major tragedies, but it does belong up there with the major tragedies. For one thing, I think it's one of the most profound interrogations into sexual jealousy that I've ever read. Well, certainly, I've never read anything that improves upon it. In particular, I want to focus on the figure of Iago. Iago is absolutely key in *Othello*. Now, *Othello*, as a play, strikes us as a bit of an outlier when it comes to Shakespeare's major works, particularly the major tragedies. Let's think about the opening of the play. OK, so you've got Iago and Roderigo, the gullible Roderigo. They're on their way by night through the streets of Venice to Brabantio's house to let him know that his daughter, Desdemona, has run off with their general, Othello.

- 7.22** Roderigo, we learn, is in love with Desdemona. He's very resentful that she's already devoted herself to Othello. We learn that Iago is harboring a certain degree of professional jealousy because he's been passed over for promotion to Michael Cassio, who is far lacking in experience. Iago says, with unconcealed bitterness, that he "never set a squadron in the field, nor the division of a battle knows more than a spinster." So he has this resentment. He has this professional jealousy. And we learn all this in the very first scene. Now, they go there by night, the pair of them. They call up to Brabantio's window. They wake him up and, in the most degrading terms, they let him know that his daughter has eloped. Desdemona has eloped.
- 7.23** They draw attention to Othello's race, and they draw attention to the age difference between the two. Again, in very, very degrading terms. So Iago says, "An old black ram is tupping your white ewe." Now, for most of the play, I should say, Othello's race isn't considered much of a concern. He's a North African Moor. He's a black man. But on the whole, it isn't a concern in the play. He is a respected general. His race is only ever really invoked critically and opportunistically by those who have another problem with him, those who take against him for other reasons. So it's not a play about racism, although race is a factor to consider.
- 7.24** And so we have Brabantio woken up in the middle of the night by these people shouting these obscene phrases up at the window about his daughter, the individual he loves more than anyone in the world. And he's furious. He's furious at her, as well. He's furious that she has married behind his back. At this time, that would have been an unspeakable thing to do. And he claims that Othello must have enchanted her. He says, "She has run to Othello's sooty bosom." He puts it down to practices of "cunning hell." In other words, here's an example of where race becomes a factor. Because he is furious with Othello, he then exoticizes him, and he invokes witchcraft and this kind of thing, and he mentions his "sooty bosom." So he is invoking it there, but only because he is angry. And that characterization is very much an aberration within this play.
- 7.25** So what is it that we are seeing here in this first scene? It strikes us that we are immediately in unfamiliar territory. This isn't like the other tragedies. This feels more like a domestic drama. It could even be the set-up for a comedy. Othello is a much more focused tragedy than the ones that we've looked at so far. Well, insofar that everything is revolved around the marriage of Othello and Desdemona, and beyond the complete disintegration of their relationship, the stakes aren't very high at all. I mean, yes, there is a broader conflict going on with the Turks, but most of them are drowned and defeated at the start of Act 2. So although at that point in the play, we move them from Venice and the last four acts are in Cyprus, on war conditions in the anticipation of conflict, the conflict really isn't about that. The conflict is about—it is within the household of Othello and Desdemona.
- 7.26** You contrast that to Hamlet, where Hamlet is a prince of the realm. He's got the Norwegian army approaching on the borders. It concerns the murder of a king, a

perverse succession, the breakdown of the royal family. That means the breakdown of the body politic. As Marcellus says, and I've quoted before, "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark." Those are very high stakes. So too in King Lear. You've got an elderly monarch, foolishly entrusts the keeping of the realm to the two daughters who despise him, exiling the one daughter who loves him and would serve his interests. That is a broken society. Regan and Goneril turn against each other. We end up with civil war. We're against this backdrop of a pagan world without salvation. The stakes, again, are very high.

7.27 Macbeth, very high stakes. It's about the murder of a king. His murder is descent into tyranny. It's all guided by powerful militias, supernatural, malevolent forces. Even in Timon of Athens, which is what we would say is a minor tragedy, I suppose, it's certainly an uneven tragedy. It was probably a collaboration with a writer called Thomas Middleton. But there we're focusing on a lord who turns his back on society, and there's a city at war. All of these things are much bigger than Othello, because Othello is about one married couple. That is where the drama is located. One is not left at the end of the play with a sense that the deaths of Othello and Desdemona have any lasting impact on Venice as a whole. Cassio is left in charge of Cyprus. The political situation is much as it was before.

7.28 And yet, I would say this is perhaps the most heartbreaking of Shakespeare's plays. I would say perhaps it even exceeds the heartbreak at the end of King Lear. It's one of those plays I've seen a number of times, and I almost don't want to see it again. Every time I watch Othello, it distresses me, profoundly, and I think it's meant to. It is a difficult play. Maybe it is because it doesn't have those broader political ramifications. Maybe it is because it's so deeply rooted in human experience and this particular couple. Maybe that's why neither of them deserve what happens to them. But that's a theme that we're coming back to again and again, isn't it, throughout Shakespeare.

7.29 Through this character of Iago, we sense the presence of evil in a much more potent and distilled way than anywhere else in the Shakespeare canon. Othello, as a play, is brilliantly constructed. You've got the first two acts which set up all of the conditions necessary for Iago's final treachery to convince Othello, in other words, that Desdemona is sleeping with Michael Cassio. And once Othello starts to accept this and think that this is happening, once he starts falling for Iago's scheme, from Act 3 to the end of the play, it doesn't let up at all. It just goes straight through, in that way that I mentioned with Macbeth, where I suggested that it goes too fast for us. We want it to slow down because it's too unbearable. Same in the last three acts of Othello. It doesn't let up. We get dragged down into Othello's spiral of jealousy and rage. We feel that we're on the same journey.

7.30 Like Macbeth, the moments of relief that we want are not lacking. Sorry, are lacking. There's a clown at one point, very brief moment of comedy, and then it's gone. Shakespeare, in other words, in the first two acts of Othello, is building this world. He

takes his time with this play in a very interesting way—again, which makes it feel more a domestic drama. So he builds the world, he establishes the relationships, all of the qualities of the key players, and then he lets the switch off, and we are accelerating to hell.

- 7.31** In the first scene, as I've said, Iago shows his hand. He tells Roderigo, "I will wear my heart upon my sleeve for daws to peck at. I am not what I am." Now, look, Roderigo is stupid. Iago can say whatever he wants to Roderigo because Roderigo is too foolish to understand the significance of what he is so plainly being told. There's something profane in his words. "I am not what I am." Well, that's a variation on the words of God in Exodus. "I am that I am." This is a perverse inversion. This is like a diabolical inversion of that idea. Iago says, "I am not what I am." What does that mean? He's saying, "I'm not who you think I am. You can't trust me." But he says it outright from the very first scene. He's also implying that he lives in opposition to the light of God. He says he's going to wear his heart on his sleeve "for daws to peck at." Daws means jackdaws, foolish birds. And Roderigo is one of those jackdaws, of course. But of course, to Iago, everyone is a jackdaw.
- 7.32** Something he delights in is that he can get away with anything because he's better than anyone. He's smarter than anyone, or at least he thinks he is. "I am not what I am." So what exactly is he? Does Iago even know himself? Now, this is a question that we might want to seek to resolve, but the play stubbornly refuses to resolve it. Many critics have argued over Iago's motives. This is an absolute key point. Why does he do what he does? Now, I don't know what any of you think or whether you've got a sense of what the motive really is, but a lot of people haven't been able to work it out. Coleridge famously declared, described that Iago had a "motiveless malignancy." Sorry, malignity. It's an interesting phrase. Is he really motiveless? I mean, yes, he was passed over for promotion, right? And that's said right from the start. Is that a satisfactory motive for this? I don't think it really works.
- 7.33** Now, we've noticed in the soliloquies that when a character has some kind of torment about a particular issue, there are long soliloquies in which they grapple with it, in which they explore it. That doesn't happen here. Iago mentions that he was passed over for promotion and then drops it, and that's it. Doesn't mention it again. If this were the driving force for Iago's evil, we would have a soliloquy about it. We would have a lot more. So why does he say that? It's almost like it's an excuse. There are other examples. By the way, I should say, Iago's soliloquies are particularly fascinating in Shakespeare because I think they're unique. They seem to be the only soliloquies in which a character lies to himself. We don't get that.
- 7.34** Other characters will reveal what's going on in their heads, however confused that might be. Iago doesn't even tell the truth when he's by himself on stage, talking to himself. Consider what he says in Act 1, Scene 3. He says, "I hate the Moor." That's true enough. He hates Othello. "I hate the Moor. And it is thought abroad that 'twixt my

sheets he has done my office." OK, so there's a rumor that Othello has slept with Iago's wife, Amelia. Do we believe that? No, it's really unlikely, and Iago doesn't believe it either. He says, "I know not if it be true, but I, for the mere suspicion in that kind, will do as if for surety." In other words, it doesn't matter to him if Othello has actually slept with his wife, Amelia. He's going to proceed on the assumption that he has, anyway.

7.35 We saw this rationalization, didn't we, with Julius Caesar, when Brutus admits to himself that Caesar has never been anything but a rational and just leader. He says, "And to speak truth of Caesar, I have not known when his affection swayed more than his reason." And yet, he says he's a "serpent's egg waiting to be hatched." So he's condemning him for something he hasn't done. Now, Iago, similarly, does not really believe that Othello has cuckolded him. He says, "I know not if it be true," but the merest suspicion will suffice as rationalization. And then there's this odd moment in Act 3, Scene 3, where Iago says to Othello that he slept one night with Cassio. It's quite common at the time for men to share beds. He slept one night with Cassio. Cassio is having a dream. He tells Othello what happened. It's very curious. This is what he says.

7.36 "I lay with Cassio lately, and being troubled with a raging tooth, I could not sleep. There are a kind of men so loose of soul that in their sleeps will mutter their affairs. One of this kind is Cassio. In sleep, I heard him say, 'Sweet Desdemona, let us be wary, let us hide our loves.' And then, sir, would he grip and wring my hand, cry, 'O, sweet creature!', then kiss me hard, as if he plucked up kisses by the roots, that grew upon my lips, lay his leg over my thigh, and sigh, and kiss, and then cry, 'Cursed fate, that gave thee to the Moor!'" And Othello replies, "Monstrous, monstrous." And Iago, using his typical tactic of trying to get Othello to reach his own conclusions, says, "Nay, this was but his dream."

7.37 So, what do we make of this? The story that Iago tells is oddly specific. It's oddly detailed. Why all these details about him gripping his hand, kissing him hard, laying his leg over his thigh? Sounds a bit like a sexual fantasy, doesn't it? It sounds like he's getting off on it. Now, Laurence Olivier famously broached the idea that Iago's motive is, in fact, suppressed homosexuality. That's why he hates the Moor, because he's in love with the Moor. He doesn't even understand those feelings himself. Well, that's an interesting possibility. There could be something to it. I think that speech about the dream certainly points in that direction. It's not as though Shakespeare hadn't represented homosexuality before. You have Patroclus and Achilles in *Troilus and Cressida*. You have the sonnets, which are gay love poems for the most part. It's not that he wouldn't broach it.

7.38 Of course, King James I was on the throne at this point, who was openly gay. But the point is, I suppose, that I don't think it's necessarily a satisfactory motive if it is true. It's one of those things that actors have to decide. I think the actor playing Iago probably has to decide why he's doing it. The problem is, the text does not tell him why he's doing it. This is just another possibility, that he's seeking to destroy Othello because he

loves Othello. Now, actually, there's some good reason for this. Psychological studies keep showing us that there is a strong correlation between homophobia and suppressed homosexuality. In other words, those people who declare that they hate gay people tend to secretly share their desires. It makes sense. It's projection. And certainly this scene is oddly homoerotic. He's imagining and reliving an intimate moment with Cassio that didn't actually happen.

- 7.39** But maybe there's another option. Maybe Iago is in love with Desdemona. How about that? Maybe that's there. Well, he says something that implies it. This is towards the end of Act 2, Scene 1. I think it's worth considering this in full because it really does draw us into a better understanding of Iago. But ultimately, what I would say is, this soliloquy does raise more questions than it answers. He says, "That Cassio loves her, I do well believe it. That she loves him, 'tis apt and of great credit. The Moor—how be it that I endure him not—is of a constant, loving, noble nature. And I dare think he'll prove to Desdemona a most dear husband." So why is he doing all this? He admires them all.
- 7.40** Anyway, he says, "Now I do love her too, not out of absolute lust—though peradventure I stand accountant for as great a sin—but partly led to diet my revenge for that I do suspect the lusty Moor hath leapt into my seat." There's that idea again that he suggests that Othello might have slept with Amelia. "The thought whereof doth, like a poisonous mineral, gnaw my inwards, and nothing can or shall content my soul, till I am evened with him, wife for wife—or failing so, yet that I put the Moor at least into a jealousy so strong that judgment cannot cure." Note that there is self-deception here on a grand scale. So Iago seems to be implying that the relationship he has concocted between Desdemona and Cassio has some basis in truth. I mean, he made up that lie that Cassio and Desdemona are having an affair. Now he's saying, "Yeah, it's probably true."
- 7.41** Do you see what's happening here? He creates a fantasy, and then he believes it himself. He seems to be implying—he says that it's apt, he says. It's apt that they love each other. So he's believing his own lies again. He acknowledges that the Moor is loving, constant, noble. Of course, that makes him all the more vulnerable, doesn't it, to Iago's schemes? But Iago also confesses, crucially, that he has lusted after Desdemona. So is that the motive? This is the case in the source text. In *Hecatomithi*, which is this old Italian book of short stories, there's a story from which Shakespeare took the Othello plot, and in that, it's quite clear that Iago does love Desdemona. Now, that isn't something that is clear to me in Shakespeare's text.
- 7.42** Why, for instance, does it get mentioned here as an inconsequential aside? Like I said before, why isn't there a big soliloquy about it? I don't believe it. I don't think we're meant to believe it, and I don't think Iago believes it. I suppose it means as much as his suggestion that Othello has slept with Amelia. Again, I suppose it's possible that Othello has slept with Amelia, but there's no evidence at all for it. Iago must know that it's not

true. And yet what does he say? He says, "It gnaws my inwards." It gnaws him inside. How can that be? How can you concoct a lie and then get so upset about it that you have a physiological reaction to it? That's the kind of man we're dealing with here. He is stirred by his own twisted fantasies. They have the same effect on him as though they were real.

- 7.43 Iago's life, in other words, is one dominated by the fictions that he chooses to weave for himself. It isn't just that he relishes the power that he exerts over his unsuspecting victims, but that he lives his life as though his stories were true. And so, in this fantasy parallel reality, Iago has convinced himself, or at least has pretended to convince himself, that he wants to get even with Othello, wife for wife. And yet we know from Shakespeare's description of Othello and the courtship that he had with Desdemona, that Othello does not have a sexually predatory nature. That's not who he is. Early in the play, when we hear about their courtship, we know that it came about almost by accident.
- 7.44 Othello was often at the house, telling stories of his travels and conquests and wars, his encounters with strange men, cannibals, strange creatures, he says, men whose heads grow beneath their shoulders. This is the kind of thing that the travel narratives of the time were full of. Remember, this is a time when people were conquering the globe. They were traveling all over the world, finding new cultures and peoples that they had never known existed. It would be the equivalent of us coming across aliens. It would be that significant. You had these travel narratives. There's one in particular I'm thinking of. There's an image from a book called the *Cosmographia* by Sebastian Münster. From 1572, it shows an image of one of these men with a face below the shoulders, just as Othello describes. Remember what I said, Shakespeare is a voracious reader. He read a lot, so he would have come across these kinds of images.
- 7.45 So not only is Othello not exoticized, he exoticizes others. And it's clear that Desdemona was as much an active agent in their courtship as he was, because Othello says this. He says, "She loved me for the dangers I had passed, and I loved her that she did pity them. This only is the witchcraft I have used." That is to say, no witchcraft at all. Othello is no predator. He is not an "old black ram tugging white ewes." And for Iago to present him as such, so early on in the play, establishes that we're dealing with a particular kind of villain, one who's weaving his own perverted reality and inviting other people to share in that perverted reality. It's crucial for the play that we believe in the purity and the transcendental quality of the love between Desdemona and Othello. This is very important. This is the thing that gets destroyed. We have to believe in it, and Shakespeare makes us believe in it.
- 7.46 Iago is taking a wrecking ball to something sacred in humanity, our capacity to love. There's nothing more sacred than that, to so fully invest ourselves in another human being that we prioritize their happiness over our own to rejoice fully and completely in someone else's existence. That is what Iago destroys so callously. That sense of the loss

of something pure is why the play has this devastating impact on us. If you look at the scene where Othello and Desdemona are reunited in Act 2, Othello says, "O, my fair warrior." Desdemona says, "My dear Othello."

7.47 Othello says, "It gives me wonder great as my content to see you here before me, O my soul's joy, if after every tempest come such calms. May the winds blow till they have wakened death, and let the laboring barque climb hills of seas Olympus-high, and duck again as low as hell's from heaven." All tribulations, all terrors, all the natural shocks that flesh is heir to, are all worth enduring, so long as he may be united with his wife, Desdemona. He continues, "I cannot speak enough of this content. It stops me here. It is too much of joy. And this," and they kiss, "and this, the greatest discords be that e'er our heart shall make." Nothing will ever come between us, although he doesn't know. He doesn't know about Iago.

7.48 What does Iago say? Hearing all these words, he says, "O, you are well tuned now, but I'll set down the pegs that make this music, as honest as I am." Now, he's talking about the pegs of a musical instrument that are playing this sweet tune. He's going to slacken those pegs because he is a vandal of love. He wants a different tune to be played, one that is shrill and discordant and ugly. He even scoffs, "as honest as I am." He's mocking that quality that other people apply to him. He's continually in this play referred to as "honest Iago." Othello calls him honest all the time, and Iago finds that amusing. He finds it amusing that Othello or anyone finds him honest when all the while he's plotting against him. It is a thrill for him to be so misunderstood.

7.49 Even in the first scene of the play, Iago is degrading the love, isn't he? He's degrading this love between Othello and Desdemona, making impure all that is pure. He's undermining and skewering anything that speaks of goodness and beauty. He has a need to poison it. Not only does he cry out to Brabantio, "An old black ram is tupping your white ewe," which is a vulgar enough phrase, he says that they are "making the beast with two backs," which is a phrase you may have heard of. It comes from Shakespeare, making the beast with two backs. He's depicting their love as lust. Two people copulating, becoming one animal with two backs. It's grotesque. And it's wrong. It's completely wrong. Othello and Desdemona never consummate their marriage, ever.

7.50 Now, once Brabantio is summoned, Iago absents himself. He leaves only Roderigo there to be identified. So we know that he's cunning. We know what he's doing. We might think of Iago throughout the play as a kind of puppet master, not just of Othello, of everyone—Cassio, Iago, even Amelia, definitely Desdemona. It's that control of other people that delights him, that drives him onwards. One of his character's odd little tics is he always uses this phrase "go to." You might not have noticed it. It's such a casual thing. But if you read it again, have a look. He always says, "Go to." It's very casual. Just go away. It's really dismissive. It implies someone who is just completely impatient of

the whims of others, like waving his hand like a conductor and assuming that his wishes will be done without any further discussion.

- 7.51** I think it's one of those really revealing little details that Shakespeare really gets, little verbal tics. Look at Hamlet again. Look at the way that Hamlet speaks, that constant repetition needlessly of little words here and there. Other characters don't do it in the play. Just, as I say, he thinks as the character, and therefore, he also gets these little verbal tics right. Most writers wouldn't do that. They wouldn't think to do that. And also in this case, this is something that just isn't generally noticed.
- 7.52** Iago then tells us, "I am not what I am." That's his phrase. "I am not what I am." And it is the case that no one truly knows Iago, although the success of his machinations are dependent on the fact that Othello thinks that he knows Iago. As I said, he describes him repeatedly as honest, a man of honesty and trust. And this is a reputation we can assume that Iago has cultivated over many years. Harold Bloom, who I've mentioned a number of times in these lectures, he described Iago as a great improviser. And frequently in the play, Iago seizes the opportunity to manipulate events to his advantage. Now, I think the first example of this is Brabantio's final words to Othello. This is in Act 1. He says, "Look to her, Moor." He's accepted that Othello has married Desdemona, and that's that. "Look to her, Moor, if thou hast eyes to see. She has deceived her father, and may thee."
- 7.53** It's one comment. Iago doesn't respond, doesn't say anything. In fact, there's no overt indication that he's registered it, but he is there when the line is uttered. Then this sentiment seems to lurk under all of Othello's susceptibility to Iago's manipulation. It's as though Brabantio has planted this seed in Iago's head. If she has so easily deceived her father, why would she not deceive her husband? It's a bit like, we all know people who have been in relationships that started by cheating, right? You might be in one. If you're in that kind of relationship, you know that there's always that slight seed of doubt. Well, you did it before. Anyway, that, I think, is what's happening here.
- 7.54** Then what happens is, Iago explicitly echoes the words of Brabantio in Act 3, Scene 3. He says, "She did deceive her father, marrying you." We didn't register that he'd clocked it, but he had. He'd heard it. He'd recognized it might be useful. He'd put it away in his mind somewhere, and then he deploys it at just the right time. He is an improviser, a preparer. He's always prepared. He's looking for scraps of things that he can use in the future. Similarly, when Cassio happens to take Desdemona's hand in Act 2, Scene 1, Iago realizes that's a useful tool, and he says in an aside, "With as little a web as this will I ensnare a great fly as Cassio." The words, the coincidences, the little daily actions —these are all just raw material for Iago's mischief and villainy.
- 7.55** We know this because, when Amelia says that he has—what does she say? She says, "A hundred times he's urged her to steal Desdemona's handkerchief." It's not something he's just come up with. He's been doing this for ages. He's been on at his wife saying, "Can you steal Desdemona's handkerchief for me?" Why? Why would he need that?

What's the point? Is it because he's in love with Desdemona? You might read it that way. Or is it because he thought, "Maybe I could use that in some way that I don't yet know"? Maybe it's that. Similarly, Cassio's remarks about how he can't handle his drink. You remember Cassio says, "I better not drink anything because I get drunk too easily." What does Iago do? Gets him off to drink, gets him into a fight. All of this ends up with Cassio being demoted. He's no longer the lieutenant that he was. He shames him. He basically destroys him.

- 7.56** There's that other example, when Iago and Othello are approaching Cassio and Desdemona, just as Cassio is leaving Desdemona. What does Iago do? He says, "Ha, I like not that." Now, Cassio has done nothing. He's just walked away. Iago is saying to Othello, "That looks a bit suspicious to me." So he's making it up as he goes along. In fact, he says he looked like he was walking—why would he walk away looking all guilty like that? This is the kind of mind we're dealing with. And Roderigo is another because Roderigo is obsessed with Desdemona, and Iago seizes on that and encourages it. He tells him, "You know what you should do? You should build up your assets. Put money in thy purse." That famous speech, he repeats it again and again. "Put money in thy purse." In other words, saying, "You can have Desdemona. There's no reason you can't have Desdemona. You'll be able to woo her from Othello's side."
- 7.57** Iago seems particularly alert to the ways in which love can blind men to reason. In a previous lecture, I mentioned this common Renaissance trope of the dichotomy of reason and passion. Well, Iago is fully aware of that. He says, "But we have reason to cool our raging motions, our carnal stings, our unbitted lusts; whereof I take this that you call love to be a sect or scion." A sect or scion. Love is just like a cutting from the tree of lust. That's all it is. It's a bit like Mercutio just misinterpreting love as lust. He's saying, "Love is just another thing that I can use to manipulate you. Love is just a civilizing patina to these animal instincts." Remember, he's already described the beast with two backs. That's what he thinks. Just as Mercutio degrades the love of Romeo and Rosaline, or Romeo and Juliet even, we then have, at this moment, he is degrading the love of Othello and Desdemona.
- 7.58** And by the way, there isn't really any suggestion that his relationship with Amelia, Iago and Amelia, that that's a particularly loving bond. There's no suggestion there. There's a lot of banter between them. They get on reasonably well. But it's not an intense passionate love, is it? There's no suggestion of that. But he's going to use love to manipulate others. As far as Iago is concerned, the very concept of love is a weakness that he can use to his advantage. Othello, of course, wouldn't be jealous if there was nothing to be jealous of. If he wasn't deeply in love with Desdemona, none of this would happen. And Roderigo, likewise, would not be so easily gulled if he wasn't obsessed with Desdemona. And even the framing of Cassio couldn't have worked if he hadn't been sleeping with the courtesan Bianca. Even when sex and love do not degrade Shakespeare's characters, these emotions do make them vulnerable.

7.59 Now, Iago lives in a world where deception is the norm. Because he is false, he assumes that everyone else must be false. What does he say to his wife, Emilia, about the duplicity of women? You must remember this. "Come on, come on. You are pictures out of door, bells in your parlors, wildcats in your kitchens, saints in your injuries, devils being offended, players in your housewifery, and hussies in your beds." And this is just a litany of misogynistic stereotypes. So when he says that women are "pictures out of doors," he means that they're like a painting. They're like a pretense. They put on an image in public to disguise their true natures. You think of Hamlet when he's going on about "nature gives you one face and you paint yourselves another," the idea that even makeup is a sign of women's duplicity. It's a common trope of the time.

7.60 Iago says that they are chatterboxes, "bells in your parlors." He says that women are territorial, "wildcats in your kitchens," that they feign innocence when they commit harm. He says "saints in your injuries," that they are "devils being offended." One thinks of the proverb, "Hell hath no fury like a woman scorned." It's just a variation on that, really. Iago also says that women pretend to be good at housekeeping. "Players in your housewifery," or housewifery. Finally, he says, of course, "hussies in your beds," which is—I don't have to explain. But so often in Shakespeare, women are not passive figures who accept this kind of abuse. You have Emilia and Desdemona listening to all of this. Of course, Iago is trying to be funny. Let's not forget that as well. He's being deliberately provocative here, but it's rooted in a truth.

7.61 Emilia and Desdemona, they won't allow him to get away with it. Desdemona says, "O, fie upon thee, slanderer!" We're not meant to take Iago's words seriously, only that his predisposition to assume dissemblance, that tells us a lot about his own mind. Now, some critics have interpreted Emilia as being a kind of proto-feminist figure, and certainly there's her final refusal to obey her husband's commands. That is the conclusion of the plot, when she tells the story of the handkerchief, and he's telling her to get home, to shut up, and she's not going to do it.

7.62 She also talks about men, generally, in Act 3, Scene 4. She said, "They are all but stomachs, and we are but food. They eat us hungrily, and when they are full, they belch us." There's a really interesting scene between Emilia and Desdemona, when Desdemona says that she could never be unfaithful; she could never be untrue. Emilia says, "I could. It's fine." She doesn't have the same values as Desdemona does, but we still, we very much warm to her. She's one of the most likable characters, I think, in the play. Maybe she is a proto-feminist. She's certainly very independent of mind.

7.63 Back to Iago. William Hazlitt, who I always keep banging on about because I love him, he wrote brilliantly on Iago, and in doing so, said that Shakespeare knew that the love of power, which is another name for the love of mischief, is natural to man. I don't think anyone said that better. I think Iago seems to be the absolute embodiment of that notion. Iago enjoys games, not just these high-stakes games that end in death. He likes little language games. There's subtlety in his insinuations. This is from Act 3, Scene 3.

Othello says, "I do not think but Desdemona is honest." And Iago says, "Long live she so, and long live you to think so!" So that word think, "long live you to think so," very pointed, because it's a way to signal to Othello that he's probably wrong. There's deception going on there, but he doesn't say it. He doesn't need to say it. So much of Iago's words are about implication, rather than overt expression.

7.64 One thing that the play does is, it takes us on a journey with the character, as I'd say in all Shakespeare plays, really. But in this case, there are two Othellos, I think. So the first Othello is the respected and dignified general from the opening of the play. Then you have a second Othello, which is the murderer, blinded by jealousy, deranged by fury, driven into a state of total degradation and damnation. So how we get from one version of Othello to the other version of Othello, that is the story of Shakespeare's play, and that is also Iago's challenge. How can he do this? How can he transform this one Othello, who is so naturally noble—and as Othello says in his final words, "not given to jealousy"—how does he turn that person into this killer? How does he do this? Othello would believe nothing bad of Desdemona. He says, "If she be false, O then heaven mocks itself!" And yet, he does kill her. He does fall for Iago's trick.

7.65 Now, Desdemona is absolutely key to this. I think a lesser writer would have made her a saintly, beautiful, vacuous figure, one whose function is solely to serve the plot. But Desdemona is a fascinating character. She's three-dimensional. She's dignified. She's morally sound, she's intelligent, she's perceptive. Roderigo's affection for her is probably just the unbridled lust of youth, of course, but she does have this reputation for her beauty that seems rooted in something more profound, something about her soul. Cassio describes her in this way, saying of their marriage, "He hath achieved a maid that paragons description and wild fame, one that excels the quirks of blazoning pens, and in the essential vesture of creation does tire the engineer." So the "blazoning pens," you remember when I talked about the blazon, the writing of poems that compartmentalized the body? It's not good enough for Desdemona because she excels the quirks of those writers.

7.66 How does Othello kill that woman? How can that happen? It doesn't make sense. How can the best of men commit the worst of deeds? That, I think, is all the plot that we need. People have said that Othello has quite a simple plot, doesn't have all these major complicated subplots that some of the other plays have. But I think this fundamental transformation of the one version of Othello into the other version of Othello is all you need for a supreme dramatic achievement. I'm reminded of a brilliant novel by Norman Douglas called *South Wind*, which is a forgotten novel, but was considered in the early 20th century, one of the best novels that had been published. The critics at the time attacked it because they said it didn't have a plot. They were very angry about this. It doesn't have a plot. When was it published? Around 1917, I think.

7.67 Norman Douglas replied to this. He said, "It would be nearer to the truth to say that there is nothing but plot from beginning to end." This is what he said, "How to make

murder palatable to a bishop— that is the plot." That's what the novel does. In *South Wind*, a bishop arrives on an island, the island of Nepenthe, which a fictionalized version of Capri, and he's a decent God-fearing bishop and, by the end of the play, he watches a murder and doesn't seem to mind. So the whole novel is about just transforming the one man into the other. It's also satirical and very, very funny. But that is the plot. That's all you need. The idea is that this man, this saintly man, can go to a Mediterranean island and become Mediterraneanized, lose his English inhibitions, lose his sense of morality.

7.68 Othello does the same. In *Othello*, we start out with one character, and he is completely transformed into another. And I think that's all we need. And Shakespeare, I think, does this better than anyone. Macbeth does the same, doesn't he? Macbeth goes from war hero to mass-murdering tyrant, a killer of children. And more than that, Shakespeare takes us with him. He makes us experience it. He makes us comprehend the transition. So in *Othello*, this transition is no less remarkable. Iago, of course, is the figure who actuates that metamorphosis, and he guides us. He guides the form that it takes. He analogizes the process to poisoning. Iago says, "I'll pour this pestilence in his ear." That's a common theme in Shakespeare. He mentions it a few times. The death of Claudius in *Hamlet* is poison poured into the ear.

7.69 By Act 3, Iago resolves to leave Desdemona's handkerchief in Cassio's chamber, knowing that Othello will see it in his possession and assume that his wife has given it to him. This handkerchief is very important to Othello. He talks about it. It was the first love token that he ever gave to her. If he sees Cassio with it, then it's game over. This is what Iago says. "I will in Cassio's lodging lose this napkin, and let him find it. Trifles light as air are to the jealous confirmations strong as proofs of holy writ." Note how well he understands human nature. And consider what happens in the next scene. Othello starts to see evidence of infidelity everywhere. He touches Desdemona's hand and finds it moist. He says it's suggestive of "a liberal heart," with an implication of sexual licentiousness.

7.70 As a side point, I always think of Iago's later line in this scene. He says, "Take note, take note, O world, to be direct and honest is not safe." What I find interesting about that is Iago is absolutely right. Iago does have a keen insight into human nature. He's right about these things. He's right that, if you plant the seeds of doubt, people will start seeing evidence of their own. And he's also right that to be honest carries risk. It makes you vulnerable. So what I'm saying is that, even while Shakespeare has created this complete moral abyss in human form, he does put wisdom into his mouth. Iago is intelligent. And moreover, that wisdom that Iago has is fundamental to his ability to torture other people. This is what he says. He says, "This may do something. The Moor already changes with my poison." There's that analogy again. "Dangerous conceits are in their natures poisons, which at the first are scarce found to distaste, but, with a little art upon the blood, burn like the mines of sulphur." A little art upon the blood.

- 7.71** Now, if you look at the Folio text, which I mentioned to you, it actually says, "Act upon the blood." I think the quarto's version, "art", is more effective. Both could work. It could be the compositor miswrote the word art, but I think art is better. "His art upon the blood." Iago is constantly aware of his sense of performance. It's part of his strategy, the art of destroying this man. Now, a little "art upon the blood" is what we see at the start of Act 4, when Iago's suggestions actually propel Othello into an epileptic fit. So this is a key moment when we see Iago's poison taking hold, the transition of the Othello we all know and respect into a man who would murder his wife. I think this is that key moment, that turning point. The certainties of the world are collapsing, and so too the language with which Othello can express himself.
- 7.72** So we open Act 4 in medias res, in the middle of the action, midway through a heated conversation between Iago and Othello. Othello says, "Hath he said anything?" Iago: "He hath, my lord, but you will be well assured, no more than he'll unsweat." "What hath he said?" "Faith, that he did—I know not what he did." And Othello, "What, what!" Iago: "Lie—". Othello: "With her?" Iago: "With her, on her, what you will." And then, with that devastating comment, Othello's eloquence totally deserts him. We shift from verse to prose. All his poise is gone. We're left with frantic repetition, a panicked and frenzied syntax. What does Othello say?
- 7.73** "Lie with her? Lie on her? We say 'lie on her' when they belie her. Lie with her? 'Swounds, that's fulsome!' 'Swounds is God's wounds. It's a contraction, a minced oath. 'Handkerchief—confessions—handkerchief.' You can hear the confusion in his mind. 'To confess and be hanged for his labor. First to be hanged and then to confess! I tremble at it. Nature would not invest herself in such shadowing passion without some instruction. It is not words that shake me thus. Pish! Noses, ears, and lips! Is't possible? Confess? Handkerchief? O devil!' And Othello falls down in a trance. He's having a fit. He's broken down linguistically. He then breaks down physically. And Iago leans down to him—and observe this coldness, this self-satisfaction. Iago says, "Work on, my medicine, work. Thus credulous fools are caught." At Othello's lowest point, Iago is having a great time.
- 7.74** In all of this, of course, Iago is drawing on the fear of cuckoldry. This is a really common theme in Shakespeare. It's common among many writers of the time. If one's wife sleeps with another man, that makes you a cuckold. It suggests a man who is incapable of controlling the sexuality of his wife. Weirdly, that word has had a resurgence in recent years on certain online forums. I don't know why. The idea of being cuckolded, for instance—the idea is that your masculinity has been taken away from you. It's strange because it actually means the same as it did in Shakespeare's day, but it's coming back in fashion.
- 7.75** In Shakespeare's day, the notion of cuckoldry became associated, or was associated, with the myth of Actaeon. You might know the myth of Actaeon. It's where Actaeon is out hunting in the woods. It's in Ovid. Again, it's in Ovid's *Metamorphoses*. He's hunting

in the woods. He comes across the goddess Diana bathing naked. And because she's so embarrassed and ashamed and humiliated that this man has seen her naked, she turns him, transforms him, into a stag. And because he was out hunting, his hunting dogs then chase him and tear him to pieces as a stag. Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, by the way, is just a series of stories about transformations, hence the title.

- 7.76** Now, because this was often interpreted as being related to cuckoldry, it means that often the horns of Actaeon, the horns of the stag, are invoked. It's like a symbol, like a shortcut, an allusion that everyone at the time would have got. By the way, the etymology of the term cuckold goes from the Old French for cuckoo, and you can still hear it, can't you? The idea—a bird that lays its eggs in other nests. There is a connection there. That's why men at this time were so fearful that their wives were sleeping with other people. Maybe not because of the sex itself, but if you're raising a child that is not your own, that really matters in this society where patrilineage is so important. You've got to secure a male offspring. The stakes for female infidelity are really, really high. It also, of course, there's that sense of competitive shame with other men. So this is also about male relations.
- 7.77** We get it all through Shakespeare, all the time. *Merry Wives of Windsor*, you might remember, Falstaff attempts to cuckold two married men. He courts their wives. He ends up getting his comeuppance when he's encouraged to disguise himself as this character, Herne the Hunter, and wear stag's horns. It's not an accident; it's deliberate. The symbolism is very clear. In *Much Ado About Nothing*, Don Pedro utters the proverb that "the savage bull doth bear the yoke," when he's talking to Benedick, because Benedick says he's forsworn love. And Benedick replies, "The savage bull may, but if ever the sensible Benedick bear it, pluck off the bull's horns and set them in my forehead, and let me be vilely painted, and in such great letters as they write, 'Here is good horse to hire,' let them signify under my sign, 'Here you may see Benedick, the married man.'" In other words, there's a risk to be married. You can get cuckolded. You can have horns on your head. Claudio says, "If this should ever happen, thou wouldst be horn-mad."
- 7.78** The image is really, really commonplace. There's a play called *Women Beware Women* by Thomas Middleton. Early Jacobean, we don't know the exact date. The whole plot of that play is that a man has married this beautiful young woman. He's so paranoid she's going to sleep with someone else that he locks her in the house, keeps her locked away. But of course, the joke is that, by doing that, he creates the conditions that she ends up committing adultery. It's commonly used for humor at the time, the idea of cuckoldry.
- 7.79** In *Othello*, cuckoldry directs us to tragedy, because Othello's love for Desdemona is not a laughing matter. It's very dignified, very serious. In Act 3, Scene 3, when Othello fears that Desdemona may have been unfaithful, when those fears start to germinate, what does he say? It's very subtle. He says, "I have a pain upon my forehead here." He

probably has a pain upon his forehead. There are lots of suggestions that he has poor eyesight throughout the play, but the implication, symbolically, poetically, is also, of course, that he is growing the cuckold's horns.

7.80 So let us come to the terrible final scene, surely the most painful scene in all of Shakespeare. This is when Othello, now convinced that Desdemona has made him a cuckold, goes to the bed chamber to kill her. Note that the method of the murder has been decided upon by Iago. What does Iago say to him? "Do it not with poison. Strangle her in her bed, even the bed she hath contaminated." And Othello sees that as poetic justice. Othello says, "Good, good, the justice of it pleases." So Iago, always the puppet master. He's not only created the conditions whereby Othello will kill his wife, he's decided on how he's going to kill his wife. He gets to decide every little detail in this little show.

7.81 And it's a really difficult scene to watch because she's lying in the bed, their marriage bed. They haven't consummated their marriage yet. He's coming in. He has the speech, put out the light, and then put out the light. He knows what he's going to do. She wakes up and she tells him, when he starts to speak of killing, well, she cannot really comprehend it. She knows that something has been wrong. He strikes her earlier in the play across the face. He humiliates her. He has been needlessly angry with her, but she has no conception of what is to come. He's standing above her, and he's going to kill her, and he tells her he's going to kill her, and she pleads for her life. But she also says that there is no reason here. There is no logic here. She says she didn't give the handkerchief to Cassio. She pleads with him to just call for Cassio and clear the matter up. But so trusting is Othello of Iago that he won't even consider it. He's in a state of mania.

7.82 Now, do you remember, in the second lecture in this series, I mentioned Titus Andronicus? I mentioned the moment when the ravaged Lavinia, with her hands cut off and her tongue cut out, enters on the stage, and Marcus, her uncle, is there. And all of the stage directions for how Lavinia reacts and moves are embedded within the text that Marcus says. The same technique happens here. Desdemona looks at Othello and says, "I fear you, for you're fatal then when your eyes roll so." And then later, "Why gnaw you so your nether lip? Some bloody passion shakes your very frame." Othello has lost control. This is manifesting physically, and all of that is within the words that she says. He won't listen to reason at this point. He tells her that Cassio is dead. He doesn't realize that Cassio is not dead, but that is what Iago has led him to believe. Desdemona weeps, and Othello interprets that weeping as that she is weeping for her lost lover. He cannot be—anything she does at this point will not help.

7.83 He says, "Out, strumpet! Weep'st thou for him to my face?" It makes him more angry. Desdemona says, "O, banish me, my lord, but kill me not." Othello: "Down, strumpet." Desdemona: "Kill me tomorrow; let me live tonight." Othello: "Nay, and you strive—". Desdemona: "But half an hour." And Othello: "Being done, there is no pause." Then

Desdemona asks, "But while I say one prayer." She wants to say her prayers before she dies. Othello just says, "It is too late," and he smothers her with the pillow. This innocent person is killed. She doesn't die immediately. She dies after Amelia comes in, pulls back the fabric from the frame of the bed chamber, and sees her lady dying, and asks who did this. Desdemona won't even blame her husband, even then.

7.84 Now, of course, it goes without saying that we are right to be critical of Othello's murder of Desdemona. It's absolutely horrific. But is he a fool? So, the evidence has mounted up. Iago has created the conditions, the evidence. You've had Iago's trick with Cassio earlier in the play where Othello is overhearing, and Othello thinks he hears Cassio boasting about having sex with Desdemona. Of course, we know he's actually talking about the prostitute Bianca, right? We've got the handkerchief, so this significant love token, which Iago says he's seen in the possession of Cassio. Cassio has wiped his beard with this handkerchief, apparently. We have the various suspicions of Iago. Most of this is coming from Iago, right? And remember, Iago is "honest Iago." That's what they call him. There's no reason for Othello not to trust him. Why would he lie?

7.85 There's that dreaming moment. We talked about Cassio dreaming about having sex with Desdemona. And through all of this deception that we see, the play finally comes back to one simple question. Why? Why? Why does any of this have to happen? But for all of our suppositions, the truth is we will never know why Iago does what he does. I don't think we're meant to know. The very fact that so many actors and directors have invented various reasons for this behavior tells us that it is ultimately inexplicable. By the end, we are asking that question, "Why?" We need to know. We can't leave until we know why this has happened, but Shakespeare won't tell us.

7.86 I mean, human behavior is often inexplicable. Why should he tell us? But the question is still in our heads, and Othello asks the question for us, OK? Othello says, "Will you, I pray, demand that demi-devil why he hath thus ensnared my soul and body?" Soul and body is right, isn't it? Because Othello now, knowing the full truth, he's going to kill himself, but he's also killed his innocent wife, and therefore, he has condemned himself to hell. Iago has condemned his soul and his body, and Othello needs to know why. He must know why. He needs to understand more than anything. He says this not to Iago. He cannot talk to Iago. He cannot look him in the eye. He says it to Cassio. He says, "Will you, I pray, demand that demi-devil why he hath thus ensnared my soul and body?"

7.87 Iago's reply is surely one of the most haunting lines in all literature. He says, "Demand me nothing. What you know, you know." And we're left with that. Now, Iago is going to be tortured, but he vows never to speak again, and he never does speak again. "What you know, you know." You have to be happy with that. How can we be? We're left with no clarity, with no understanding of why this evil exists at all. I don't think we will ever understand Iago's motives. I don't think he understands them himself. Maybe this is all

he can do. Maybe we have to accept the terrible truth that there is an aspect of human nature that simply wants to watch the world burn.

7.88 Thank you very much. Does anyone have any questions about Othello, or given that it's the last lecture of the series, any broader questions about Shakespeare?

7.89 I was just wondering what you thought the role of mental illness or madness has in Shakespeare's plays.

7.90 Yes, mental illness and madness is something that recurs throughout Shakespeare. I think in Hamlet, in particular, it's very, very prominent. Of course, he's drawing on the original source material where madness is very much a part of the Amleth story, but he uses it in very interesting ways. I think in both Hamlet and also in King Lear, where he introduces the madness element, there is a sense in which Shakespeare believes that madness enables us to become truth-tellers, that it sort of removes the shackles of societal obligation so that we can start speaking freely or at least exploring ideas in a very free way. He keeps coming back to the idea of madness, almost like a dramatic conceit.

7.91 What he has to say about it, I'm not so sure. He could be talking about the outsider, generally. The fool in Lear speaks like a madman and is the only one that tells the truth. Maybe there's something in that. In Titus Andronicus, Titus first goes mad and then feigns madness to kidnap Chiron and Demetrius. So it's often used as an element of the plot line, a means of disguise, I suppose, but sometimes it's authentic. What you find is that when you get the authentic madness, they move through some kind of cathartic process so that they emerge on the other side in a more pure way.

7.92 I don't think madness or mental illness was particularly well understood at the time. I think the figure of Tom O'Bedlam—you'll have heard of that phrase. Bedlam, of course, is the place where lunatics, as they were called, were accommodated. Poor Tom in King Lear is a reference to Tom O'Bedlam. These people were just known to be out in society, in the community. You would see them here and there. That's why he dresses like this scrawny beggar, and that's why they refer to him as Poor Tom. It's like a stock figure. But these are people that weren't cared for often. This was a society where you would see mad people on the streets. There was no welfare state. This isn't something that anyone could help.

7.93 But it means that it was a very interesting topic, I think, for Shakespeare and for writers of the time, and something that they would have been very fearful of, the idea that someone can lose their wits in that way. I suppose Othello even experiences a kind of madness. I mean, he has a fit, and then he loses control entirely. I think it's a kind of insanity that's happening there. So yes, I think it's something that's feared. I think it's something that can be a plot device. But I think it's also a means by which Shakespeare can find a way to interrogate the human soul and to isolate us, as it were, from the expectations of custom and culture.

- 7.94 I was just wondering, throughout these lectures, you've emphasized a few themes such as, obviously, revenge and gratitude, jealousy, passion versus reason, and populism. I was just wondering if you deliberately chose those because of the times we were in, or if it was just another testament to Shakespeare's artistry and his understanding of humanity.
- 7.95 I suppose I'm tending to read Shakespeare through the concerns of today's age. I think that's natural. I'll be honest, I haven't given that much thought. I think I've just naturally gravitated towards trying to associate things that we are living through with these plays. I think one of the reasons for that is that, as I said, a lot of people are quite, well, they balk at the suggestion that Shakespeare is timeless or universal. I'm quite keen to show that these plays are completely relevant today, not because I'm trying to shoehorn topics in that aren't necessarily related, but it naturally occurs to me. When I read these, reread these plays recently, lots of things occurred to me that wouldn't have occurred to me 20 years ago because we're living in a different cultural climate at the moment.
- 7.96 I do think that Shakespeare has the capacity to illuminate our modern world, to illuminate a lot of the things that we are going through, because as I say, I don't think human nature really changes, and I don't think there's anything really new in the world. We're talking about political tribalism a lot at the moment. We're talking about the way in which populism is on the rise, and people are very concerned about this. This has happened a million times over. So I think I adhere to the idea of the universality of Shakespeare, however unfashionable that might be, and therefore, I am keen to show how he is still relevant.
- 7.97 If someone wants to study this by themselves, but they have not really encountered much of it, where should they start and why?
- 7.98 If they have not studied it themselves—well, I'm all for self-education, I think. The best starting point, I think, is the texts themselves. I think what people who have had no experience of Shakespeare whatsoever, the best thing to do is get a good text of Shakespeare, one that is well annotated. What I would do, actually, is I would avoid the most recent editions of Shakespeare, the ones published over the last 15, 20 years. I would avoid them because the introductions and the notes tend to be quite politicized. I would go for something that was published, I'd say, between the 1970s and the 1990s. I think that's the sweet spot, where they have very good notes, and the academics of the time aren't so ideologically in lockstep. They're more interested in the text. I might be—I'm probably generalizing horribly. I mean, there are some very talented academics working today, but there is a preponderance, I would say, of literary critics who are more interested in ideology than anything else. I think that's the sweet spot.
- 7.99 Get a good copy of the plays. Read them one play at a time. Any terms that you don't know, just check the glossary; see what the term means. A lot of the really good editions have the glossary on the same page, so it's very easy to do that. Also, I would

say, don't worry about the language difference. Don't worry about understanding everything. Think of these plays as poems. A poem is not a riddle to be solved. You don't read a poem and understand everything that is being said. Some of the best poems, you won't understand a lot of what is being said. If you think of *Kubla Khan*, for instance. But you get the gist; you get the imagery. Certain things strike you. I mean, if you read James Joyce's book, *Ulysses*, I think you'll probably get, if you're lucky, 10% of what he's going on about. But you'll catch certain allusions and you'll miss others, but it doesn't matter because you still get an incredibly wonderful human and individual experience. So don't get bogged down or fearful in the idea that you need to understand absolutely everything that Shakespeare is saying, that you need to chase up every single allusion.

- 7.100** Understand that you will read these plays many, many times and you will still learn more and more things about them. They're incredibly layered. So I think that's the best way. Get a good copy, read the book, and the more you read of Shakespeare, the more he will become accessible to you. The language just becomes natural to you. When you first approach Shakespeare, it feels like a foreign language. When you've read two or three plays, it doesn't anymore. Your brain locks in. It's a very interesting thing. You get the same thing. A good example of this is, do you know a novel called *A Clockwork Orange* by Anthony Burgess? He invented his own lingo for the Droogs, the characters in that. As you read it, for the first 20 pages, you haven't got a clue what they're talking about. I promise you, by the time you've got to the end of that novel, you can speak the language. You know everything they're saying. It's an incredible thing that he does.
- 7.101** I think the same is true of Shakespeare. It's about familiarity. One of my worries is that we don't really teach Shakespeare enough to people young enough. I think we think that people in primary school or early secondary school won't get it. I think that's completely wrong. I think if you just raise the bar quite high, kids will go up to that bar. I think I was failed by education. I wasn't taught enough of this stuff. I had a couple of really great teachers who did do some excellent work on Shakespeare, but I could have had more. I could have done with more. I think teaching yourself—don't be afraid of teaching yourself, I suppose, is the bottom line.
- 7.102** I was just going to ask, do you recommend reading out loud when you're reading Shakespeare at home or in your head, or does it not really matter?
- 7.103** Oh, absolutely. It depends if you live alone. I think, though, reading out loud is always good because you will really pick up on the rhythms and the cadence. All of the stuff I've been talking about—the shift from prose to verse and back again, or the way in which he messes around with meter deliberately—all of that becomes very clear when you read something aloud. So yeah, I would absolutely recommend that you do that. One of the things some friends of mine did at university is when they had to cover a Shakespeare play, because they didn't like it much, they would get a group of people around to read the whole thing out. So in other words, people would play different

roles, and you would get through it that way and then have a discussion, and then it would go into your mind. That's another good way of doing it. But yes, absolutely. I think reading aloud is a great thing to do.

- 7.104** What has it done for you to be familiar with such texts?
- 7.105** What has it done for me? Well, it's difficult to know because I don't know what person I would be if I had never read Shakespeare. I imagine a less interesting person. I'm not suggesting, arrogantly, that I am particularly interesting, but I think certainly I must be more interesting than I would have been if I hadn't been educated in literature, because I think reading great literature inevitably improves you as an individual. I think it makes you a better person, actually. I think there's a moral dimension to it, although I don't think that art or literature have to be in themselves moral. I think they tend to have that effect.
- 7.106** I think they open you up to a huge range of different experiences. It's like someone who never travels. They don't really understand humanity. They understand their own narrow little corner of humanity, and that's not interesting to me. I think you stifle yourself. I think it's better to be intellectually curious, and the best way to satisfy that intellectual curiosity is through reading the very best literature that there is. Remember, our time is finite. We've got to pick and choose. There's a lot of dross out there. There's a lot of bad books. Be selective.
- 7.107** Remember that there is a canon of English literature for a reason, not because some high and mighty academics decided we should study this and we should study that, although that's what they're starting to do now. The canon forms because artists are influenced by other great artists. The more that a writer is imitated, the better that writer normally is. There's a reason why Shakespeare has survived. It's not because of fashion; it's not because of academics. It's because he wrote plays that nobody else could write. For that reason alone, I would suggest that he does make us better, and we have almost an obligation to read him.
- 7.108** So throughout these lectures, it's become very clear that Shakespeare had an insight into the human nature, both the good and the bad, which is perhaps what makes him unique and so relatable and timeless, as you said. I wonder if you could crystallize the soul of Shakespeare in work, what makes his work superior. What would those elements be that perhaps modern writers or aspiring writers could meditate on or practice in their writing to hopefully increase their chances of bettering their work?
- 7.109** I think you're asking, "Why is Shakespeare such a genius?", which is a impossible question to answer. In terms of aspiration, I suppose what you should be doing as an aspiring writer —there's a lot to learn from Shakespeare. The way he innovates with language, the way he changes the meaning of words. We have many, many phrases that come directly from Shakespeare, and we don't know that we're speaking Shakespearean because he was an innovator. He wasn't satisfied with how things were.

He was able to develop his craft. Partly, I think it's because he had a fealty to his own vision. One of the things where I think artists and writers fall down on is that they are trying to please. There's a lot of that. Sometimes they have to. I've said before, publishing houses won't publish you if you don't follow a certain set of rules.

- 7.110** But actually, the best work comes when a writer can pursue their own vision, uninterrupted, unimpeded. I think the key of all the things you could say about Shakespeare, the key thing that I would say is, don't compromise on what you want to say—because he doesn't. He doesn't compromise. He writes the plays he wants to write. He surprises you, shocks you, disappoints you. He does all of that because he wants to produce the art that he wants to produce. I think that's what all artists should try and do.
- 7.111** Thank you. I've got a question. Did Shakespeare genuinely author his works, or was he merely copying others?
- 7.112** This is a question that gets asked a lot. OK, I'm going to be really, really clear about this. Yes, Shakespeare wrote his own works. That is unequivocal. There is no debate to be had there. I would explain why. OK, so the thing is, there are a lot of conspiracy theorists. There are a lot of people who say Shakespeare couldn't have written all these works. How could one man have written this incredible body of work? So they often say there's collaborations. Remember, there were collaborations. A few of the later plays are co-written with John Fletcher, for instance. He may have collaborated with people like Thomas Middleton or possibly George Peele. There are elements of collaboration at this time, but no, Shakespeare did write these plays, the plays that he is credited for.
- 7.113** They were published in quarto editions throughout his lifetime and attributed to William Shakespeare. They were entered into the Stationers' Register at the time, attributed to William Shakespeare. We have legal documents talking about the William Shakespeare from Stratford-upon-Avon, the playwright. We have quite a lot of documents, actually, about his life, his baptism, his death. These things do exist. There was a man from Stratford-upon-Avon called William Shakespeare who wrote plays, and all of these plays that we've been discussing were attributed to him during his lifetime. Then when he died, you had the First Folio where many, many of his colleagues and friends wrote these glowing tributes to him, which were then published in the First Folio.
- 7.114** Now, the question you have to ask is, if Shakespeare did not write these plays, why is it that not a single contemporary of Shakespeare claimed that he didn't? Not one, not even Ben Jonson, who would have taken that chance to say, "There's a rumor going around that Shakespeare wasn't even writing what he wrote." Of course, he would have said it. It is completely unfeasible, completely unfeasible, that Shakespeare didn't write these plays. But people want to believe it. I think people love conspiracy theories. I think, particularly when you have the most important creative minds in the world, you want to have a go at that. You want to bring that down. It makes sense to me.

- 7.115** But really, I think what's at the heart of it is pure class snobbery. Shakespeare was middle-class . Shakespeare didn't go to university. He wasn't an aristocrat. He wanted to be. He spent a lot of his life trying to become a gentleman, trying to get a coat of arms. He did succeed, by the way. His father had tried and failed. Shakespeare did succeed in that. So status did matter to him, but he wasn't high-born. Look at the candidates that people put for the authorship of Shakespeare. The Oxford, the Earl of Oxford, for goodness' sake. Some people say Christopher Marlowe wrote all of them. Christopher Marlowe was stabbed in the head in 1593. How does that work? They say he faked his own death and carried—I mean, these are absurd, absurd ideas.
- 7.116** It is perfectly possible that someone from a middle-class background from Stratford-upon-Avon, who had a grammar school education, had all of the basis that he needed to write these plays, had all the basis that he needed to read more to write further plays. The university education is not a factor. How could he write about lords and ladies if he wasn't an aristocrat? Because he had an imagination, because he was a genius, because we don't always write about—we don't always write autobiographies, for heaven's sake. So what I would say is, it's an absolute dead-end. Anyone who tells you that Shakespeare didn't write Shakespeare's works simply does not know what they are talking about.
- 7.117** So, I just want to thank you all for coming along to attend these lectures. I've really appreciated your input and the discussions we've had, and I hope that you got a lot out of it.